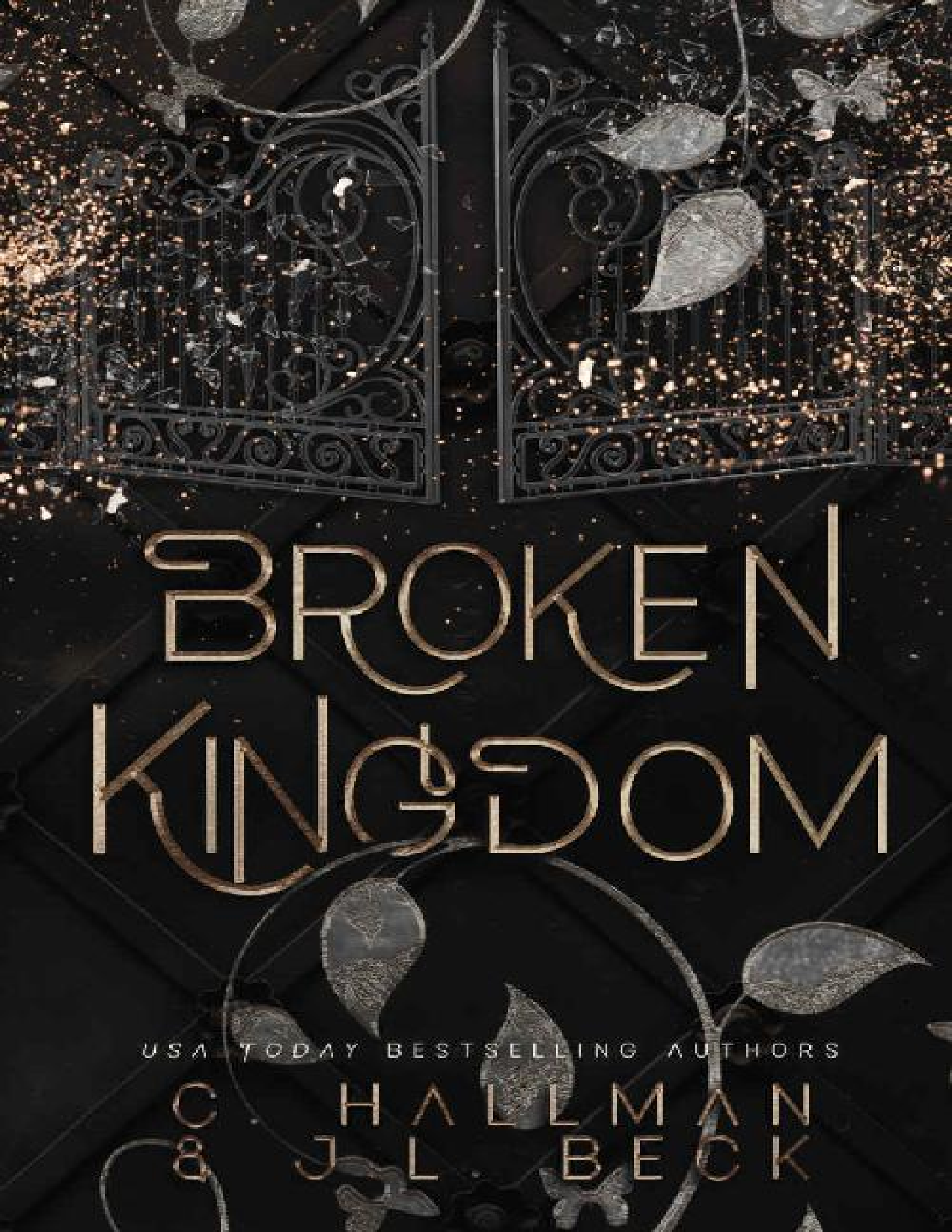
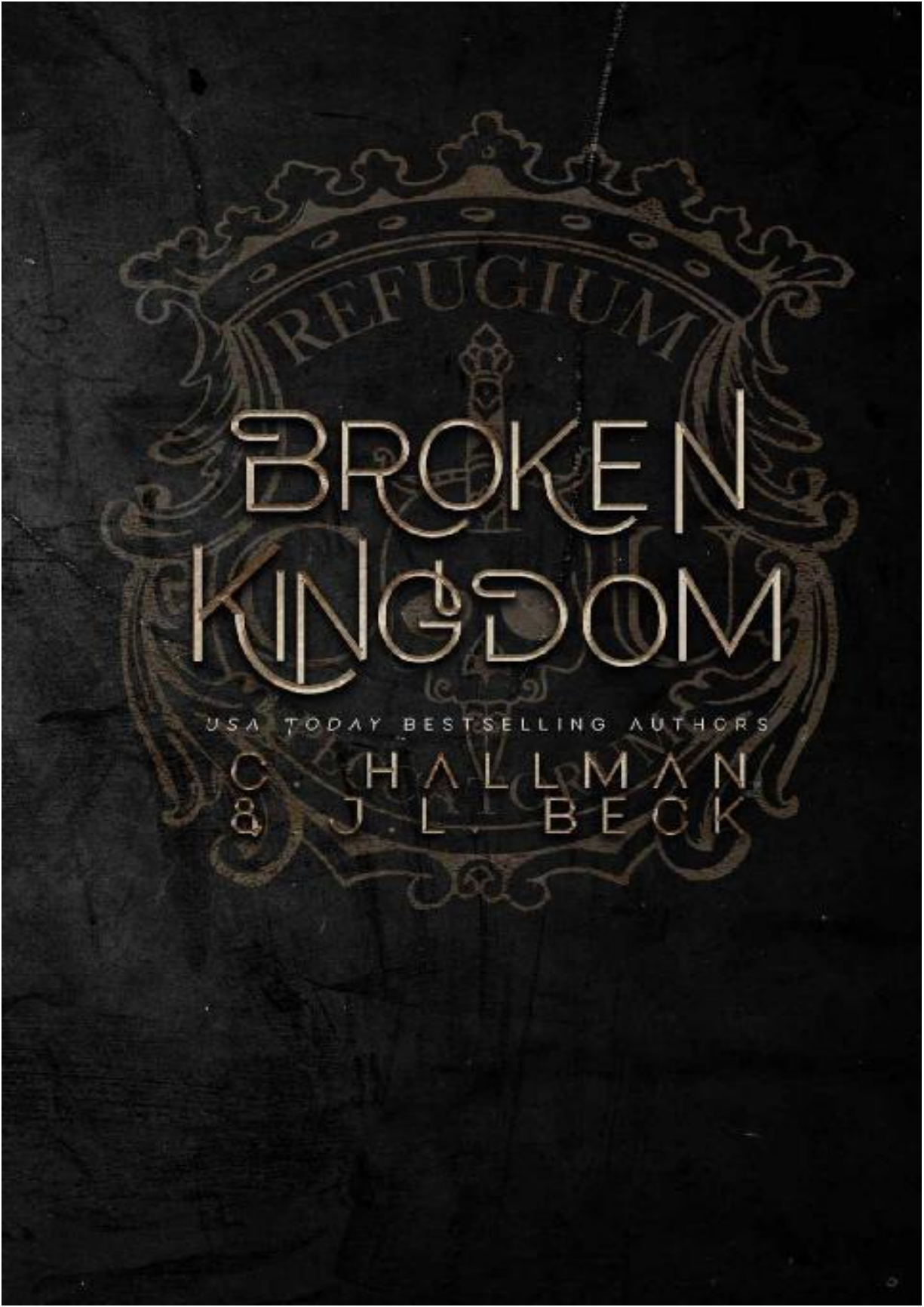




BROKEN KINGDOM

USA TODAY BESTSELLING AUTHORS

C. HALLMAN
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REFUGIUM

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ASPEN

For a while, there is nothing but pain. So much pain, I can't even pinpoint where it's coming from. Where am I hurt? My head, my leg, or my stomach? Everything?

I must have been hit by a bus. Any minute now, I'll wake up in some hospital, my parents standing beside my bed, worrying and waiting for me to open my eyes.

The smell of rubbing alcohol is thick in the air, adding to my hospital theory. The only thing missing is the sound of a heart-rate monitor beeping in the background.

I strain my ears, trying to make out any other sound, but there is nothing for a long time. When I finally do hear the creaking of a door, I try to pry my eyes open, but they feel like someone glued them shut.

"She looks like she's in pain," a deep raspy voice says. The man's voice sounds somewhat familiar, but I can't match it to a face at the moment.

"I haven't given her any pain medicine yet. I just got the toxicology report back. I had to know what kind of drug she was on first," another man explains. I don't think I know this guy at all. At least his voice sounds completely foreign to me.

Someone touches my arm, and my body jolts, sending ripples of pain across my skin.

“Give her the pain meds already. I don’t want her like this when my son gets back.” The voice is closer now as if he is standing right next to me. I’m certain I know this man, but I can’t figure out who it is.

I give opening my eyes another try, forcing my heavy eyelids to open just a tiny bit. It takes a lot of energy, but I am finally able to get my eyelids to move.

At first, I can’t see anything but bright light. After I blink a few times, my blurry vision slowly adjusting, I’m able to make out two men. Both stand beside my bed, and just like I thought, I don’t know one of them. The other, however, I know very well. Xander Rossi.

My first instinct is to be scared, to scramble off the bed and get away from him, but one look at his face has me pausing to reevaluate the whole situation.

Every interaction I’ve had so far with Xander has been hostile. Even when he wasn’t openly threatening me, he always had a grim, I-will-kill-you glint in his eyes. Not today. Today, his eyes are soft, creases of concern are edged into his forehead, and his lips are pulled into a frown. Today, he looks... tired.

“Don’t try to get up. Just relax and let the medicine work,” the unknown man says. “This should take care of the pain. You will be much more comfortable soon.”

I watch him attach something to the IV drip standing next to my bed. It takes me another moment to realize that IV is attached to my arm. My gaze wanders from the clear tube sticking out of my arm to the bruised skin around my wrist.

What happened? Why am I here, and where even is *here*?

The man, who I think is a doctor, steps away, but Xander remains by my side. “I normally don’t let people I do not trust enter my home. This is my sanctuary, Aspen, the one place I can let my guard down and be with my family in peace. I don’t like you being here at all, but given the special circumstances, I’m allowing you to stay. This will be your sanctuary, too,

while you recover. No one will harm you while you are inside these walls. Do not make me regret this kindness.”

I open my mouth to ask him why I’m here, but my throat is so dry it only makes me cough. The sudden movement has pain exploding through my chest and abdomen. My eyes squeeze shut as tears roll down my cheeks. I try to curl up, wanting to hold my torso as if that could fix me, but my arms are so heavy.

As if this day couldn’t get any weirder, when I open my eyes again, Xander is holding out a glass of water in front of my lips. Sliding his hand under my neck, he lifts my head carefully so I can drink. I take a greedy sip, letting the cold liquid soothe my burning throat.

With the same gentle touch, he lays my head back and sets the glass on the nightstand. Just as I let myself sink back into the soft pillow, I can feel the medicine spreading through my veins. Slowly, the pain fades away, and a warm and fuzzy feeling takes its place.

“Get some rest,” Xander instructs before turning around to leave.

Suddenly, I’m scared. Scared to be alone, and I don’t know why. “Wait,” I croak, making him stop to look at me over his shoulder. “I-I don’t... I mean, I—” I stumble over the words. How do I tell him that I don’t want to be alone?

It doesn’t make any sense, and no matter how crazy it sounds in my head, I would rather have Xander Rossi here with me than be by myself. I’m pretty sure he wants me dead, yet I feel safe with him for some reason. Maybe safe isn’t the right word... less afraid might be better.

Walking back to the bed, he pulls up a chair and sits down next to me. “I already told you, no one will harm you here. You are completely safe within these walls. I’ll stay until Quinton gets here, but remember... don’t make me regret this.”

I won’t. I want to say it out loud, but my tongue feels heavy, just like the rest of my body. My eyes flutter closed, and I’m pulled back into darkness, only this time there is no pain.

I have no idea how long I'm out—could be minutes or hours—all I know is that when I open my eyes next, it's nighttime. The room is mostly dark, the only light coming from a dim lamp sitting on the nightstand. My eyes focus on a picture frame next to it. It's an image of Quinton with Adela and Scarlet. They look so... happy.

I stare at the picture for a minute before I start to wonder again how I ended up here. This must be Quinton's room. I'm in his bed, hurt, but I don't know why.

My mind is hazy, and I can't recall any memories of what happened. The last thing I remember is being at Corium... hanging out with Brittney... seeing Anja in the elevator. After that, everything starts to get confusing. An image of Lucas kicking in a door pops into my head, then I suddenly remember getting on a helicopter. Was I in a crash again?

I feel like I'm at a beach, and all my memories lie beneath the sand. I'm trying desperately to uncover them with my hand, but every time I reach one, another wave crashes onto the shore, adding more sand and washing away the work I've done.

Confused and desperate for answers, I groan in frustration. That's when I catch some movement in the dark corner of the room. I freeze, panic clawing its way up my spine as I realize I'm not alone.

Squinting my eyes, I try to make out the ominous figure across the room. The outline of a tall man with broad shoulders comes into view as he takes two steps toward me. I want to sit up so I'm less vulnerable, but fear has me paralyzed, holding me prisoner in my own body.

He takes two more strides before he steps out of the shadow, and the light reveals his face.

Quinton.

I relax. Sinking back into the mattress, I exhale a breath I didn't know I was holding. Quinton stops beside the bed, looking over me before sinking down to his knees.

Now that he is close, I can see how pale he is. Dark circles paint the skin below his eyes. His lips are chapped, his face unshaven, and his hair is

unkempt.

“I’m so sorry, Aspen.” His low and raspy voice sounds just as tired as he looks.

“I don’t understand,” I whisper because that’s all I can manage. “What happened?”

“You had to leave Corium because of a gas leak. Do you remember that?”

Gas leak? Memories of waking up in the middle of the night pop into my head. Anja and I trapped, Lucas coming for us.

“Lucas took you home.” As Quinton keeps explaining, more memories resurface. The helicopter, the rental car, getting home, then...

“Matteo took you from your house...” My mind goes blank. As if someone has taken a spoon and scooped out all those memories from my brain. “He hurt you, Aspen. He hurt you bad.”

I remember waking up and being in pain before, but as I’m mentally checking where I’m hurting now, all I can feel is a dull ache in my lower abdomen. Only when I move my legs and try to scoot up a little does a more profound pain between my legs appear.

No. My eyes widen in terror. It can’t be... but one look at Quinton tells me all I need to know. Matteo took me; he raped me.

“I’m gonna make him pay for what he did. I’m going to get revenge for you and the baby.”

“Baby?”

“Did you know you were pregnant?”

Dumbfounded, I stare at him, now more confused than ever. By the time my brain has processed the words baby and pregnant, I’m faced with the unmistakable past tense of the sentence.

“I was...”

“Yes, and you lost it because of him,” Quinton grits through his teeth. For a long time, I was under the impression Quinton hated me, and maybe a part

of him did, but nothing compares to the deep-rooted hatred in his voice now.

“I will find him, and I will make him suffer,” he promises me with a sinister glint in his eyes that makes my skin crawl. “I swear it, Aspen. I will get revenge, no matter the cost.”

I believe him, but now I’m worried what that cost will be, and if I lose Quinton in the process, I know I won’t survive.

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QUINTON

I wait until Aspen falls back to sleep before I find my father in his office. Uncle Damon, Roman, and Ren are here as well, ready to talk about what happened and what we're going to do.

"Quinton, sit down," my father orders, and I'm too tired to fight him on it. I take the seat across from his desk.

"We have to find him before he goes back to Corium. I can't kill him there."

"Quinton, I know you want revenge, but you can't just kill Matteo—"

"I can, and I will!"

"It's not a smart move. His entire family is going to come after us."

"I don't care. Let them come."

"You let your anger cloud your judgment." A part of me knows he's right, but an even bigger part doesn't give a shit. I don't care if I start a war. Matteo will die.

"Why did you have everyone come then? Just so they can watch you tell me no?"

"If you calm down and listen for a moment, I will tell you."

"Fine, I'm listening."

“You can’t just openly kill Matteo. His family will retaliate, and a lot of our people won’t like defending us when they find out why we killed him.”

“So, what? We make it look like an accident?”

My father shakes his head. “The Valentines are assholes, but they are not stupid. They would still come after us.”

“Then what?” I ask impatiently.

“I have something to hold above Dick Valentine’s head. Something so bad that he might be willing to give us his son in return.” That piques my interest.

“Now we’re talking.”

“That’s why they’re here.” Dad nods past me. “Roman and Ren are coming with us. Damon is going to stay here while we are gone. Luke is going to meet us on the way and shadow us as we go in.”

“Okay.” I’m glad to have Luke as backup. Not only is he one of the best hitmen I know, but he is also Ren’s uncle and one of our closest friends. “Can we leave now?”

“We’re ready when you are.” Roman moves beside me, his hand landing on my shoulder. “Let’s go kill the fucker.”

“Looking forward to it.”

My father gets up from his desk and walks to his wall-to-wall bookshelf. He uses the small pin pad on the side to open a hidden cabinet behind the shelves. An array of guns, knives, ammunition, and other fun little toys come into view. Pulling out a drawer on the bottom, my father grabs some bulletproof vests and hands me one.

“If everything goes as planned, we won’t need any of this, but you can never be too prepared. Put this under your clothes and pick some holsters and at least two guns,” he orders, and for once, I gladly follow his command.

Roman, Ren, and my father do the same. After we are all armed to the teeth, my father closes his small armory, and we head downstairs.

The drive to the Valentines' estate goes by in a blur since my mind is already conjuring up all the different ways I'm going to kill Matteo. Right now, that's the only thing keeping me sane. I just hope my father doesn't expect me to walk away if blackmailing Valentine Senior doesn't work.

"We're here," Dad announces as he pulls into the long driveway leading to a lavish house. "Remember, let me do the talking." He doesn't say my name, but everyone in the car knows he's addressing me.

"I can't make any promises."

I exit the car as soon as we stop. Everyone else follows closely. I wait until we are piled up at the door before I ring the doorbell.

A moment later, the heavy wooden door opens, and a young woman in a maid's outfit that looks two sizes too small on her appears. "Hello," she greets so quietly I almost miss it. "C-Can I help y-you?"

"We're here to see Dick."

"Okay..." She nods her head and opens the door further. The skirt is so short, she might as well wear nothing, and the blouse is so tight, the buttons look like they are about to pop open. Hesitantly, she steps away and waves us in. "Please wait here. I'll let Master know you're here."

"Did she just say *master*?" Ren questions when she is out of earshot.

"Apparently, Matteo's whole family consists of weirdos," Roman says.

"You have no idea," my father agrees, making me wonder what dirt he has on Valentine.

My eyes snap up when Dick enters the room a moment later. He has the same build and facial structure as Matteo, but his hair is thinning, and his stomach is bulging out like he's had one too many beers.

"Xander, old friend. I didn't expect a visit from you and... your son." He addresses us first, ignoring Ren and Roman, which is funny since Roman is well over six feet tall and built like a brick house. Someone not taking notice of him seems ridiculous.

“I wanted to discuss a matter that’s better handled in person. Quinton, my friend, Roman, and his son, Ren, happened to be with me when we decided to stop by.” My father’s lie rolls off his tongue smoothly.

“Of course.” Valentine smiles. “Let’s sit and have a drink, catch up.” He motions for us to follow him to the sitting room. I don’t particularly want to sit down, but as my father has explained many times, it’s better to play the game. I disagree. Why put up this fake front? No one is trying to win an Oscar for best actor.

“Can I offer you a drink? Whiskey?” Valentine asks, taking a seat on one of the large leather chairs. Ren and I sit down on one of the sofas while Roman and my dad sit on another.

“No, I’d rather get straight to the point,” my father answers. “Your son, Matteo. I want him dead.”

Valentine leans back in his chair. If he’s shocked, he doesn’t give anything away. “Is that so? What did he do to piss you off?”

“He hurt someone who is under our protection.”

“What? He wouldn’t do that. Who is that supposed person?”

“Aspen Mather.”

This time, Valentine’s eyes widen in surprise. “Her? You never announced she was, and why would she be? How should my son have known that?”

“He fucking knew!” I growl, earning a warning glare from my dad.

“It doesn’t matter. What matters is that you will hand over your son.”

“Fuck, I will. This is a bullshit accusation, and you know it.”

“You know what else I know? I know you like to dress up as a little girl and get your ass fucked by some well-hung black guy. What was his name again? Bernard?”

I almost choke on my own spit. *The fuck?* I think my father is bluffing for a split second, making up some rumor to spread, but when I see Valentine turning pale, I realize this has to be true.

“How... how do you know about that?” He hasn’t even finished his questions when my father pulls out his phone and plays a video recording.

“Squeal for me, little piggy...” A man’s voice with a French accent fills the room. *“Let me hear how much you like getting your ass rimmed by my fat cock.”*

“Turn that off!” Valentine gets up from his seat, puffing his chest as he reaches for my father’s phone. Of course, Dad is faster and easily evades his hand.

Casually, my father stuffs his phone back into his pocket and looks up at Valentine, completely unfazed. “I want Matteo, or this video will be released.”

“Are you asking me to sacrifice my son to save myself from being publicly humiliated?”

“Yes, and we both know that you are that kind of man. Just imagine the way your men would look at you. How your peers would laugh at you. How much power you would lose—”

“All right, all right, I got it. I’ll tell you where Matteo is.”

“No, you are going to have him come here. We’re not leaving without him.”

“He is not stupid; he won’t come here now. He probably already knows you’re here.” Dick pulls out a handkerchief from his pocket and pads his sweaty forehead.

“Not my problem. Get him here.”

“Look, how about as a gesture of goodwill, I’ll make sure the video of the Mather girl is destroyed.”

“Video?” my father asks. “From the other night?”

“Yes.” Valentine nods and clears his throat. He looks beyond flustered, his eyes scanning the room as if he is trying to come up with an escape plan. “My idiot sons took a video, but I’ll make sure it never gets out.”

“Did you just say sons, as in plural?” I grit through my teeth, ready to rip someone’s throat out. Valentine knows he’s fucked up. His face goes from pale to white, and thick beads of sweat form on his forehead.

“Fuck,” Valentine curses. “I mean, he was there, but I don’t think he touched her.”

“I want to see the video,” I demand. Getting up from where I’m sitting, I take a step toward Matteo’s father. He instantly takes a step back. “Now!”

“I don’t have it, but I’ll get it—” I don’t let him finish the sentence. I close the distance between us and wrap my hand around his throat, slamming his body backward onto the coffee table.

“Give me your fucking phone!”

He shakes his head and opens his mouth, but no words come out, only a pained wheeze. His eyes flicker to somewhere in the room, probably to my father, hoping he’ll hold me back.

He slams his fist into my ribs a few times, but his punches are so weak I barely feel them. His other hand claws at my arm, but even the deep scratches on my skin hardly register.

Only when he is turning blue, and his eyes start bulging out of his sockets does he reach into his back pocket and pull out his phone.

“Unlock it,” I order, and watch him do so with trembling fingers. The screen lights up, and I release my hold on his throat.

Valentine slumps to his knees, gasping for air, and I snatch the phone from his fingers.

“Why don’t you let me look,” my father offers. “I don’t think you watching this is a good idea.”

I consider it for a split second but decide I need to do this. “I want to know who was there. I have to see this for myself.”

“Quinton...” Ren starts, but I wave him off and pull up the saved videos from Valentine’s phone.

There are three of them. The first one is paused on Aspen's face. Her eyes are closed, her features pulled into a pained expression. Gripping the phone tight enough to snap it in half, I press play.

"Fuck, Aspen... no wonder Quinton kept this pussy all to himself," Matteo grunts, pulling her head back by her hair.

The camera zooms out and shows Aspen completely naked, her hands cuffed to something above her head. Matteo is behind her, holding her hips while he fucks her. Someone else is there, standing next to him and watching the whole thing with a grin on his face.

I know Matteo's brother, Rico, and this is not him. I don't know who that man is, but I will find out. He is living on borrowed time.

"Rico, you want a turn?" Matteo calls for his brother, and a moment later, he appears in the frame.

"Fuck yeah. I thought you would never ask." Rico chuckles and flicks open the button of his jeans. *"I want her ass, though..."*

I pause the video, unable to stomach more of this right now. I send the videos to myself before putting Valentine's phone into my pocket. He is still on the ground with his back propped up against the sofa I was sitting on earlier.

"Who was the other guy in the videos?" I question Valentine.

"I have no idea." He shrugs, but I can smell the lie from a mile away. "I don't keep track of my son's friends." I glance over at my father, needing some reassurance that he'll have my back if I take this any further.

Dad gives me a slight nod, and that's all I need.

"What the fuck is going on here?" A voice booms through the room. I turn my head to where it's coming from and smile when I see who it is. *Rico.*

I don't think I've ever moved so fast in my life. I'm across the room, slamming into Rico's chest before he knows what hit him. I tackle him down to the ground and get on top of him. He fights me, even getting a few punches in, but nothing compares to the anger-infused strength I possess at

the moment. I subdue him with ease, raining down punches until he stops fighting at all.

I'm vaguely aware of people screaming around me, then a gunshot being fired, but none of that makes me stop. I keep pounding my fists into his face until I'm certain I've broken every bone in it.

My hands are covered in blood, and Rico's face is unrecognizable, but I still can't stop. Someone grabs me from behind, pulling me away from Rico's lifeless body. I start fighting, twisting my body to kill whoever is attacking me, but there are not only two hands holding me down, there are four.

"It's okay, Quinton." My father's voice calms me instantly. "He is dead."

I relax slightly, but Dad and Roman still keep their hands on me, almost like they are afraid I'll lose it again.

"I'm fine," I say, but it's another few moments before they let me go, and I can finally turn around.

My eyes are immediately drawn to Dick Valentine, who is slumped to the ground with a bullet hole between his vacant eyes. Behind his lifeless body is his young maid, her body shaking like a leaf. Ren is standing next to her, his hand wrapped around her upper arm.

"You killed him?" I turn toward my father. "What happened to we can't just go around offing people without a reason?"

"I guess we have to move to plan B," my father announces. "We're killing everyone. The whole Valentine family."

Fuck yes.

ASPEN

*A*s the last rays of sun breach the heavy curtains, I realize how large Quinton's room really is. His king-sized bed is pushed against the wall, and you could easily fit three more beds between here and the large double window.

His room is sparsely decorated, but the few pictures he has in here are him with his sisters. It's odd being here, especially without him. Even more odd is how Xander is okay with me staying here.

The doctor and nurse have been in and out of my room all day, making sure I'm comfortable and not in any pain. I haven't seen Quinton since he left, but being in his room, surrounded by his things, makes me feel close to him.

Thanks to the heavy medication I am on, I sleep more than my eyes are open, but I've been awake for at least an hour now. I'm doing nothing besides lying here and looking at the ceiling. Surprisingly, I'm not bored. I'm not scared or worried. Right now, I'm nothing. I'm simply... here. I'm not sure if it's the medicine the doctor gave me or if I'm so overwhelmed that I'm numb.

My body aches but not badly. As long as I stay still, I feel no pain. Only when I move does it feel like I'm very sore, especially in my lower stomach.

I don't know how I'm feeling mentally about everything Quinton told me. Even when I think about it, there is no emotion attached to it. Not yet anyway. I'm sure that will change when I start remembering... if I remember.

Some memories have popped back up, but none from the attack. The drug they gave me must be blocking them. I remember Lucas dropping me off at my house and no one being there. I even recall thinking about calling Quinton, but I decided against it because I had the idiotic idea of being able to protect myself. How naïve and stupid I was.

The sound of approaching footsteps breaks the silence of the night, making me fist the soft sheets beneath my fingers. My heart races, and I suck in a deep breath, holding it until the door opens enough to let me see who it is.

When Quinton's dark, messy hair comes into view, I puff out the air in my lungs and relax my hands. Closing the door behind him quietly, he walks into the room until he's standing right next to the bed, so close I can touch him.

"You're awake," he whispers.

"Can't sleep."

"Do you need some more pain meds? Are you hungry?"

"No." I shake my head. "I'm okay."

"I'm gonna take a quick shower. I'll be right back." Quinton disappears into the attached bathroom but doesn't close the door all the way. I listen to the shower being turned on, letting the sound of the falling water almost lull me back to sleep.

The moment the water turns off and the space is drowning in silence once more, my eyes fly open. It's not until this moment that I realize why I can't sleep. It's too quiet in here.

Quinton is naked when he re-enters the room, with only a towel wrapped around his hips. I watch him go to one of the large drawers, pulling a pair of boxers from it before dropping the towel on the ground and trading it for underwear.

By the time he comes closer again, the sun has almost set, but the room is bright enough to let me notice how swollen and bruised Quinton's knuckles are.

"What happened to your hands?" I ask as Quinton carefully climbs onto the bed. He settles onto the other side of the large mattress, leaving a good foot between us. I'm sure it's because he doesn't want to accidentally hurt me, but truthfully, I'd rather have him closer than this.

"We went to Matteo's family's place tonight." The name alone has my stomach churning. "But he wasn't there. We'll find him, though. Don't worry about him; we'll find him soon," Quinton promises, and I have no doubt he'll make good on it.

"If he wasn't there, who did you beat up?" I ask, thinking about his knuckles.

"Matteo's brother was there, Rico..."

"Get the door, Rico. We're going to teach this bitch a fucking lesson. I was gonna fuck you alone, Aspen, but since you are being a cunt, I'm going to let my brother and uncle fuck you too."

The memory hits me like a ton of bricks, knocking the air out of me.

"Hey, you okay?" Quinton reaches out for my hand. His fingers engulf mine, and I let the warmth of his touch calm me.

"I-I think Rico was there when..." My throat clogs up, not letting me finish the sentence.

"I know he was," Quinton confirms.

"Matteo's uncle was there too." "Rico is already dead, and his uncle will be soon as well."

"You killed Rico?"

"Yes."

Never in my life did I think I would be happy to hear of someone's death, and maybe even now, happy is the wrong word. Relief might be more

fitting. I'm relieved that he will never be able to touch me again or hurt anyone else.

"How long have I been here, and how did you find me? My memory is so fuzzy."

"You left Corium four days ago. Lucas dropped you off at your place Friday morning, and Matteo sent me an address Friday night, saying you would be there. I went there right away and brought you here. You were pretty out of it the first forty-eight hours."

"I still feel out of it, like I'm not myself."

"You are still on a high dose of pain meds. It will get better."

I want to believe him, but a part of me thinks I'm stuck like this, numb and uncaring. "Thank you for coming for me."

"Don't thank me for that. It should have never happened in the first place."

"You're right, it shouldn't have happened... I feel like it's my fault it did," I admit shamefully.

"Why the fuck would you think that?"

"I thought about calling you when I got home, and the house was empty. I decided against it because I wanted to take care of myself. Maybe if I had called you—"

"Don't," Quinton snaps. "Don't you dare blame yourself. None of this is your fault."

"I just wish I wasn't so weak."

"Aspen, you're the strongest person I know. No matter how much shit people put you through, including me, you never let it break you. You got back up every time with your head held high. You even stood up to my father, and I've seen grown men piss their pants in his presence."

"I don't feel strong."

"But you are. Even when the entire school had it out for you, you went to class every day."

“I wanted to hide in my room.”

“But you didn’t.”

“I basically sold my body to you so you would keep me safe.”

“You did what you had to do to protect yourself. Everyone needs someone, and needing help is not a weakness. Plus, we both know that you wanted me anyway.”

“Do you have an answer to everything?”

“Yes.”

“Then tell me what is going to happen next?”

“You’ll stay here until you’re all healed up, and then we’ll go back to Corium. In the meantime, I’m tracking down Matteo so I can end his miserable life.”

I think about how much easier it will be with Matteo gone. Not having to watch my back and constantly worry he’ll be waiting for me around every corner.

“I like the idea of him being dead.”

“Me too.”

“What did you have to promise your father for him to be so nice to me? He almost seemed like he cared about me when he was here earlier.”

“I didn’t have to promise him anything. Don’t take this the wrong way, but I don’t think it’s particularly about you. He still doesn’t like you, but he is angry that they hurt you the way they did. Scarlet is not much younger than you, and Adela was your age.” He doesn’t have to explain more; Xander thinks it could have been one of his daughters.

Quinton readjusts his hold on my hand, interlacing my fingers with his. We’ve had sex, kissed, and held each other while naked, but nothing has felt as intimate as the way we are holding hands right now.

“How am I going to get over what happened?”

“You’re not supposed to get over it, but we’ll learn how to live with it. What happened doesn’t define who you are.”



I DON'T KNOW when I fell asleep. I only know that when I open my eyes, I'm alone again. Deep down inside, I didn't expect anything else. Quinton rarely sleeps for long. Besides, he's on a mission to balance the scales.

It's only when the door opens that I realize the approach of the nurse must be what woke me. “Good, you’re awake.”

I only nod since I doubt she would appreciate it if I pointed out she woke me up. She's been nothing but kind, though, like the doctor.

“How about we get you on your feet?” She must recognize the horror on my face for what it is since her expression softens. “Movement is important for healing. I know it's easy for me to say in my position while you're the one hurting, but it's the truth. The sooner you start moving around, the quicker your body will mend itself.”

I'm in pain with the slightest movement, even with the meds. And she wants me to walk?

I don't have it in me to argue.

Besides, she's already pulling back the blankets. I don't think she's going to listen to arguments.

Now I'm treated to the sight of the tube running out from between my legs and emptying into a clear bag. The sight of blood-tinged urine stirs up half-memories of confusion and agony. I don't even remember having the catheter inserted. Now, I have to spread my sore legs to have it removed. One humiliation after another.

“I'll be taking this catheter out, and then I'll help you to the bathroom. Just relax.” I exhale hard when she tells me to and whimper against the uncomfortable pressure of having the bulb removed. I'm still so raw down there, a constant reminder of what they did to me.

But one of them has already paid with his life. Somehow, the discomfort subsides when I remember that.

It flares back up as soon as I sit up with the nurse's help, then lower my legs over the side of the bed. Parts of my body I didn't know existed suddenly scream out. "Deep breaths," the nurse reminds me in a soft voice. "You're doing fine." I don't know if I agree, but I do manage to stand on shaky legs before dragging one foot, then the other, across the room. It seems even larger than before.

By the time we reach the bathroom, it's not only my legs that are shaking. My entire lower half pulses with pain, and I'm finding it hard to remember to breathe when fighting not to cry takes up so much of my concentration.

None of that is anything compared to what happens after the horror show of peeing with an audience. "You're doing just great," she insists. You would think after months of being treated like I'm not human, I'd be grateful for the kind encouragement. But it seems empty right now when I feel anything but great. I feel weak and hurt and crumpled.

And I look even worse. It's seeing myself in the mirror for the first time that breaks me. At first, I recoil in shock. That can't be me, the girl whose face is so swollen, the girl with those ugly bruises all over her throat. The finger marks are a hideous tattoo. Like a phantom hand. It can't be real.

But it is. This is the proof, clear as day, thanks to the lighting mounted above the vanity. A tear rolls down my cheek. I didn't even know I started to cry.

"All of this will get better." The grip she has on my arm, and the hand at my waist tighten just a little. "Bruises fade. Swelling goes down. None of the damage was permanent. This will only be a memory."

Only a memory. Like that's not bad. I can't get away from the mirror fast enough. "I need to lie down," I whisper, keeping my eyes away from my reflection. She helps me back to bed, and I thank her in a weak voice. That little bit of activity exhausted me.

What I want more than anything is the emptiness of sleep. I want to forget. I want to be somewhere, anywhere it doesn't hurt.

Instead, there's a soft knock on the door before it opens. I hold my breath, hoping for Quinton, but it's his mother's golden head that pokes into the room. "Hi, there," Ella murmurs. "I wanted to check on you. I heard it's time for you to get up and move around a little bit."

"She did just fine," the nurse announces. I almost want to ask her to stop pretending I'm being heroic since I feel anything but. The words feel empty. But that's not her fault.

The women exchange the kind of brief, tight smile people wear when they're uncomfortable but trying their best. The nurse leaves us alone, promising she'll be back in half an hour with more medicine. After walking to the bathroom and back, the thirty minutes can't pass fast enough.

Ella, meanwhile, hasn't moved. She's so polished and put together, but not in a flashy way. It helps me feel more comfortable around her.

"Are you hungry?" she asks, taking a few slow steps closer to the bed. "You slept through breakfast, you know."

Yes, and now that she mentions it, my stomach growls like it heard her. I just now notice how hungry I am. "It's not easy to stay awake for long," I admit.

"I'm sure. But you do need to rest." She folds her hands in front of herself, and this time, her smile looks more natural. Less hesitant. "What do you say? I can have lunch brought up for both of us."

My brows knit together before I can stop them. I'm not used to so much kindness, especially not from this family. "Unless you would rather be alone," she adds. "I only thought you might like a little company while waiting for your next dose of medication since you've spent so much time alone up here, and I'm sure your first time out of bed wasn't pleasant."

She doesn't know it, but that's exactly what I need now. A little company and a little kindness. "That would be great," I decide, and for the first time since waking up to a nightmare, I feel a sliver of content.

QUINTON

I deeply regret killing Rico the way I did. I let my emotions take over and acted rashly. That won't happen with Pauli, Matteo's uncle. When I get to him, I won't end his life as quickly as I did Rico. I will take my time, make him suffer, and draw out his agony for many, many hours. Only when I get tired of his endless begging and pleading to end his suffering will I finally give him the mercy of death.

I haven't been able to watch much of the videos Valentine had on his phone, but I force myself to do so in small increments. That's all I can handle without going on an uncontrollable killing spree.

Hovering my thumb over the play button, I mentally prepare myself for what's to come. When I press down, the screen comes to life, and the overwhelming feeling of dread and helplessness starts eating its way through my body.

"Look at your ass taking my cock like a good little whore," Matteo grunts, forcing himself into her from behind. *"You should thank me for using some spit."*

She is on all fours now, her back arched and her head held up by Pauli.

"You are right. She is being a really good whore. I'm going to reward her with a fat lollipop to suck on." Pauli snickers. *"Open your mouth, little slut."* He slaps her across the face so hard her upper body slumps to the ground. Pauli pulls her back up by her hair, and Aspen cries out in pain.

I press pause and shove my phone back in my pocket. Taking a few calming breaths, I remind myself that Aspen is safe in my room, and Pauli will suffer greatly for what he has done.

According to my father, we'll be able to bring him in today. Apparently, Pauli is even dumber than the rest of his family since he is not even trying to hide.

Not much longer, and I'll be able to let my anger out on that piece of shit.

Making my way through the house, I ignore all the extra guards Dad has put in place and make my way to his office.

"We've got him," my father announces as soon as I enter the room. Closing his laptop in front of him, he continues. "Our men are bringing him to the same warehouse they held Aspen in. Still no sign of Matteo but maybe his dear uncle can help with that."

"I'm ready to find out. Did we get the venom in?"

"Yes, it's already packed in the car."

It didn't take me long to come up with an appropriate way to kill him—after we torture him, of course. Both of which I will enjoy dearly.

I follow my dad outside, thankful that we don't run into my mom or my sister. I don't have the time or patience right now to act like a normal brother or son when all I can think of is leaving to torture someone to death.

It's rare that Dad drives the car himself. Normally, we have a driver ready to take us anywhere we want. Today, my father slides into the driver's seat of the blacked-out SUV. I take my seat in the passenger's side, relieved to have another moment to ourselves.

"I'll let you take the lead on this unless you give me a sign that you want me to take over," my father says, breaking the silence.

"That won't happen."

"I didn't think so either, but I wanted you to know you have the option."

"I want to make him suffer."

“He will, and you’ll be the one making him.”

All I can do is nod. Silently, I wonder how fucked up our family is that we bond over shit like this. The relationship between my father and me has been strained to say the least. It’s been so bad I didn’t want to be in the same room as him.

This whole thing has brought me closer to him. I feel our bond strengthen again. I’m still not over him lying and taking my birth mother from me, but having him by my side now makes me appreciate the man my father is.

Normal people don’t have to deal with half the shit I go through, but they also don’t get to hunt people down to make them pay for what they did. Most days, I feel like our lifestyle is a burden. Today, I’m fucking glad my dad is who he is.

When we get to the warehouse, my father’s men have already stripped Pauli of his clothes and tied him to the chair we had altered.

Our footsteps echo through the large open space as we approach the tied-up bastard. He is already whimpering against the gag like the little bitch he is.

I hate being in this place, knowing it’s where they hurt Aspen. The image of finding her naked, battered body on this nasty floor still haunts me, but that’s a part of the reason I wanted it to be here. I want good memories to replace the bad ones. And by good, I mean I want this place to be filled with the screams of Aspen’s abusers. I want their blood to coat the walls and their piss to soak the floor.

“Hello, Pauli,” my father greets, excitement coating his tone. “Looks like you are just getting comfortable.”

Pauli struggles against the rope holding him in place. His junk is hanging out of the hole we had cut in the chair, making me smirk.

We also had a table set up with an array of special tools and liquids that I’m dying to try out. When I walk over to look at what my father brought, my excitement only grows. I reach for the castration clamp, normally used for cattle. Picking up the heavy metal object, I take a closer look at the sharp edges.

“Normally, farmers use this to castrate their bulls. They heat these tongs so the process is quick and the skin is cauterized. Unfortunately, I didn’t bring a lighter, and I wasn’t in the Boy Scouts, so I have no idea how to make fire.”

Pauli mumbles something inaudible against the fabric shoved in his mouth.

“What was that? You’re looking forward to having your balls chopped off? Yeah, me too, buddy. Me too.” I snap the clamp shut, letting him hear the sound of the metal coming together.

“I guess we’re ready to start.” My father’s voice booms through the space, and two of his men take their position behind Pauli. Grabbing the chair, they tip Pauli back. His muffled screams are music to my ears.

“Here, put this on,” Dad orders and throws me a ski mask. I pull it on quickly before kneeling in front of Pauli with the castration clamp in hand.

“Is the camera on? Don’t want to miss any of this.” I grin.

“Camera is on,” my father confirms.

“Good. Say goodbye to your shriveled-up balls, Pauli.” I open the tongs and place them around his scrotum. Even with the fabric stuffed into his mouth, Pauli’s screams are so loud it hurts my eardrum.

I clamp down, and his whole body convulses in pain to the point I think he might break the restraints. His high-pitched screams go on for a while before they turn to pained groans and finally trail off into a low whimper.

Leaving the clamp on, I get on my feet and watch Pauli being sat back up. With every little move, his distress gets more apparent, and I couldn’t be happier about it.



I DON’T KEEP track of time, but I know we must have been at it for hours by the way my muscles ache, and Pauli’s blood is dried to his skin.

Every time I feel an inkling of guilt for doing this to him, I think about the way he raped Aspen on this very floor, and all my doubts disappear into thin air. He deserves every single excruciating second of pain I inflict on him.

He has passed out a few times, but luckily, we brought a few vials of epinephrine to wake his ass right back up. Unfortunately, if we give him another dose, his heart will probably stop. So I guess it is time to end this and go home.

A while ago, Dad pulled up a chair to lounge back like he's enjoying the show all while filming everything.

"My phone battery is about to die, better wrap this up soon if you want to get it on video." My father sounds almost bored now.

"That's fine. I don't think he's gonna make it much longer anyway. What do you say, Pauli? Should we stop torturing you?"

Pauli's eyes are so swollen I'm not sure he can even see me, but when he slowly nods his head, I know he can at least hear. His face is unrecognizable, his body barely able to support his own weight. The gag in his mouth is soaked with blood and puke, so I grab a pair of pliers from the table to take it out.

He doesn't even squirm away anymore, his body too battered to fight me, even a little. The castration tool is still hanging from his balls which are a dark blue now.

As soon as the gag is out, he starts pleading. "P-Please... please..."

"Please, what? End your miserable life? Yeah, planning on it. But you know what? I'm not heartless. Maybe you've suffered enough? I mean, your balls are basically about to fall off, and all you did was have a little fun with some unwilling girl, right? Do you really deserve to die for that?"

Pauli must have grown a brain cell in the last few hours because he doesn't even try to answer my rhetorical question.

"Like I said, I'm not heartless. So I'm gonna let fate decide if you live or die." I walk back to the table and pull the small black container closer.

Unlatching the sides, I pop the lid open and look at the two syringes inside.

“One of these has morphine in it, the other one strychnine. Heard of it?” I pause, taking the container over to Pauli to let him look at them. “Strychnine is a particularly nasty poison that takes only ten minutes to work when taken by mouth. Which means an injection will work much faster than that. First, your body will begin to spasm, starting around the head and neck area, then it will spread to the rest of your muscle tissue. It will get to the point of your backbone arching. The convulsions will get so bad that lactic acidosis, hyperthermia, and rhabdomyolysis will all set in around the same time. But you’ll actually die from asphyxiation since your neural pathways will be paralyzed, and you won’t be able to breathe.”

I hold the two syringes right in front of his face. Both hold a clear liquid and are not distinguishable from each other. “You pick one. I have no idea which one holds your salvation and which one your demise.”

Pauli stares at the two for a few seconds before slightly nodding to the left one.

“Left it is.” Carefully, I take out the one he picked and set the box back on the table. Not too gently, I plunge the needle into his arm and inject him with every last drop of liquid in the syringe. When I’m done, I dispose of the injection needle and turn to Pauli.

“Well, before we find out which one you picked. I have a confession to make... there is no morphine.”

ASPEN

Things are different today. I can feel it in my chest with every breath I take. There is still pain, more emotional than physical. I sit in Quinton's bed. His scent surrounds me, comforting me, swirling deep in my lungs. Ella walks about the room, refilling my water cup and disposing of my barely touched breakfast.

I don't feel like myself, and in many ways, that person I used to be is gone. The shell encasing me is the same, bruised and battered but still intact. It's the deeper stuff, the stuff that I can't even fathom thinking about because if I do, I'll spiral into a place I'll never return from.

My mind still attempts to fill the missing pieces with whatever horror it can muster up. I do my best not to think about what Quinton told me, but somehow, I can't get the thoughts to leave, and I know why.

I know I need to digest that I was pregnant, that there was an innocent life growing inside me, but I just... I can't. I look down at my flat stomach covered by one of Quinton's oversized T-shirts.

I feel empty, completely empty, without a drop of use. The thought evaporates when Quinton's sister, Scarlet, sits on the edge of the bed beside me. I watch her out of the corner of my eye.

I know she wants to comfort me because everyone does. Quinton, their mom, the doctor, and the nurse, but nothing can comfort me. Nothing can stop the gushing wound inside my heart.

“Are you in any pain?” Scarlet asks, her voice nearly a whisper.

I look up at her and shake my head. My throat is tight, emotions I’m not ready to face yet clog it.

She frowns, and her angelic face fills with sadness. Scarlet is beautiful, the perfect blend of Xander and Ella, with big blue eyes and blond hair framing her heart-shaped face. I don’t want to burden her with the knowledge of what happened.

I don’t even know everything that happened. My mind blocks out every thought the moment I think I might have latched onto something. Bitter cold encompasses my body, and I grip the blanket tightly, wanting to bury myself beneath it.

“Quinton asked me to tell you everything will be okay and that he’ll return soon.”

All I can do is blink, letting her know that I heard her. Nothing is ever going to be fine again. I’m broken, shattered from the inside out. I might be alive, but a part of me died back in that warehouse.

The best parts of me, the parts that make me whole. Out of the corner of my eye, I spot Ella walking toward us.

Her blond hair is tied back into a ponytail, and the concerned look etched into her features makes my stomach tighten. I’m already tired of people worrying about me.

She stops at the edge of the bed, her eyes roaming over me. I can see the sadness in her eyes, the pity.

“Would you like to take a shower or even a sponge bath?” The idea of being clean, of taking a shower, never crossed my mind. It doesn’t matter to me. No amount of soap or water will clean away the filth that coats my skin. I’m forever damaged.

“Not right now,” I respond, my voice cracking. I’m thankful for Quinton’s family, that they’re here to take care of me and help, but all I feel like is a burden. A weak burden who couldn’t protect herself.

Ella frowns, but then the look of sadness slips from her face. “Maybe instead of a shower or bath, I bring you a cell phone, so you can call someone? Maybe a friend or your parents? Anyone that might be worried about your whereabouts?”

She stares at me, waiting for my answer. The thought of talking to Brittney, or even my mother, lightens my mood, but I don’t have Brittney’s number, and I have no idea where my mother is.

“Whenever I get down, I always call my sister, Violet. Talking to her always helps.” I know she’s just being kind, but I want to tell her it’s nice that she has someone to talk to, but that’s not the case for me. Instead, I just shake my head.

“There isn’t really anyone to call.” I shrug. “My mom wasn’t home when I was there. It looked like no one had been there for a while, and she hadn’t answered any of my calls.”

“Maybe she is...” Ella trails off, probably not able to think of any excuse a mother wouldn’t be available to her children.

“She hasn’t answered any of the school’s calls either. Even after the helicopter crash...” I force myself to shut up. Ella already feels sorry for me; I don’t need to add anything to the pity party.

“How about extended family? Cousins, friends?”

I keep shaking my head, almost embarrassed by how lonely my life is.

“Are you sure?” Scarlet interjects. “What about someone from school?”

An idea pops into my head then. “Actually, there is someone I want to call, but I don’t have his number. Is there any way you could get it?”

Ella places her hands on her hips, a giant smile appearing on her face. “I’m a Rossi, sweetheart. There is nothing out of my reach. Whose number do we need to get?”

“Lucas Diabolo, if it’s not too much trouble.”

“It’s not.” Both Scarlet and Ella speak at the same time.

My gaze ping-pongs between them, and I watch curiously as Ella pulls her cell phone out. She navigates the device and passes it to me a moment later. I take it and peer down at the bright screen, my eyes half-open.

Right there on the screen is Luca's name and number, which means she had his information saved in her phone. I'm not really surprised. She is Xander's wife, after all.

"Go ahead, call him," Ella encourages. "He knows you're here."

My finger hovers over the green call button for a moment before I press it and bring the phone to my ear. The phone rings exactly two times before Lucas's rich voice filters into the phone.

"Hello, Ella."

"Hi, um... it's Aspen," I say, my voice thick.

"Hey, kid, it's good to hear you're doing okay."

"Sure, if you could call it that," I mumble.

"I'm sorry, I shouldn't have said it that way."

"It's all right. I am okay, I guess. I'm calling because I wanted to know if you've heard from Brittney? I wanted to make sure she was okay."

Lucas sighs. "After everything that happened to you, you're worried about someone else?"

Ignoring his comment, I ask, "Can you just tell me if she's okay or not?"

"She's doing fine. I checked in with her last night. Everyone is okay. Now you need to worry about yourself and heal up, okay?"

He sounds like my dad. Which reminds me... "Have you heard from my parents?" I ask the question, all while knowing the answer.

"Unfortunately, no. As soon as Xander called me after..." He trails off a bit, and I'm thankful he doesn't say anything in regard to what happened. "I called both your mother and father numerous times but got no answer."

“Okay.” I squeeze the phone, ignoring the dull ache forming in my chest. They don’t care about me because they would try harder if they did, and that’s the shitty part. The person who is supposed to be my enemy, supposed to be the last person I ever turn to, is the only person I have when the dust settles.

“I know it’s not my place, but I’m sorry, Aspen. Like always, if I hear anything, I’ll be sure to contact you right away.” Again, pity clings to his words. I don’t want sympathy, not right now. I just want to crawl beneath the covers and pretend none of this ever happened.

“Thanks,” I whisper and hang up the phone, letting it drop down onto the blanket covering my lap.

I can feel Ella and Scarlet watching me, and I hold back the tears forming in my eyes. Almost as if Ella can tell how close I am to shattering, she clears her throat and speaks.

“Scarlet and I are going to go make you some tea. We’ll be back in a bit, okay?”

My throat is clogged with emotions, so all I can manage to do is nod. Scarlet pushes off the bed and walks out of the bedroom with her mother. As soon as they’re gone and the door clicks closed behind them, one single tear slips from my eye. It leaves a cold trail behind as it slides over the apple of my cheek and down my face.

That single tear holds all my betrayals, all the pain and sadness I’ve endured. It holds my disappointment for my parents and the loss of innocence by others who wanted to hurt me for their own twisted pleasure. After today, I vow never to cry for people who do not cry for me, who do not care for me. I vow to be stronger because the only person I can count on is myself.

QUINTON

“*H*ow much longer?” I’ve lost track of the number of times I’ve asked this question. It’s been four days since I killed Pauli and three days since I killed two of Matteo’s cousins, but it took me only one day to get antsy for the next kill.

A kill that has Matteo’s name tag pinned to it.

“We’ve got a lead on it, but I’m not sure if it will pan out. Matteo is supposed to be at this address tonight.” My dad shows me his phone with a map pulled up.

“I’m ready when you are.”

“Have you decided what you are going to do to him?”

“Oh, yes. I have every detail planned, and I have a very special room ready for Matteo.”

My father gives me an approving nod. “Before we leave, I need to talk to you again. I want to remind you of our deal.”

Of course, he is. He doesn’t need to remind me. The deal was I have to dump Aspen after this. I thought he would change his mind seeing how much she means to me, but I guess I was wrong.

“Why? Why do I have to stop seeing her?”

Instead of answering, he counters with his own question.

“How did you find out I killed Tia?”

“What does that have to do with...” I don’t even finish my question, realizing quickly that it has everything to do with this.

“She didn’t tell me. I overheard her talking to her dad.”

“But she knew?”

“Yes, but I don’t even know how long.”

“She’s known since before the founders’ ball. I’m sure of it because she threatened to tell you when I ran into her that night.”

“She was probably bluffing.”

“Maybe she was, maybe she wasn’t. The fact is that she knew, and she’d known for a while. Instead of telling you, she held on to it so she could use it against me.”

Fuck. I don’t have an explanation for that one. “So what? You really think she is here to spy on us?” There is no way I’m that blind, is there?

“No. I thought that in the beginning. But I know now that her parents were just using her. I don’t even think she knows the extent of it.”

“Why? What are you keeping from me?”

“Nothing. I’ve learned that keeping things from you doesn’t end well. I knew after... when I saw her in your room after you brought her here. It made me realize how young she is, how naïve and impressionable. Even if she knew she was wearing a wire, she was just a child trying to please her parents. And then those assholes just left their own daughter to fend for herself, unprotected.”

“I don’t understand. If you know that Aspen is not the one to blame, why can’t I be with her?”

“Because one, even if they are assholes who treat her like shit, they are still her parents. We could never fully trust her. And two, if people find out about you and what happened to Aspen, connect it with the sudden demise of the entire Valentine family, we’re going to have a lot of angry people

knocking on our door. Being with her will put our family in danger. It will put your mother and sister in danger, and I cannot let that happen.”

Fuck.

As much as I want to keep Aspen, I can’t put Scarlet and my mom in danger. Dad is right. I can’t be with her.

“Neither can I.”

Not now, not ever.



I’m flat on the ground. The entire front side of my body is so cold it’s numb. My clothes have absorbed the thin layer of snow covering the grass when I laid down, making it impossible to get warm.

Relaxing my body, I force myself not to shake as I bring the scope back to my eye. From where I’m at, I have the perfect view of the house, the driveways, and even part of the backyard. There is only one thing missing now. Matteo.

As I wait, my father’s words run on replay, a never-ending loop I can’t stop. I have to let her go, but that doesn’t mean I can’t watch out for her from afar. I can protect my family and still make sure Aspen is safe, and that means eliminating every threat.

“You’re doing much better than I thought you would,” Luke whispers from beside me. “Last time we did this, you were whining about being cold.”

“Last time we did this, I was fourteen, and it was just to train. Where is the fun in that? This time, I actually get to kill people.”

“Can’t argue with that.” Luke chuckles.

A few minutes later, a black van pulls up, stopping in the driveway. Both front doors open, and two guys step out. I catch sight of Matteo through my scope, and my trigger finger tingles. He has no idea what’s coming. I could

end him now, blow his brains out with one bullet. His body would hit the ground before his friends realized they were under attack.

But killing him so quickly would only bring me regret.

No, he won't die so easily.

"I got a shot on one of the guys inside," Luke whispers under his breath.

"Take it," I order, a second before I fire my own shot. I hit Matteo's friend dead center between his eyes. The bullet hits with such force that I can see half of his head explode in my scope.

A grin tucks at the corner of my lips when I see Matteo freak out and run inside, where he is going to find another dead body. This night is already great. I can't wait for the rest of it.

We leave our sniper rifles behind and make our way down the hill we were hiding out on. We are armed from head to toe, wearing Kevlar thin enough to let us move freely but strong enough to stop a bullet or knife. Not that I'm particularly worried about dying, but neither one of my parents would have let me go if I hadn't put this on.

By the time we get to the house, backup from the other side of the property is already there. We crouch in front of one of the large bay windows, looking inside the living room. No one is inside as far as we can see, but of course, we have to expect anything.

"All in position?" Luke whispers, and multiple voices come through my earpiece, confirming everyone is ready. "Three, two, go."

We all move at the same time, a synchronized team just as we trained for. Luke fires two quick shots in opposite corners of the window, making the entire glass shatter in front of us.

Guns raised, we step over the window frame and into the room. Shards of glass crunch underneath our boots as we move farther into the house.

Adrenaline is pumping through my veins, heightening my senses. I clear my mind, leaving nothing behind but one single thought, one mission... find Matteo.

I'm vaguely aware of voices coming through the headset, but I drown them out and keep walking through the house. I see two of my men, recognizing them instantly since we are all wearing midnight blue. Matteo's shirt was gray, and when I finally catch sight of the gray figure rushing around the corner, I'm like a bull seeing red.

I follow him, each move precise and controlled.

He spins around when he realizes I'm coming for him. Matteo is holding a gun, but he doesn't even have a chance to point it at me before I shoot it out of his hand. He groans, holding his bleeding fingers to his chest, and turns, still trying to get away from me.

Lowering my gun, I shoot him in the back of the calf, making him scream out in pain and crumple to the floor like a rag doll. While he is crying like the worthless piece of shit he is, I kick his fallen gun behind me so he can't get to it.

I watch patiently as he rolls onto his back and sprawls out, looking up at me. Casually leaning against the wall, I stand there and simply enjoy the view for a few moments. I don't have to worry about anyone else attacking me since I know my team has taken care of anyone else in this house.

"Kill me already," Matteo rasps after a while. His breathing is heavy with blood pooling around his leg.

"I will, but not until you suffer, and trust me when I say this... I have a lot of suffering planned for you."

"The house is clear!" Luke announces from down the hall.

"I got what I came for, so we can leave," I yell back.

Taking two steps toward Matteo, I swing my leg back and kick him full force in his upper thigh, right above his bullet wound. To my ears, his cries of anguish sound like a beautiful symphony composed just for me. In a pitiful attempt to roll away from me, he moves to his side. I use the new angle to give his ribs a swift kick before raising my foot and driving my heel into his nose.

Matteo's head snaps back so hard that, for a moment, I'm worried I broke his neck. His pained groan and the blood gushing from his nose make me breathe easier. He's still alive.

Luke comes up behind me, and we make quick work of tying Matteo up while he is out. After I tighten the rope around his ankles, I wrap the end of it around my hand and start dragging him through the house by his feet.

He doesn't wake up until I drag him down the front steps, making sure his head hits each corner. Matteo groans and mumbles something inaudible as I drag his body through the gravel outside, then, with Luke's help, lift him into the car's trunk.

"Everything is set up at the warehouse," Luke confirms when we get into the car.

"Good." I can't remember the last time I was so excited for something. Maybe Christmas morning when I was five? No, I don't think I've ever been this excited before. I feel like I've been waiting a lifetime for this.

We pull up to the warehouse an hour later. My hands are shaking but not from fear or anger. I'm shaking because of the anticipation.

Luke and I get out of the car and walk around to the trunk. I pop it open, finding Matteo still passed out.

"Wake up, shithead. You're gonna miss all the fun." I grab Matteo by one arm and let Luke take the other.

"He's lost a lot of blood," Luke points out. "We'll have to cauterize the wound if you want him to live a little longer."

"Let's get on with it then."

We drag Matteo through the warehouse to the same spot he raped Aspen, and I killed his uncle. Pauli's mangled body is still there, rotting away on the chair where I left him.

My men have set up a new torture chair for Matteo, far enough away to avoid the pungent odor of rotting flesh but close enough for him to see his uncle's dead body.

We make quick work of restraining Matteo to the bolted-down chair. My hands are not shaking anymore. I'm calm, collected... and so fucking ready for this.

"Let's wake his ass up before we cauterize the wound." I grin.

Luke nods and starts getting a syringe of epinephrine ready while I light up the compact flamethrower to heat the end of a crowbar. The metal turns from its dull gray color to a glowing orange just in time. Luke shoves the needle into Matteo's chest and injects him with the drug.

Matteo's reaction is almost instantaneous. His eyes fly open, and he sucks in an audible breath like he has been underwater, and his head has just breached the surface.

"There you are. Welcome back to hell." My words have barely left my mouth when I press the glowing end of the crowbar to Matteo's bullet wound. The smell of burned flesh fills the air, and I watch in delight as his skin melts into his ripped jeans.

"It's gonna be a pain getting those pants off now," I say more to myself since no one can actually hear me over Matteo's cries. He screams so loud, I'm sure anyone within a one-mile radius can hear.

I pull the bar away from his mangled leg and drop it on the ground beside us. Matteo's pained cries turn into pitiful whimpers while I look over the tools and gadgets my men have laid out for me on the table.

"How about we pull some teeth? That will be fun." I can't help the corners of my mouth from tipping up.

"I'll make sure his mouth stays open," Luke says and grabs the baseball bat from the table. I take my time picking out a pair of pliers before turning back around to face Matteo.

Luke stands behind him, pulling the wedged baseball bat in Matteo's mouth. Smirking like the villain in a Disney movie, I close the distance between me and my target.

"Let's start with these." I tap the bottom teeth with the pliers.

Matteo's eyes are wide open, bloodshot, and full of fear. He knows what's coming. Pain and death.

"I warned you. I told you what would happen if you touched her, and I always stand by my word." Turning the pliers in my hand, I open and grab one of his bottom teeth and start pulling.

Being so close to his face, I'm thankful for the bat muffling Matteo's gurgled scream as I wiggle and pull his teeth out one by one. He is going to make my ears hurt otherwise.

I take my time extracting all the front teeth I can reach with the bat shoved in his mouth. There is so much swelling and blood that Matteo is unrecognizable.

"I'm bored with this. Let's find something new." I throw the pliers aside and wipe my blood-covered hands on my shirt.

Luke pulls the bat out of Matteo's mouth, and his head instantly lulls to the side as if he's lost his strength to even hold himself up.

"Is he dead?" Luke questions casually from behind him.

"I hope not. I have so much more planned for him." So, so much.

ASPEN

“Spread her legs. I want to watch the cum drip out of her and onto the ground.” Matteo’s voice rings in my ears, but my limbs are too heavy to struggle against the person grasping them. I try with all my might to open my eyes, but there must be boulders holding them shut because no matter how hard I try to lift them, they don’t budge.

“You’re getting this on video, right?” I hear Matteo say.

In my mind, I’m screaming, telling them to stop, struggling with all my might, but all that seems to escape my lips is a groan. Someone laughs, and the sound is like nails on a chalkboard.

“Fuck, yeah, I’m getting this. Can you imagine how livid Rossi is going to be when he sees this video? His queen all used up, our cum dripping out of her,” a voice I don’t recognize says, and I feel myself drifting to another place, a place where no one can hurt me.

“Roll her over and get a look at her ass. I want him to see how hard we took her.”

I wake suddenly, shoving up into a sitting position, my hands fist the sheets. It was just a dream. It was just a dream. I recite to myself over and over again. But was it really? Because I endured those things.

I peer around the room, my eyes wild as I look for any hints of danger. When I find the room empty, I let out a ragged breath. Beads of sweat cling

to my skin, and my heart beats rapidly in my chest, each thump heavier than the next.

Everything is okay. You're safe.

I repeat the sentence half a dozen times before I feel even an inkling of calmness entering my bloodstream. Breathing deeply through my nose and out of my mouth, I slowly calm myself. The panic threatening to pull me under slowly recedes like the banks of an overflowing river.

My vise-like grip on the blanket slips, and I toss the covers aside. Moving, I let my feet dangle over the edge of the bed. I bring the neck of the oversized T-shirt that's Quinton to my nose and inhale deeply, letting his woodsy scent fill my lungs. It calms me, and I shudder as I come down from the adrenaline high the nightmare gave me. Slowly, I push off the bed and tiptoe into the bathroom to get a glass of water.

The light automatically turns on when I walk inside. It's only a few feet to the sink, and my fingers shake as I grab the glass sitting on the counter. I don't even look at my reflection in the mirror, afraid of what I might see. The haunting look in my eyes terrifies me.

I'll have to live with what happened for the rest of my life. The memories will never disappear. I'll never be the same person I was before. I turn on the faucet and watch the water splatter against the porcelain sink before I bring the glass under the stream of water and fill it. Once full, I bring the glass to my lips and take a gulp.

The cool water blazes a path down my throat. I turn to walk out of the bathroom, the light shutting off behind me. The room is dark, and a scream catches in my throat, and my hold on the glass nearly slips when I see Quinton standing at the foot of the bed.

Every inch of him is covered in blood, and for a brief second, I panic and wonder if it's his blood, only realizing a moment later that it's most likely *theirs*. His icy blue gaze catches on me, softening slightly.

"It's done. They're all dead."

"Dead? All of them? Who are all of them?" I'm not sure what I anticipated happening.

“Every single Valentine. I killed them all. The whole family.” The look in his eyes is that of rage and violence, and I’d hate to see what he did to them tonight, knowing how much blood coats his body. “They hurt you, hurt what was mine, so I made certain they’ll never be able to do it again.” A sane person would be disgusted, one who assumes the law or policemen could do the job of ensuring the guilty get prosecuted, but in our lives, we’re the jury, judge, and prosecutor.

Quinton did what the law never would. The weight on my chest lifts, the knowledge that they died for their crimes, that they can never hurt me again, makes me feel free.

“Thank you,” I whisper.

I set the glass of water on the nightstand and consider rushing toward him to give him a hug but reconsider, looking at the blood dripping off him and onto the floor.

“Don’t thank me. It never should’ve happened, and I’ll blame myself every day going forward for it. At least now I know you got a sliver of justice.” I nod because while I don’t feel Quinton is to blame, I understand why he feels that way. “I’m going to take a shower and wash the filth away. Afterward, I want to hold you.”

I swallow around the emotions clogging my throat. Before, Quinton was kind in this sick and twisted way, but now, he’s opened himself up, showing me a new side to him, and the effects of it all have me in a jumbled knot of emotions.

I don’t know how I’m ever going to find my way back to normal. Quinton walks into the bathroom, his footsteps heavy. He closes the door behind him, and I climb back into bed, tugging the covers up and over my body. I listen as the shower turns on and stare at the bathroom door waiting for him to come to bed.

After a while, my eyes start to grow heavy, but it’s then that I hear the water being turned off, and suddenly, I’m wide-awake again. My stomach tightens into a knot when the door opens, and Quinton comes walking out with a towel wrapped around his waist. I don’t know where we stand or what happens next.

All I know is I need his support more than I want to admit. When he reaches the edge of the bed, his intoxicating scent fills my nostrils.

“You smell good,” I say.

I squeak when he drops the towel to the floor and reaches for me, pulling back the covers and tugging me to the edge of the bed. His hands grip onto my sides, and he leans into me, his nose pressed against my neck right over my pulse.

“What kind of man does it make me to want to fuck you right now? Even after knowing everything you’ve been through?” His voice is thick, and the way his nose skims over my skin makes me shiver. My nipples harden, but the idea of letting him fuck me or even touch me in a sexual manner makes me sick to my stomach.

“I know you want me, and I want you too, but I...” My voice trails off, my throat tightening, refusing to let me finish my statement out of fear that he might leave. I want his presence. I *need* it.

He pulls back, and even with nothing but the sliver of moonlight coming in through the huge window above his bed, I can still make out the chocolate brown of his eyes and the hard contours of his face. He looks conflicted, and I want to tell him that it’s okay. I understand, but I can’t seem to get my mouth to produce words.

Something in his features changes upon looking at my face, and he snaps, pulling away from me, and the absence of his warm body leaves me cold.

“I’m sorry. I don’t know what the fuck I’m thinking. After everything you’ve been through, what those fuckers did to you. I’m just another fucking monster...”

He stomps over to his closet and disappears inside. My heart leaps from my chest, and I find myself scurrying out of bed to follow him. I refuse to let him think such a thing. Maybe there was a time when he hurt me and used me for his own twisted pleasure, but he never, not once, hurt me like Matteo did.

Lights illuminate the inside of the closet, and I have to blink a couple of times to adjust to the brightness. Looking straight ahead, I find him pulling

on a pair of boxers. His nakedness doesn't bother me, not when I've seen him many times like this.

"You aren't a monster. You're nothing like them. Please don't compare yourself to the..." I want to say people, but they aren't people. They aren't even humans in my eyes. "Bastards who hurt me," I continue, finally finding the right words.

Quinton shakes his head, strands of black hair go flying while some rest against his forehead. I notice the water droplets clinging to the strands and the way they shimmer in the light. His eyes shine bright, and his lips are turned down in a frown. He looks manic, violent, like he's ready to slaughter all over again. I want him to, I want him to bring them back to life and kill them all over and over again because even though I'm not a violent person, they deserve to suffer, to bleed out, and be brought back to life again and again.

Quinton crosses the space between us and cradles my cheek in his hand. His touch is gentle, and I lean into it, wanting it to heal me like a soothing balm.

"I might not be the type of monster they were to you, but I'm still a monster nonetheless."

This strange feeling overcomes me. My heart suddenly feels like it's going to burst out of my chest. Turning, I press my lips to his palm, the touch of my lips against his hand, the same hand that drew out their pain, that sought out revenge for me. A bolt of heat zips across my lips, igniting a fire between us.

I look up, peering into Quinton's eyes as I speak. "You're my monster. My protector. You stood up for me, even killed for me, and that's something no one has ever done... and probably never will again."

His gaze softens, the contours of his face relaxing. "No one will ever hurt you again, Aspen. I vow, on my life, on my sister's, on my mother's lives, that no one will get to you ever again. So long as there's blood pumping through my veins and air in my lungs, I will protect you. Tell me you understand that? Tell me that no matter what happens in the future, you will remember that."

The urgency in his voice makes my lungs hurt, the air inside them evaporates, and I don't want to agree because I can't imagine Quinton disappearing from my life, but I know he'll always be here.

I nod my head, wanting to believe him so badly it physically hurts. I push onto my tiptoes and press my lips to his. As sick as being intimate makes me feel, this is different. This is deeper than intimacy.

He must be able to sense my desire because a moment later, the soft look in his eyes is replaced with darkness, and I can feel his walls coming back up. *Why is he shutting me out?*

"Let's get you to bed. You're still healing, and being up in the middle of the night isn't going to help you heal any faster."

"I had a nightmare," I announce, trying to direct the attention away from us. He drops his hand from my cheek and takes my hand into his instead. Without a word, he leads me back to the bed. He tucks us both beneath the covers, but not before pulling me into his side. His scent surrounds me, encompassing my entire body in a blanket of warmth. Snuggled deep in his arms, I feel safe, cherished, and not as broken as I felt earlier.

Quinton doesn't ask what my nightmare was about, and I don't know that I'd have the strength to recite it to him anyway. Right before I fall asleep, when my eyes are growing heavy, and the warmth of his body around me is doing funny things to my mind, I feel him press his lips to my ear and whisper, "I'll protect you from everyone and everything, no matter what. Always remember that."

And even though I shouldn't, I believe him because Quinton and I are so much more than enemies, so much more than the darkness and despair we share. We can both deny it all we want, but this has brought us closer, and I have no doubt Quinton will kill for me again and again.

QUINTON

I stay up all night, unable to let myself close my eyes any longer than the split second it takes me to blink. Aspen's warm body is sprawled out on top of mine, and my arms are wrapped around her torso, holding her in place.

Her head is on my chest with her cheek pressed against my bare skin. Her eyes are closed, and her face is relaxed, making her look innocent and peaceful. As if fate is laughing at us, her body molds to mine perfectly, fitting together like two missing puzzle pieces.

I wish we could stay like this forever, sealed in a bubble, hiding from the world where nothing can touch us. Tightening my arms, I draw her to me even closer, not wanting to think about what I have to do when she wakes up.

The thought of hurting her has my stomach in knots, but this is the best way. I have to push her away, whether I want to or not. Being with her puts my mother and sister in danger, and I can't let that happen.

My brain hurts from thinking about all the ways I could tell her. In the end, I know the right thing to do is end it quickly. I have to make her hate me. If she hates me, she'll forget about me and move on. If she keeps loving me from afar, she'll never be able to be happy.

The night ends before I'm ready. The sun rises, throwing rays of light through my dark curtains and into my room. I briefly watch specks of dust

dance in the air before drawing my gaze back to Aspen. The only upside about the early morning light is that I can see her face better now. I memorize every inch of her, every feature, and every curve.

Aspen stirs, her breathing changes, and I know she is about to wake up. Closing my eyes, I suck in a deep breath, letting her scent ground me one last time. Then I shove all my feelings down into the darkest corner of myself until I'm almost numb—because that's the only way I can force myself to do this.

I open my eyes and stare up at the ceiling as I push Aspen off my body. Instantly, I feel cold. Inside and out. A chill seeps deep into my bones, and I already know that I won't be able to shake that feeling for a long time, maybe not ever.

Shoving myself off the bed, I quickly grab the first thing I can find and get dressed. The rustling of bedsheets fills the room, followed by a tiny feminine moan that sends a lightning bolt straight to my cock.

Not a good time, asshole.

"Quinton?" Aspen's sleepy voice meets my ear, but I continue dressing like I didn't hear it. "Hey, are you okay?"

No, I'm not, and neither will you in a few seconds.

"You need to leave." I keep my tone even.

"What do you mean?"

"I mean, you need to get your shit together and go back to Corium. You can't stay here any longer." I can't even look at her while I talk, but I can hear the confusion in her voice.

"Your father said I can stay here—"

"I don't give a fuck what my father said. I don't want you here," I growl, shoving my feet into my shoes. "Get dressed and be gone by the time I get back."

"Quinton, stop. I know you don't mean that. Why are you doing this?" From the corner of my eyes, I watch her climb off the bed and come for me.

I know what I have to do next will kill her, as much as it's going to kill me to say.

"If I can't fuck you, you are no good to me."

She stops her approach, and I still can't bring myself to look at her, knowing the pain I would see and that I might not be able to keep up the lie if I do.

"That's not true." I know which part she is talking about, but I act like it's going over my head.

"If it's not true, then bend over and let me fuck you. Or at least get on your knees and suck me off." I've always been an asshole to her, but this reaches new heights. If I'm not already going to hell, I surely will for this. "Even if you could, I don't think I'd get it up after they fucked you."

Bile rises in my throat, and I know I have to get out of here now before I puke all over the floor. My stupid, treacherous heart is splitting in two, and the pain encompasses my entire chest.

"I know you don't mean that. Don't push me away, Quinton. I need you," Aspen pleads, her voice so small and fragile, and all I want to do is take it back. I clench my hands into tight fists, trying to contain the pain, the hurt, to stop myself from taking her into my arms and apologizing. This is for the best.

"I don't want to see you again, so hurry and get out." The lie leaves a bitter taste on my tongue. All I want is to see her, hold her, taste her. I want to have her in every way, but I can't. Instead, I force my legs to carry me out of the room, leaving Aspen behind.

Slamming the door shut behind me, I speed walk down the hall and into Adela's old room. After they raided the house, Mom put everything that wasn't broken back in its spot. It's not the same; it doesn't smell like it used to in here. I can't feel her presence lingering like I did before. Still, being here helps calm me.

I sit in the large bay window where Adela used to sit and read. The sun has fully risen now and has warmed the glass. I press my forehead to it, seeking

warmth, but my skin remains ice cold. I'm not sure how long I sit there staring out into the front lawn, but a car pulls up out front after a while.

A guard appears carrying a suitcase and places it in the trunk. My lungs burn from the lack of oxygen as I watch my father exit the front door shortly after with Aspen trailing behind. Her head is bowed, but her steps never falter. I suck a ragged breath into my lungs, watching my dad open the back door for her. She disappears inside, and my heart threatens to lurch out of my chest.

To my surprise, my father walks around and climbs into the back seat on the other side. I guess he's taking her to the airport.

The car takes off, driving down the long, winding driveway. I follow with my eyes until I can't see them anymore.

She's gone. The realization hits me like a ton of bricks. I won't be able to hold her tonight or any other night. I won't be able to run my fingers through her silky hair or watch her hazel eyes light up when I speak. I won't be able to feel her smooth skin or smell her flowery shampoo. *I lost her.* And even though I know I will keep her safe from a distance, I feel like someone died. I feel like I lost the best parts of me forever. The creaking of the door tells me someone else has entered the room. Looking away from the window, I find my mom standing in the doorway. Her tearful eyes find mine, and a sad smile tugs on her lips. She enters the room, closing the door softly behind her.

"I thought I might find you here." I pull up my legs, and she sits next to me on the bench. "I'm so sorry, Quinton. I know sending her away wasn't easy. I wish I could change the way things are. I wish I could make you feel better and take all your pain away."

"I know, Mom. It's okay. I'm going to be okay," I lie. Losing Aspen is indescribable. It's heartache and pain, but it's deeper than all of that. It's an ache that will never go away.

"Letting someone you love go is the hardest thing you will ever have to do."

“I don’t—” I can’t even say it out loud. Many lies have passed my lips today, but I can’t say this one out loud.

Fuck, I love Aspen.

I love her, and now I have to forget about her. I have to let her go to keep her safe, and keeping my mother and sister safe is the most important thing in the world.

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ASPEN

“*T*his is not the way to the airport,” I say numbly.

I should probably be freaking out. Xander Rossi is taking me somewhere, and I have no idea where or why, nor do I have a way to defend myself or call for help. I should be terrified, but I can’t bring myself to care about anything right now.

“It’s not, but my private airstrip is this way.”

All I can do is nod. I don’t have the energy to do much else.

“My plane will take you straight to Tacoma. Lucas will be waiting there for you with a helicopter.”

I nod again. Even though a thank you rests on the tip of my tongue, I can’t force one past my lips.

I could never have anticipated things would end this way. Nothing could’ve prepared me for the heartache Quinton’s words left behind even after all we have been through. I know he loves me. Deep down, I know he does. So why is he sending me away?

That’s the question running through my mind until the car comes to a sudden halt. I look out the window, realizing we have arrived at the airstrip, where a small private plane is waiting for us.

I don’t know why my hand is shaking as I reach for the door handle to get out of the car. I don’t feel cold or scared. No, I’m back to being numb.

“Aspen.” Xander’s voice booms through the car. I turn my head to look at him. “You are stronger than you think.”

It’s odd to have Xander Rossi giving me any kind of encouragement, and I wish I could appreciate it more than I am, but at this moment, all I can do is give him a final nod before exiting the car.

The driver has already grabbed my suitcase full of stuff that doesn’t even belong to me. Honestly, I’m not sure what the maids packed while I was sitting on the bed like a zombie.

Ignoring the harsh winter wind, I climb the narrow staircase and walk onto the plane. I take a seat in one of the comfortable leather chairs and buckle up.

The plane takes off shortly after. For the most part, I’m left completely alone in the cabin. A stewardess comes to my seat asking me if I want anything to drink or eat a few times, but I can’t get anything down. Even the few sips of water I take sit heavy on my stomach. By the time we land in Tacoma, I don’t feel any better, not that I thought I would.

Just as Xander told me he would, Lucas is waiting for me at the airport. He takes my suitcase, and we walk toward the waiting helicopter. Besides a quick hello, Lucas hasn’t tried to make conversation, which I am grateful for. I’m sure Xander has already caught him up on everything anyway.

The helicopter takes us back to Corium. As we approach, I look down onto the snowy surface where the university is nestled into the mountain.

Memories of Quinton and I being out there in the forest enter my mind. He came for me then, gave me my first kiss, and brought me back to Corium. It might’ve hated me, but he didn’t want me dead. We shared so many moments, and now that’s all I have left. Memories from a time when we were something between enemies and friends. Whatever we were, it was better than what we are now.

We land on the helipad smoothly. The propellers are still spinning above when we exit into the unforgiving Alaskan air.

I wrap my arms around my body, pulling the jacket tight as I watch Lucas drag my suitcase out of the helicopter.

“I can get it from here.” I reach for my luggage, but Lucas shakes his head.

“I’ll take it. I’m going to show you to your new room.”

“What do you mean, *new* room?” He is mistaken if he thinks I’m going back to a shithole like before. “I’m done being pushed around. I’m going to *my* room, the one where I was before I left.”

“I’m sorry, Aspen. We already moved you into a new room.”

“I’m not going back—”

Lucas holds up a hand. “We’re not downgrading you. You’re going to like your new place. It’s really more of an apartment than a room.” He smiles.

“What’s so funny?” Is this a joke to him?

“Nothing is funny. I’m just happy for you. A lot of people in your shoes would be broken right now, meek and scared. You went through a lot, but you came out on the other side stronger.”

“I’m not stronger...” At least I don’t feel like it. “My bullshit meter just runs on low.”

I’m still not happy about being moved again, but I guess that’s better than living in a janitor’s closet like I used to.

I follow Lucas into the underground tunnel leading to the dorms. When we get to the elevator, he pushes the level B button. I didn’t even know there were student rooms on that level.

“I thought B was for staff only?”

“It is. You’ll be the exception.”

“Why are you moving me there?”

“We agreed it will be safer for you to be away from the other students.”

“We? You mean Xander? Is he the reason Quinton is acting this way? Is Xander trying to keep us apart?” Of course, he is. I was so wrapped up in my pain that I didn’t see the obvious. Quinton loves me; he wouldn’t do something like this without being told to.

“Quinton was the one who called me and asked that you be moved. I agreed with him, knowing after everything that happened, it would be best for you.”

“Best for who?” I mumble the question just as the elevator doors open. We step out into the hallway on a new floor, where I’ve never been before. Everything looks mostly the same. Except the doors are farther apart, indicating that the living quarters are larger than on the student floor.

“Brittney hasn’t returned from winter break, but her place is this door.” He points at the door we pass. “Yours is next to hers.” Under any other circumstances, that would make me happy, but today, I can’t muster up a single ounce of happiness.

We stop in front of what I assume to be my new room, and Lucas pulls a key card from his pocket. He slides it through the lock, disengaging it with a low beep.

He pushes the door open and pulls my suitcase inside. I follow him and quickly scan the inside of my new home. It’s surprisingly large, an open space floorplan with a living room and kitchen combo.

“The bedroom and bathroom are through here. The kitchen is fully stocked with food, but if you need anything else, you can let me know, and I’ll have it delivered to your room.”

“You don’t want me to go to the cafeteria?”

“I’d rather you stay here.”

“You know I still have to go to classes, right?”

Lucas cringes, or at least it looks like a cringe. “Actually... you don’t.”

“What’s that supposed to mean?”

“You will have classes, but not with the rest of the students. You will have private classes with me, Brittney, and Dr. Lauren.”

My face deadpans. I don’t even know what to say to that.

“I’ll give you an extra week to recover. You’ll start your classes next Monday.”

“I guess.” I fold my arms in front of my chest.

“Unpack, relax, and let your body heal.”

“It’s not my body I’m worried about,” I say out loud before I can stop myself. “Never mind.”

“You are stronger than you think,” he says, and I wonder if he and Xander have rehearsed together since he used the same words. “It might not seem like it today, but you are.”

“I’m still going to the library and the sunroom. I can’t spend all my time in this apartment.”

“Agreed. Also, you’ll meet Dr. Lauren for classes at the lab, and classes with me will be either at my office or at the gym. I’ll come up with a schedule for you. Email me if you need anything.”

Lucas exits my room, leaving me alone in this new room with a suitcase full of stuff that isn’t even mine.

A few months ago, I would’ve killed for this arrangement, but now I just want to go back to how things were before.

I want to go back to drinking weird-tasting protein shakes in the cafeteria, dodging students in the hallways, and sitting in the back of the class to avoid my teacher’s wrath. I want all of that just so I can feel the tiniest bit of normal again.

But I guess that’s the hardest part about all of this.

Nothing is ever going to be like it was before.

QUINTON

Leaving North Woods after the winter break felt like both a relief and a burden. Relief that I'm back at Corium and closer to Aspen, yet a burden because I had to leave my family behind. Now I only have Ren and the daily updates Lucas gives me on Aspen.

I haven't installed cameras in her new room, mostly because I'm scared of seeing her. Being scared is something I've experienced few times in my life, but I can't help feeling it now. I'm scared of seeing her hurt, unable to go to her and calm her. I'm scared of seeing her happy, seeing her move on without me. I'm scared she'll forget what we shared... forget about me.

According to Lucas, she's been adjusting well, everything considered. It's me who can't get a fucking grip. The only thing keeping me sane is knowing that Aspen is safe.

My father promised me she would be sheltered and well taken care of, and he has never broken a promise to me.

The silence of the living room breaks when the front lock disengages and the door swings open. Light filters in from the hallway, and Ren's silhouette appears in the entrance.

"Quit being a weirdo and turn on the light when you sit on the couch," Ren snaps. "Do weird stuff in your own room."

I don't even reply. Witty comebacks remind me of Aspen, and since I'm avoiding everything Aspen, I avoid those as well.

“Are you going to stay cooped up in here, or are you actually joining humanity sometime this year?”

“I’m fine right here.” I shrug.

I’ll never admit it out loud, but I’m depressed. I’ve only left my room once since I got back a week ago. I won’t even go to the gym since that’s also a place that reminds me of the one I’m supposed to forget.

“Well, you’re missing out because Billy brought his tattoo gun, and while normally, I would avoid anything that isn’t professionally done, he’s actually pretty good and clean.” Ren pulls up his shirt, showing me a large tattoo covering his rib cage.

“Jesus,” I mutter as I take in the intricate ink decorating part of his torso. It’s an angry-looking black and gray wolf surrounded by a forest that seems to be closing in on him. Behind the wolf is a colorful night sky with shades of dark purple and navy blue. In the center of the sky sits a large bright moon, and I know exactly why it seems like the moon is the highlight of the tattoo. *Luna*.

“I got this for my sister,” Ren confirms. “I’m the wolf, angry, protective, and without color. She is the light, making everything around her bright and beautiful.”

“Damn, that is good. Where is Billy now?”

“In his room, but I think he’s done tattooing today.”

“He’s done when I say he is.” I shove off the couch and strut past Ren. “I’m getting a fucking tattoo.”

“Whatever gets you off this couch and out of this apartment. I’m gonna Skype home.”

“Tell them I said hi,” I utter absentmindedly before shutting the door behind me. My thoughts are already swirling around the tattoo I’m getting as I walk down the hall to Billy’s room.

I knock but don’t wait for someone to answer before I simply waltz in.

Billy is sitting in his bed, looking like he is about to yell at me. His mouth shuts as soon as he realizes who I am.

Next to him, I spot Nash with his sleeve rolled up, and his forearm glistens with the ointment rubbed into a fresh tattoo.

“Hey, man,” Billy greets me. I’ve never really talked to him before, and he seems a little uneasy having me in his room now, but I don’t really care what he feels.

“I’m here for a tattoo,” I announce. “You done with Nash?”

“Yeah, he just touched mine up. He’s all yours.”

“I’ll have to clean everything and get a new set of needles. Give me ten minutes.”

I’m about to tell him he’s got five, but then I remember this might not be something I want to rush him about.

“What did you get?” I ask Nash, who proudly shows off the small 3x3 inch tattoo on his forearm.

“Family crest. What are you getting?”

“I want a bear on my arm to cover the scar.”

“Cool idea,” Billy chimes in. “I can definitely draw up something badass. Wait, didn’t a bear give you that scar?”

“Yeah, that’s kind of the point. I thought it would be fitting.”

“Agreed. Why did you go out there?”

“Yeah, Quinton, why did you?” Nash asks. “Not because of Aspen, right?” he taunts, and I’m two seconds away from ripping his throat out for saying her name. “Where is she anyway? Haven’t seen her around since I got back.”

“Lucas decided it’s better to keep her away from the rest of the students. I guess he finally got it through his head that she doesn’t belong with us.”

“A little too late.” Nash shakes his head.

“What’s that supposed to mean?”

“Don’t you think it’s suspicious that Matteo’s entire family disappeared?”

“What does that have to do with Aspen?” I ask, playing dumb.

Nash shrugs. “I’m just saying Matteo had it out for Aspen. Then his family disappears?”

I barely manage to contain my anger by simply hearing his and her name in the same sentence. “Exactly, he had it out for her, but all she did was avoid him. Nothing actually happened.”

“You don’t think Matteo did more than just *try* to get her?” Nash’s words rattle something deep inside me. An uneasy feeling creeps up my spine. Does he know what Matteo did to Aspen?

No, he can’t. I shake the thought away. There is no way he could have known... unless Matteo sent him one of the videos. *Fuck*.

Keeping my face neutral, I hide all my internal turmoil. “Plus, how the fuck is one girl going to make a whole crime family disappear?”

“Obviously, she had help.”

“Who would help her? She’s a nobody. *Persona non grata* in our world.” For the first time since I got back, I’m glad about the way my father has set everything up. Staying away from Aspen is protecting her as well as my family.

“Um, okay.” Billy tries to join our tense conversation. “I’m done cleaning. Gonna start drawing up your tattoo.”

“I’m heading to my room,” Nash explains as he gets up from the bed. “Thanks for the tattoo, Billy. I see you around, Quinton.”

“See you around,” I mutter, but on the inside, I imagine wrapping my hands around his throat. I need to get him off Aspen’s trail, no matter what. I won’t break my promise to her. I’ll keep her safe.

As soon as Nash is gone, I turn to face Billy. “Listen up. You will tattoo exactly what I tell you to, and you will not tell anyone about this, or I swear

I will find someone you care about and kill them. Got it?”

“Got it,” Billy answers without thinking, nodding his head furiously.

“Great, now start drawing. This is what I want...” I give him a detailed description of the bear I want, and he uses his iPad to draw it just like I asked. I have to give it to him. He is talented and able to create an image just as I imagined it.

Once he’s done, he prints out the design on transfer paper and places it on my arm. “Looks good like that,” I confirm, and he starts his tattoo gun a few seconds later.

The needle starts penetrating my skin, and though I find it uncomfortable, it doesn’t hurt like I thought it would. It’s more of an annoyance than actual pain, which is disappointing. I was actually looking forward to an ache other than the one in my chest.

The buzzing of the tattoo machine dancing over my skin is almost soothing. Minutes turn into hours before I know it. Billy doesn’t ask any questions or try to make small talk, which I would’ve shut down immediately anyway.

While he finishes the shadings, I decide to pull out my phone and text my father.

ME: Nash is snooping around Aspen. He thinks she has something to do with the disappearance of the Valentine family. Can you find out if a video was sent to him?

Dad: I’ll see what I can do. Meanwhile, tread lightly. Nash’s father, Nathaniel Brookshire, is one of the founding members of Corium.

“*FUCK.*” How did I not know about this? I tuck my phone back into my pocket.

“Almost done.” Billy pours some green liquid soap onto a paper towel and rubs it down my arm. The excess ink wipes away, letting me see all the

small, detailed lines better.

“There’s a mirror on the bathroom door if you want to check it out.” He nods toward the door.

I stand, my legs stiff from sitting still for so long. I walk over to the mirror and take a closer look at my arm.

The fierce-looking bear looks realistic from afar, but close up, it looks almost abstract, with harsh lines that shouldn’t be there but somehow belong. His fur turns into an angry pattern, which perfectly hides the name I asked him to integrate.

Aspen.

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ASPEN

People keep telling me how strong I am, but if they could see what is going on in my head, they wouldn't say such things. The bruises on my skin have faded, but an ugly darkness remains inside me that continues to grow. It sticks to my insides like black tar, coating my feelings and thoughts, no matter how mundane they are.

I shower quickly, feeling vulnerable and exposed while naked. So far, I have avoided looking in the mirror every time I'm in the bathroom. But today, I built up the courage to force myself to.

I showered in such haste that the mirror didn't even have time to fog up. I plant my feet right in front of it to see my entire body. With trembling fingers and a thundering heartbeat, I reach for the towel and undo the knot at my chest.

The fluffy white towel slides off my body and lands in a heap at my feet. I suck a ragged breath into my lungs and let my gaze roam over every inch of skin.

For the most part, I look normal. The black and blue areas have returned to a normal skin color. The only marks remaining are thin red lines around my wrists, and I'm pretty sure those marks are scars that will stay with me permanently.

Frowning, I turn but continue looking in the mirror to see my backside. At first glimpse, all I see are the marks on my lower back and butt. Crisscross

lines, some wider than others.

My throat clogs up as I vaguely remember someone hitting me with a belt. Oddly, I don't clearly remember the situation, but the memory of the pain is clear.

My eyes trail up the rest of my back, smooth and unblemished until I reach my shoulder. Leaning into the mirror, I inspect the skin and find an oval-looking scar. It takes me a moment to realize that the two crescent scars are a bite mark. As soon as I do, the unwanted memory floods my mind.

"I told you I would have you, Aspen. I promised to take every one of your holes, to mark you, and to make you pay for being such a bitch to me," Matteo grits into the shell of my ear.

His meaty fingers dig into my hips, holding me in place as he forces his dick inside me. Internally, I scream at him to stop, but the only sound to make it past my clogged throat is a low, pitiful whimper.

"You do have a nice cunt, nice and tight. Though it might not be that way when we're done with you. Do you think Quinton will want you back once you're all used up, my cum dripping out of your pussy and ass?"

I try to shake my head, but even that takes too much effort. The drug they gave me doesn't only fog my mind but keeps my body helpless as well.

"Answer me!" Matteo demands while pounding into me from behind so hard I feel like I'm being ripped in two. "Answer!" he yells again. Doesn't he know what the drugs are doing to me? I couldn't answer him even if I wanted to.

Then I feel it, his mouth on my shoulder, his teeth sinking into my skin. Pain burns across my skin. Even in my drugged-up state, I know he is biting deep enough to leave his mark. A permanent scar to remind me of him and what he's done to me.

The foggy memory slowly fades, and reality sinks in again. I guess he got what he wanted. Tears build behind my eyes, but I blink the moisture away. He doesn't deserve any more of my tears. None of them do. Not even my parents.

Leaving the bathroom, I enter the bedroom and rummage through the closet to find some comfortable clothing to put on. It's then that I notice the suitcase sitting in the back of the closet. When I arrived at Corium, I didn't bother to go through the suitcase, but now that it's staring me in the eyes, I feel the need to. I'm not even sure what could be in it.

Grabbing the handle on the suitcase, I tug it out of the closet and drag it across the floor. I stare at the suitcase for a long moment. Time has moved at a snail's pace since I left there.

Every day and night, I find myself thinking of Quinton. We can't be together, even after all we've been through, and I know it's better for my heart if I pretend he doesn't exist but looking at this stupid thing takes me back to that night in his bedroom when he told me he'd protect me no matter what.

The aching in my chest makes it hard to breathe, but I force myself to calm down and unzip the suitcase. I flip it open and find a white box sitting on the contents. Curious, I open the box, my fingers trembling. Inside is a brand new iPhone, and I clutch the device to my chest for a moment.

Going without a phone for the last couple of weeks has sucked. I mean, I don't have anyone to talk to, but that's beside the point. I press the little button on the side of the phone and wait patiently for the screen to load.

While I wait, I look through the rest of the suitcase and find another box. I pull the lid off, and my heart sinks into my belly. I wasn't sure what I would find, but I never would've guessed it would be Adela's bracelet. The rose gold bracelet with the intricate charm glitter in the light, and my lips turn up at the sides, the feeling almost foreign.

A tiny piece of paper slips out of the box when I pluck the bracelet out. I grab it out of the air and unfold it as quickly as possible without tangling the bracelet, which isn't easy.

As soon as the paper is unfolded, I wish I hadn't opened it all.

SHE WOULD WANT you to have this to remind you how strong you are.

-Q

LIKE A PIECE OF SHATTERED GLASS, I've barely held myself together and the note—the words written on it, and their meaning—send all the fractured pieces of my heart into space.

I take the bracelet and the phone over to the bed, leaving the clothes Quinton's mom packed me in the suitcase. Putting the bracelet on the nightstand, I collapse down on the bed and ignore the wetness on my cheeks. I'm crying and all because of a note.

I swipe at the falling tears and navigate the new phone, which is already set up for me. I'm tempted to text Quinton and tell him thank you, but one, I don't have his number, and two, it's not a good idea.

He wants nothing to do with me, and it's best if we stay away from each other. Still, every inch of my body aches to be with him. Ignoring the ache, I focus on something else and instead start going through the phone. When I reach the contacts, I smile again.

Ella's number is programmed into the phone. I can't help but send off a thank-you text to her. She has no idea how much she helped me. A second later, the phone chimes, alerting of a text from Ella.

ELLA: You're welcome, Aspen, and if you need anything, send me a text or call. I'm always here for you.

I DON'T DESERVE their help, not after all that my father's done, but somehow, they find the compassion to care. It's not that I'm not grateful for it, but it also puts things in perspective.

They have experienced trauma much greater than mine. They've lost a child they watched grow up, just to witness her die in front of their eyes. I can't even comprehend the pain Ella and Xander must have gone through... what they are still going through.

Clutching onto Adela's bracelet, I promise her and myself to be as strong as people keep telling me I am. I will be strong to honor Adela's life and that of the child who never had a chance to be born.

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QUINTON

Staring at the screen, I listen to my father talk even though all I want to do is swipe the computer off my table. “You said you were going to take care of it.”

“I said I’d see what I could do,” my father corrects me. “The hacker I talked to said he can’t do it unless he is there. And I can’t just let this random geek into Corium.”

“So are you saying it can be done if someone is close to the phone?”

“That’s what the guy said.”

“All right then, never mind. I know what to do.”

“Quinton, wait—” My father tries, but I cut him off by closing my laptop. I’m jumping up from my chair at the same time, not wanting to waste another moment.

Rushing past Ren in the living room, I’m out the door and heading to the library.

Purposely, I choose to go the long way to get there, not wanting to risk running into Aspen. When I get to the top part of Corium, I realize I haven’t seen the sun in too long. I have to squint my eyes just to stand the blinding light.

Once I get to the library, I stand at the door for a minute, listening for any voices. Wanting to make sure that Aspen is not already here. I don’t hear

anything, so I slowly make my way around the bookshelves. It doesn't take me long to find the blue-haired librarian walking the aisles. Luckily for me, she seems to be by herself.

As soon as I step into her line of sight, she jumps two feet back and throws her fists into the air like she is about to fight me.

"Calm down, champ. I'm just here to talk, not for a boxing match."

"Sorry, I'm a little jumpy. What can I do for you?"

"Wow. I didn't know you had it in you to be nice to me."

"I still don't particularly like you, but I know you took care of Aspen after what happened, so I dislike you a little less than before."

"Good. Remember that while I ask what I'm about to—"

"No! The answer is no, Quinton. I'm not hacking anything for you right now. Phoenix is catching onto me. I barely avoided him last time. As a matter of fact, I literally just got here and haven't even unpacked."

"This is local. All I need you to do is hack into a student's phone."

"That would be highly unethical."

"And it would be conducive in keeping Aspen safe."

"Don't use her to get what you want."

"I'm not. I have to know if Nash Brookshire knows anything about that night Aspen was taken. He accused Aspen of having something to do with Matteo's family's sudden disappearance."

"Fuck."

"Exactly."

"Okay, okay! I'll do it, but you have to get out of here now. I'll get close to him tonight in the cafeteria. As long as he has his phone on him, I can clone it. I'll text you tonight."

“Do you need my number?” Instead of answering me, she places her hand on her jutted-out hip and glares at me like my comment offends her. “Never mind. Don’t tell Aspen about this.”

Brittney frowns. “You shouldn’t keep secrets if you want to work out whatever’s going on between you.”

“Nothing is going on. I haven’t even seen Aspen in two weeks.”

“What? Why? I thought she stayed with you.”

“She did until she healed enough to come back here.”

“So let me get this straight. There is nothing going on between you two, but you risked your life to save her, you killed for her, and now you’re still protecting her?”

“What I do and why I do it is not your concern.”

“You made it my concern when you asked me to help.”

“There is a lot of shit going on that you don’t know. Just do it, okay?”

Brittney sighs. “Fine, as long as you are telling the truth about keeping Aspen safe.”

I give her a nod, but I get the feeling she still isn’t convinced. “I swear, keeping her out of harm’s way is my only concern.”

“You’re lucky I believe you.” She wrinkles her nose at me. “Now, get out before she drops by.”

“Thank you.” I rarely thank people for anything. I simply expect them to do shit for me, but I actually do appreciate her a lot and not just for hacking Nash’s phone. If it wasn’t for her, Aspen would be on her own. Brittney has been a good friend to her, and Aspen needs one now more than ever.

I make my way back through the quiet main floor of the library, my thoughts swirling around my next three steps in an effort to keep Aspen safe without drawing attention to my family.

Just as I step into the underground tunnel leading back to the dorm, my eyes catch sight of a head full of sunshine-colored hair. Aspen looks up, her gaze

locking with mine.

My step falters, and I'm frozen in place for a moment. My chest aches, the stupid thing below my rib cage longing for the girl in front of me. She is so close, yet so fucking far away.

"Don't look at me like that. You're the one who isn't supposed to be here. The library is my spot, remember?"

"That deal is off the table, and you know it. You have nothing to offer me anymore."

"Stop lying, Quinton. If this is about you wanting to fuck me, then let's go. Take me to your room and fuck me." I know she is bluffing, but shit, my cock gets hard at the prospect.

"Shut up. You couldn't handle it."

"Try me. Let's go." She reaches for me, and I'm so stunned by her actions that I don't even flinch when she grabs a fistful of my shirt and tries to drag me down the hall.

"Aspen, stop," I warn, but that only makes her pull harder.

"No!" She pulls hard enough to actually make me move. "You want to fuck, so let's go fuck."

"Last warning, stop pushing." My voice takes on a sharp edge, but she stays determined to make her point, so I have to make mine. Grabbing her wrist, I spin her around and shove her against the closest wall.

She gasps, her body goes rigid, and when I glimpse her eyes, I don't miss the fear flickering there. I've probably already scared her enough, but I decide to drive it home by wrapping my fingers around her slender throat.

"Is this what you want?" I grit my teeth, forcing my body to hover over hers in a threatening manner instead of pulling her into my arms.

"Yes," she whimpers. "I want this. If this is the only way I can have you."

Fuck.

I squeeze my eyes shut because if I look at the anguish in her beautiful face for another second, I will give in. I will forget every reason we shouldn't be together, throw her over my shoulder, and take her to my room where I'll lock her in and never let her go.

"We can't," I whisper, more to myself. Pressing my forehead against hers, I let my fingertips dance over the smooth skin on her neck. We are both breathing heavy. Emotions clog my throat, and I have to force the air past.

"I miss you," she croaks, and all I want to do is tell her the same. I have to remember what's at stake.

"Don't. You need to forget about me."

"I can't. I love you." Her words slice through me like a hot blade, burning my insides without killing me—because death would be the easy way out. This is worse than death, so much worse.

A part of me knew she loved me, just as I love her, but hearing those three little words spoken out loud somehow makes it worse. It makes it real. Now that the words are out, I can't pretend they don't exist.

"I could never love you." The words leave my mouth, but they don't sound like mine. They belong to some stranger, a shadow without a face.

"Why are you lying?" The anguish in her voice cuts deeper than I expected. I'd prepare myself to see her, but obviously not well enough.

"You're the one lying if you think we can be together." I suck in a breath, wanting to breathe her in, taking in as much as I can of her scent. Letting my hand fall from her neck, I push away from the wall and turn my back to her.

"Don't make this harder than it has to be."

"I don't think that's possible."

It takes an enormous amount of restraint to walk away, and I'm only barely able to. Everything inside me wants to turn back and comfort her... wants to tell her I love her too.

ASPEN

*M*y heart lurches in my chest, each beat thunderous and bleeding. With every step I take, I hear his voice in my mind.

“You need to forget about me.” Like I could ever do that.

“I could never love you.” Like he doesn’t already. I know he’s lying. I know he’s only trying to protect me.

From what, I’m not sure, but he thinks keeping us separated resolves our problems when it’s the last thing either of us needs or wants. It’s pathetic how long I stood in the tunnel staring at his retreating frame, wishing and willing him to turn around.

He didn’t. He never even wavered. I can’t help but wonder if there is a way to make him return to me. I swipe at my watering eyes, blinking back tears. Today cannot and will not end in tears.

A couple of students pass by me on their way to class, but they just keep their heads down and continue walking.

Ahead is the entrance to the library. The huge brown doors are open, beckoning me inside. I exhale as I walk in and breathe deeply through my nose, letting the feeling of being *home* resonate through me. I’ve missed this place so much.

“Aspen!” Brittney calls. “Just the person I was looking for.” Her lips are pulled up into a mammoth-sized smile.

She's standing behind the big circular desk. I continue deeper into the library until I reach her, and Brittney comes running around the desk. Her body collides with mine, and she wraps thin arms around my middle, hugging me tight to her chest. I let out a gasp. Her sudden assault on me causes the air in my lungs to wheeze out between my teeth, but I hug her back. She has no idea how much I needed this.

"I'm so glad you're okay. As soon as Lucas told me what happened, I tried to contact you. Last I heard, you were staying with Quinton and his family." The words rush from her lips, and when she pulls away and looks me in the eyes, I can feel the walls I built up crumbling.

"What exactly did Lucas tell you?" I ask.

"He told me what *they* did and that you were staying with the Rossis until you were healed."

My lips press into a firm line, and my throat tightens when I think about the baby. Our baby that never had a chance at life.

"All of that is true. I stayed with the Rossi's for a short while, and then once I was better, Quinton shipped me back here. We kinda sorta broke up; if you could really even consider us being together at all." I huff and finally look up to find Brittney staring at me.

The frown on her face deepens.

"What happened? What's going on? How can I help?" She asks all three questions at once, and all I want to do is tell her she can't help, that she can't make things go back to the way they were, but I don't.

I peer over my shoulder, scanning the library for any students within earshot.

"No one comes in here, and even if they did, it wouldn't be right now," Brittney adds, sensing my need for privacy.

Looking back at her, I let the words tumble out of me. "I... I just... I'm struggling a little bit, and I feel weak saying that, but it's the truth."

“If you want to talk about it, we can. I’m always here for you, and I’ll never judge you.”

A lump starts to form in my throat, and I swallow around it. I need to talk to someone about this, about our baby.

“Did you...?” I can feel the tears burning at the back of my eyelids. One blink and they’ll be set free. “Did you know...about... the baby?” My voice is nothing but a soft tremble.

The blood drains from her face, and she shakes her head.

“Oh, god. Aspen. I’m so sorry, honey.” My confession has visibly shaken her, and she wraps an arm around me, pulling me closer. “I’m sorry. I had no idea.”

The tears leak from my eyes without permission, and I clear my throat before speaking. “It’s okay. It’s not like everyone knows.” I brush off the pain. To fully acknowledge the loss would kill me. I’m not ready yet, but I need to talk about it. “I’m not dealing with the pain. I’m glancing over it. Every time I think about what could’ve been...” The pain in my chest intensifies, making it hard for me to breathe.

“I don’t think there is ever a perfect time to talk about loss. Healing happens on each person’s terms. If you aren’t ready, then you aren’t. It doesn’t mean there’s anything wrong with you.”

“But I feel like if I don’t talk about our baby, it never existed. That it was never important. I didn’t know I was pregnant, but that doesn’t change the fact that I wanted our child. I... we never even got the opportunity to know. They took that from us.”

I’m on the verge of cracking, but I know I’ll never be the same if I do. Maybe that’s what I need. To realize that the person I was before will never be me again. They took that away from me, and now I need to find myself again. I need to rise from the ashes and pave my own way.

“I know they did, and I’m sorry, Aspen. I’m sorry, and I wish I knew what to do to help you. I want to help you.”

“They’re all dead, Quinton made sure of it, but that doesn’t lessen the pain. How do I forget?”

Brittney shakes her head, and pieces of blue hair fall onto her face. I can see tears forming in her own eyes. “You don’t. The pain will lessen every day, but you will never forget it. Someday, it’ll be easier for you to talk about, but you’ll have to work to get there.”

I nod, knowing deep down that she is right. Healing isn’t an overnight process, no matter how much I wish it was.

My gaze drops to my stomach, the reminder of what should be. I hate the pain that slices through me like a dull butter knife and the ache in my chest at the thought of our unborn child.

“Do you think Quinton would be with me if I was still pregnant?” I ask while already knowing the truth.

“I think Quinton is in a rough spot. He wants to protect you, but he also wants to be loyal to his family. Having a child together would’ve brought you closer, but it wouldn’t have fixed your problems.”

I clench my jaw so hard my teeth grind together. “No, but it might have made him see that he really does love me. It might have made him want to be more than enemies.”

Brittney uses a finger to lift my chin, forcing me to look at her. “Quinton loves you; he loves you so much he killed an entire family for you. He loves you in a way that isn’t conventional, and I’ll bet all the money I’ve got that he’s doing this to protect you.”

“I don’t want his protection. I want to be with him.” I barely bite back a whine of disapproval.

“Sometimes, you don’t get a choice, honey.”

I hate that she’s right. That he gets to choose if he can love me or not, while every beat of my heart is for him. How can I continue forward when the person I want to be with, the person I need, doesn’t want me?



AFTER MY EMOTIONAL conversation with Brittney, I leave the library and go straight to the headmaster's office. His assistant doesn't even bat an eye at my presence, and I slip into his office like a ghost disappearing into the night.

I learned to knock before coming into Lucas's office after interrupting two conversations and getting scolded like a child. I reach the door to his office and raise my fist and knock on the heavy wood twice. When I don't get a reply, I shrug my shoulders, twist the knob in my hand, and push the door open. As suspected, the room is empty. The quiet is nice, but coming to Lucas's office makes me feel less alone. I've been using a small desk in the corner of the room.

I pull out my books, pens, notebook, and laptop. I do a variety of online and text work, which Lucas oversees.

Today, I'm studying for a test in biology. I've just cracked the book open and started reading when the door to the office opens. Startled, I jump in my seat; the pen slips from my hand and hits the table before rolling onto the floor.

Lucas steps into the room, his head held high, his perfectly tailored suit sculpted to his body like a second skin. Of course, he's handsome. Anyone with two eyes could tell you that, but I don't see him like that. To me, he is more like a fun uncle now. At first, he intimidated me, but now I see him for what he really is. Strong. Compassionate. Wants the best for those he cares about.

He stares at me with his lips pursed, an eyebrow raised in question. "Everything okay? You look like you've seen a ghost."

My heart clammers in my chest, and I reach down to grab the pen off the floor before answering him. "I'm fine, just a little startled, is all."

Actually, now that I think about it, I've been more anxious than usual, worried that I'm being followed or watched. I know Quinton says he wouldn't let anything happen to me, and I trust that he'll try. But he can't be everywhere at all times.

Lucas closes the door and walks over to his desk, shoving down into his leather chair. I turn in my chair to face him, feeling his dark gaze on the back of my neck. I can tell simply from the concerned look etched into his features that he has something he wants to say.

“What did I do now?” I bite the bullet and ask.

Lucas’s lips turn up on one side, making him appear youthful. “Who said you did anything? Do you have a guilty conscience, Aspen?”

I roll my eyes. “Of course not.”

“Are you sure?”

“Yes, why? Did someone say I did something? Or did something happen that I need to know about?” I try not to sound as concerned as I feel. I was finally calming down from his surprise appearance, and now he’s asking me questions that are leaving me paranoid.

The grin falls off Lucas’s face. “Nothing’s going on. I was just joking with you. I did want to talk to you about something, though...”

“Well...” I gesture to the space in front of us. “Go ahead.”

“I know we talked about it before, but I think you should talk to Dr. Lauren. You’ve been really jumpy lately, and not just today. I know you said you’d talk to her when you were ready, but I think it would be good for you. Give you a chance to talk about what happened.”

Internally, my mind is screaming, NO! The last thing I want to do is relive the worst moment of my life by retelling it. So even as I sit here wanting to scream the word at him, I simply say, “No.” Just like before, his brows draw together, and disappointment flickers in his eyes.

“Aspen, I don’t want to push you, but I think it would be good. Talking about what happened doesn’t make you weak.”

“I’ll talk to someone when I’m ready, and right now, I’m not ready,” I snap, and then force myself to take a calming breath. A few seconds pass, and I’m about to swallow my pride and apologize, but he interrupts the silence.

“I’m sorry. Normally, I don’t interfere in student lives, but I won’t lie... you’ve kind of grown on me, kid.”

“Grew like cancer?” I joke humorlessly.

“More like a weed,” Lucas quips, and I almost smile. “I’m worried about you.”

Throat tightening, I have to force the words out. “Don’t be. I’m okay. If I wasn’t... I’d let you know.”

“But would you really, Aspen?”

All I can do is shrug because I’m not sure what he wants for an answer. Tired of the focus being on my mental state and if I should talk to a doctor or not, I change the subject.

“I saw Quinton today,” I announce like I’m heading into war.

Like a disappointed father, he shakes his head. “You both need to stay away from each other. It’s for the best, even if you don’t believe it.”

“What’s for the best is to stop letting everyone else dictate our lives. We’re adults; let us make our own choices.”

“There’s no choice to be made, Aspen. He doesn’t want you, and you’re better off without him.”

The heat of embarrassment kisses my cheeks, and I twist back around in my seat. I stare down at my textbook and let my hair form a wall between us.

“I know it’s not what you want to hear, and I’m sorry, but you need to stay away from him.”

I don’t bother saying anything else. It’s not like my opinion matters, anyway. I’m nothing more than a chess piece in this world, the pawn on an endless board of moving parts when I should be the queen.

QUINTON

I'm no stranger to sitting in the dark. As a matter of fact, I prefer it. The silent night is my favorite time, letting my mind rest and my body calm. But normally, when I sit with the light turned off, there is still the time displayed on the microwave and the lonely green dot at the front of the TV. Even though those seem insignificant, they are enough to give the room some kind of shape in the darkness.

Ren's door flies open, and the hinges swinging the heavy door seem louder than usual.

"What the fuck?" Ren's sleepy voice booms through the room.

"The power went out, but the backup should take over any minute." Seconds tick by, but instead of the light turning on, the silence surrounding us becomes starker. The ragged breaths from our lungs and the faint thumping of our heartbeats are the only remaining sounds.

The missing sounds make me realize quickly that the light isn't our real problem. The power outage has turned off our air supply, and if the backup generator does not click on soon, the other students will notice if they haven't already.

"Something is wrong." Ren voices what I'm thinking.

"Yeah, the generator should have kicked in by now." I fish my phone from my pocket and unlock the screen. The dim light is enough to make my eyes

squint and eliminate most of the room. “No signal. So the towers are down as well. Most likely all of Corium, which is suspicious.”

Ren takes a few steps toward me. When I look up, I’m surprised to find him dressed already. “We need to get out of here before people panic.”

“Yes, but I need to make a pit stop on the way to the surface.”

“Her room is on the level above ours, and Lucas should be close. You don’t think he has already gotten her?”

“I can’t be sure. I’m gonna find her. You don’t have to come.” I don’t have to glance at my best friend to know he is probably rolling his eyes at me.

“Of course, I’m coming. Let’s go.”

We both slip on our shoes and jackets before leaving our room. The hallway is lit up by multiple phone flashlights from students piling out of their rooms, distressed murmurs, and questions filling the space.

Without saying it out loud, we move through the thickening crowd, past the elevator, and toward the staircase.

“Going somewhere?” Vito’s voice seems to come out of nowhere before he appears in front of me.

“Up,” I growl and move past him.

“I’ll join you,” he quips like we are friends about to hang out. I don’t even answer. I’m too obsessed with going up a level and making sure Aspen is safe.

Both Ren and Vito follow me as I climb up the stairs, taking two steps at a time. Ren is holding up his phone to give us enough light when we get to the door. Entering the staff hallway, it is apparent no one here has woken up yet.

I walk directly to Aspen’s door and start knocking.

“Should I be worried that you know where she lives?” Ren questions. He is one of the few people who knows why I can’t see Aspen. Putting my family in danger puts his family in jeopardy by association.

“No, but you shouldn’t be surprised either.” Of course, I know where Aspen is staying regardless of being able to see her or not.

When she doesn’t answer the door right away, my irritation grows, and I curse myself for not having a key card made already. I knock louder, hoping to wake her up before I realize she is probably awake already but simply not opening the door.

“Aspen, it’s me. Open up!” I yell through the heavy metal door.

It only takes a few seconds for the lock to disengage and the door to creep open. Aspen’s guarded face comes into view. Her large hazel eyes find mine, and even in the dim light, I can see the fear hiding within them. My gaze travels down her body, realizing she is already dressed.

“Why didn’t you wake up Lucas or Brittney?” My question comes out a little harsher than I mean it.

Aspen’s face turns from worried to annoyed. “I tried, smart-ass. They are not here or sleep very deeply, which I doubt, considering who we are talking about.”

“All right, let’s go upstairs. If the power doesn’t turn back on soon, we will run out of air.”

She steps out of her room and shuts the door behind her. I take a step back, not wanting to be so close to her because I know if I catch a whiff of her flowery shampoo, I’ll probably lose it and pull her into my arms.

I keep my distance for the same reason when we move back into the stairwell. Other students have caught on and are making their way to the surface. We climb the stairs until we get to the next level, where Lucas has his office.

“You guys keep going. I want to check on Lucas. If he isn’t in his apartment, he must be in his office.”

“I’m coming,” Aspen announces.

“No, you go up with Ren—”

“I’m coming,” Aspen repeats in a stern voice. “If Ren wants to carry me up the stairs, okay, but I’m not walking anywhere unless *I* want to.” The thought of someone else touching her, even Ren, has my blood boiling.

“Fine,” I growl, and without thinking, I reach for her hand. Before I can come to my senses, my fingers intertwine with hers, holding her with an iron grip. Tugging her along, I walk through the door and down the hallway to Lucas’s office.

I don’t turn around, but I can hear Ren and Vito following us as well, which only makes me pull Aspen closer. I trust Ren with my life, but I wouldn’t trust Vito to pour me a drink.

“Is that light coming from his office?” Aspen asks quietly.

“I think so.” I stare at the dim light peeking through the bottom crack of his door. “I guess that answers the question of where he is.”

I don’t bother knocking. He might not like us barging in, but I don’t have time for pleasantries. Keeping one hand wrapped around Aspen’s slender fingers, I grab the metal knob with the other, twist it, and push the door open.

Shocked, I look into the bright space. I figure Lucas has some lantern or other portable light source set up, but as we enter the room, it becomes very clear that I was wrong. It seems that his office is not affected by the power outage at all. Not only are all the lights on but Brittney is also sitting in front of a computer typing away like a mad scientist.

My eyes lock with Lucas’s; he hovers behind Brittney with his arms crossed over his broad chest wearing a stern expression. The wrinkles on his forehead appear even deeper than normal, and the usual frown on his lips looks grimmer than ever.

“What the hell is going on? Why do you have power?”

“We’re trying to fix it,” Lucas growls. His gaze drops to where my hand is holding Aspen, and his expression turns from grim to disapprovingly. Aspen must notice it, too, because she tries to pull away, but that just makes me hold on tighter.

Brittney is so zoned in on whatever she is doing on the computer that she doesn't even acknowledge us.

"You shouldn't be here. Follow the evacuation plan and continue upstairs to the castle."

"Not until you tell us what's going on," Aspen says, beating me to it.

Lucas glances past us to Vito and Ren. As if he is weighing his options on whether to tell us. After a moment, he huffs. "Someone is hacking into our system and has turned off the power everywhere besides this room, which runs on a different circuit."

"I've almost got him," Brittney murmurs, never looking up at us. Her fingers keep flying over the keyboard like it's an Olympic sport and she's pushing to get gold. "I'm going to kick him to the curb and keep his ass locked out."

Him. This has to be Phoenix.

"You need to go upstairs to the surface," Lucas orders. "Let her work. There's nothing you can do here anyway."

"What if she can't get him locked out?" I barely finish the sentence when Brittney lets out a loud snort, letting me know what she thinks about my doubt without words.

"Let's go." Aspen tugs on my hand. "She's got this one." I guess Aspen has more confidence in her friend than I do. Because there is no doubt or fear in her voice.

"Not a word to anyone about this," Lucas warns. "As far as the rest of Corium knows, this is a fluke power outage. I don't want to deal with panicked parents and students, nor do I want to do the fucking paperwork."

"Got it." We all agree before turning and heading back the way we came.

Since we were in the bright room for a few minutes, the hallway seems darker than before. The flashlight from Ren's phone barely lights our way.

Vito opens the heavy metal door leading back to the staircase, and we all pile into it. It is clear the other students must have all made it to the surface,

and we are the only ones left. I blame the eerie quiet surrounding us on the bad feeling brewing in my gut.

I should have known better.

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ASPEN

The explosion rocks me to the core, and my muscles tense as I try to stay upright. Quinton's steel-like grip around my waist is the only thing keeping me in place.

Heavy breaths escape me, and I find myself on the cliff's edge of panic. The world spins around me, and my ears ring from the aftermath of the blast. Dust and debris fill my lungs as I force air deep into my chest, just to cough it out in a fit.

I hear nothing but the low ringing in my ear. My body is numb, and all my senses are in disarray. I don't know where up or down is. Forget about left or right.

With a hammering heart, it takes a minute for me to open my eyes. Dust coating my lashes makes my eyelids heavy. Slowly, my body adjusts, and I get my bearings. I'm pushed against the wall, Quinton's body pressing me to the cold surface.

"You okay?" Quinton asks, his voice a low rumble in my ear.

"Yes..." The word wheezes past my lips.

We slowly peel away from the wall, scanning the small area surrounding us. Ren and Vito are only a foot away. Quinton exchanges a silent nod with his cousin before returning his attention to me.

Luckily, we were all on this side because what used to be the stairs going up is now nothing but rubble. Shocked, I realize we're surrounded by concrete. Both exits are blocked, leaving us stuck in a compact ten-by-ten space.

The realization hits me hard... there won't be any way for us to continue to the surface. Vito picks up his phone from the ground and shines up and down the staircase... or what's left of it.

"It's still moving," he whispers, probably more to himself because it's very obvious that it is. The floor we're standing on is still vibrating, and the sound of falling debris is heavy in the air.

"We can try moving it now before it settles." Quinton takes a step away from me, motioning for me to stay. If my legs weren't so weak from shock, I would follow him, but instead, I lean against the wall for support.

Squinting my eyes, I watch Quinton look up and down through the tiny remaining spaces.

I don't know what raises my alarm first—the sound of a heavy rock crumbling above us or the sudden shock of vibration? Either way, I act before I have time to think about it. I'm closing the space between us in a fraction of a second. Time slows, and my body acts on instinct.

My fingers dig into Quinton's dirt-covered shirt, and I shove him out of the way using my entire body weight. I slam into him with such force it could rival the hit of the large piece of rubble almost hitting Quinton.

The piece of concrete hits the ground at the same time we do. Quinton took the hardest fall, his back landing against the unforgiving ground while I land right on top of him.

My heart is racing, and I clutch onto Quinton, afraid he might disappear if I let him go. The thought of something happening to him terrifies me. He's one of the few people at this place who actually cares about me. Pressed against his firm chest, I let the sound of his rapid heartbeat calm me enough to pull away and look into his eyes.

A mixture of shock and anger flickers in his dark depths.

“What the hell was that?” he growls, his fingers digging into my skin with enough force to leave bruises.

“That big piece of concrete almost hit you.” My lungs are burning as I try to catch my breath. I can feel Ren and Vito’s eyes on us, and I’m sure they’re wondering if I’m crazy.

Pressing his forehead against mine, he whispers, “Don’t ever do something like that again. I almost lost you once. I can’t risk losing you again, and especially not because you tried to save me.”

“Don’t tell me what I can and can’t do,” I growl back.

“Fucking Christ, Aspen.” He shakes his head, sending locks of brown hair flying while some remain stuck to his clammy forehead. “The idea of losing you kills me. Don’t sacrifice yourself for me.”

Before I can respond, Ren interrupts. “You guys okay?”

“Yeah, we’re okay,” Quinton answers for both of us, his voice gruff. Gently, he eases me off his chest, and we both get up. I rest against the wall, trying to catch my breath. I’m shaken up but still alive, and that’s all that matters. I can feel Vito’s hot gaze on me and look up at him through my dust-covered lashes.

“What do we do now?” I ask, needing to break the tension.

“The stairs are a no-go, obviously, but we can follow the air vents up if we go back down one level.”

“At this point, I think that’s the only option we have.” Ren peers over at the door, where chunks of concrete block it. To get out of here, we will have to move them.

“Let’s hurry and move the concrete so we can get out of here before something else blows up,” Quinton urges and jumps into action.

I shiver at the thought of another bomb—or whatever that was—going off while we’re in the stairwell. We’d become trapped and die beneath the rubble. I blink the thought away and find Ren, Quinton, and Vito moving

the gigantic pieces of concrete out of the way. It doesn't take long for us to move the debris and get the door open.

"Let's stay together," Quinton adds as Ren opens the door.

"Sure, Dad." Ren scoffs and disappears on the other side.

Once we are all out of that cramped space, Quinton stays real close to me, as close as one can be without touching them. A shiver snakes down my spine. It's darker in the hallway; Quinton, Vito, and Ren pull out their cell phones and switch on the flashlights. Good thing they remembered their phones, unlike me.

It's hard to hear anything over the blaring of the siren, and it feels like déjà vu all over again.

The last time this happened was right before I left Corium... right before Matteo happened.

Anxiety spreads through my stomach like acid, burning my insides painfully. Forcing those dreadful thoughts away, I closely follow Quinton as we turn into an office. We all walk into the dusty room, and Quinton closes the door.

Vito grabs a chair and carries it over to the far side of the room. With the added height from the chair, he reaches the ceiling with no trouble. "Thank fuck, this isn't the type of vent screwed in," Vito says and pries the vent cover off the wall.

Using the flashlight on his phone, he pops his head into the duct and peers around.

"What exactly are you looking for?" Ren yells, and I have to wonder the same thing.

"Just want to make sure we're going to fit. It will be tight, but I don't think it'll be a problem. We'll have to climb up one by one."

Oh, god. I didn't anticipate how small of a space it would be. Panic wraps its clutches around me, immobilizing me with fear.

I can't do this. I can't.

“I’ll go first, and we’ll help each other up until everyone is in,” Vito announces. He easily climbs into the duct, his body disappearing in seconds.

My lungs burn as I hold my breath and watch Quinton gesture for Ren to go next. *Shit*. It’s almost my turn. My hands tremble, and black dots appear over my vision. Head swimming, I try to breathe through the panic, but it’s no good. It just sinks its claws deeper into my skin.

Aspen. I briefly hear my name being called, but it’s like I’m trapped beneath water and unable to respond. I look up from my hands and find Quinton standing in front of me. *Was he always this close?* His lips are moving, but again, I hear nothing, not a single word. I try to decipher what he’s saying, but I can’t.

Something cold and wet slides down my cheek. *Am I crying?* Fear and concern etch deep into the contours of Quinton’s face. He cups me by the cheeks and draws my face to his using both hands.

Nose to nose, chest to chest. I can feel his hammering heartbeat and see the passion and care for me in his eyes. He’ll never let anything happen to me again, he promised.

I can read the word *breathe* on his lips as he speaks, saying it over and over again until, eventually, his deep voice rumbles through the fog and into my ears. As soon as I’m free from the panic attack, I wrap my arms around him and crash my lips against his.

Shock ripples through me when he kisses me back. Heat blossoms in my belly, crackling, and for a moment, we’re suspended in time. We aren’t hiding what we share or what happened. We aren’t surviving. We’re us. Like all good things, it comes to an end, and the bubble pops, bringing us back to the present.

A soft sigh escapes my lips as Quinton breaks the kiss and presses his forehead against mine.

“We have to go, Aspen.” His voice comes out almost painful.

“I know,” I whisper back, wishing we could stay like this forever.

One second later, Quinton is pulling away completely. My insides churn when I look up at the open duct. I'm afraid, but I'm more afraid of dying in this school. Building up the courage and pushing the impending fear down, I climb onto the chair. I look back down at Quinton, and he gives me a half-smile.

"You can do it," he encourages, and I nod.

I look back up at the air duct and find Ren peering out of the hole, his hand extended toward me. He grins like an evil villain, and still, I place my hand in his, knowing that I've never been safer in my entire life.

I hold my breath while I'm being pulled up into the air duct and release it when Ren lets go of my hand. I wiggle into the small space on my hands and knees, catching sight of a scrunched-up Vito in front of me, who is peering over his shoulder.

Panic pricks at the back of my mind, so I force myself to take slow, shallow breaths.

"Coming up!" Quinton yells, his voice clearing some of the fog circling my brain. *You can do this.* I repeat to myself, wishing like hell this was already over. I've never been afraid of small spaces, but I'm not surprised after what happened. Vito and I crawl forward a few feet to make room for Quinton and Ren.

"You good?" Vito shouts, and the sound echoes all around me.

"Yeah, let's go," Quinton replies, and I peer over my shoulder to find him directly behind me.

The sides of his lips raise into a soft smile, and the panic recedes an inch. *Nothing's going to happen. Everything is okay.* Vito starts forward, and I do the same, counting backward from one-hundred in my mind, ignoring that the air duct seems to be closing in around me.

An eternity seems to pass, or maybe two, before anyone speaks again, and if I'm being honest, I'm not really sure how far we've traveled. Then I hear it, voices. Angry voices. Voices mean people, and people mean we can get out of this forsaken air duct.

“We’re getting close,” Vito announces.

I swallow down the lump of fear threatening to suffocate me and follow him. He moves a little faster now. The voices grow louder and louder, and when Vito stops altogether, I know we’ve made it.

“Back up a bit. I’m going to kick out the vent so we can get out of here,” he says. I crawl backward, giving him room so that he can roll over.

Once on his back, he uses his feet and the weight of his body to kick the vent open. One minute later, we’re climbing out of the vent. It’s about a five-foot drop, but anything is better than staying in the vent. I jump down right behind Vito. As soon as my feet touch the ground, I realize we’re in the castle’s upper level, where they had the founders’ ball.

Students and teachers huddle in small circles. Their eyes are suddenly on us. You can taste everyone’s fear in the air, and I don’t blame them for being afraid.

I think I’d be more worried if they weren’t scared. Someone tugs me by the arm, and I look up to find Quinton pulling me closer as a few students push through the body of students.

“What the hell is going on?” two students yell in almost unison while a flurry of whispers travels through the room. The air is thick enough to cut with a knife.

Scanning the crowd, I see a few familiar teachers trying to abate them, but if I’m being honest, they look just as terrified as the students.

“Okay, everyone, stay calm. The worst thing we can do is panic. All that matters is that everyone is safe,” one teacher yells over the rising voices of the students who are clearly being driven by fear.

“We’re being attacked. How can we be calm?” one fires back, and the conversation becomes full-on yelling a moment later.

I block it out and scoot closer to Quinton.

Vito and Ren stand beside Quinton and me, the four of us forming our own tiny circle. Even though we’re inside, there is a slight chill in the air.

“What the hell is going on?” Ren asks through his teeth. I watch his eyes as he scans the area as if he’s waiting for someone to jump out and attack us.

“It’s not like they’re lying; there was an unexplained explosion, and if someone tried to blow up Corium, we’re technically being attacked,” Vito comments, his voice low.

My own worries start to build as the students become angrier, and Quinton continues to remain silent. I have to do something, we have to do something because if the students turn on each other, on the teachers, this could get bloody.

Taking Quinton’s hand into mine, I squeeze it, forcing his attention to me. “We have to do something!”

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QUINTON

Too many thoughts swirl around in my head, almost like they're being pushed deeper into my brain by outside forces. I can't focus on one thing at a time with so much pressing in on all sides.

The growing noise makes it impossible, too. All I want is a way to keep Aspen safe. If it means making sure the rest of these assholes survive, so be it. I couldn't care less. First, they need to shut up so I can think.

This is about to turn into an ugly situation, with students shouting at teachers while other students try to step in and calm things down. Any moment now, fists will start flying.

Something has to stop this. The problem is, I'm unsure of what that will be.

Until Aspen takes my hand. Until she looks up at me with all the trust in the world. She needs me and believes I can fix things. I have no choice but to live up to that.

The scene around me goes from chaos to crystal clarity. The other students are still panicked, and the staff is at a loss for an explanation, but I'm able to see through it now. It's obvious what needs to be done. I release Aspen's hand before addressing everyone.

First things first. "Everybody, shut the fuck up!" My voice echoes in the enormous space until I'm bellowing. It's enough to silence the whining and accusations and demands as efficiently as if I flipped a light switch. Even the staff go still, eyes wide, mouths hanging open.

I turn to Vito. He's useless, but I'm willing to use him for my purposes. "Get a handful of people together and light the fireplaces. We need to warm this place up." Already my breath forms a thin cloud in front of my face.

His brows shoot up. "Who put you in charge?"

"You're lucky you didn't say that louder." I force a smile for the sake of those watching. "If you want to have a tongue by the time the night's over, you'll do what I say before shit starts falling apart again." The look I give him must convey my seriousness. He falls back a step as if remembering who he's dealing with.

"He's right," Ren agrees. "We can't hang around forever without doing something to stay warm."

Vito stalks off, choosing his crew and waving them aside. The questions fly fast and heavy, and I raise a hand to signal for silence. "Once the fireplaces are lit, and Ren's team finds candles and lanterns to set up, we'll be in better shape."

It makes enough sense to convince a few students to move behind Vito, at least. When a handful of the teachers follow, it seems to encourage Ren's team to fall in line. The staff will know where to find emergency supplies, I imagine.

This leaves me with Aspen and a handful of stragglers. "We have to stay together until this passes. No wandering around. There's damage to the stairs, so don't bother trying to use them. If you brought your phones and they have a good charge, use them as flashlights to get back and forth from the bathroom if necessary."

"Why are we listening to you?"

I don't know who said it. Darkness makes tracing the origin of the muttered complaint impossible. That's why I treat every person in front of me to the same cold, forbidding look. "By all means, allow me to step down while you take the reins. You were doing so well before I spoke up, clucking like a bunch of ruffled hens thinking the sky is falling. Feel free to get lost in the dark or die in the stairwell." One by one, they drop their gazes to the floor. "I thought so."

I turn to monitor the progress around the room. Vito's team has already built a fire while the group Ren got together is handing out flashlights and lanterns. There's no telling how much longer it will take Brittney to get us back up and running, but at least we'll be warmer than before.

"We should stay together," I call out as a reminder when the flashlight beams bob farther away from the core of the group huddled in front of the fire.

I leave it to the teachers to wrangle the students since that's their job, after all. Now that the surprise has worn off, and we have light and heat, they seem to have woken up to their responsibilities. We may all be full-grown, but technically, we are still under their care.

Ren joins me, speaking low near my ear so only I can hear him. "This is fucked. How much longer are we supposed to hang around in the dark?"

"It's not so much the dark I'm concerned with as it is the lack of ventilation. We can't return to our rooms until the system kicks on." The notion of setting up beds on the unforgiving floor makes my muscles ache.

We aren't freezing now, but it's hardly warm and toasty. I suppose sleeping in shifts would help when it comes to making sure the fires don't die, but how many of the people surrounding me do I trust not to nod off in the middle of a shift?

It would be an excuse to huddle close to Aspen, though, wouldn't it? To keep each other warm through the night. I wish I could trust myself to leave it there, as a matter of survival, but I know better. Especially when she insists on throwing herself at me. There is only so much self-control in existence.

All this time, she's been silent. Her presence at my side somehow strengthens me. I know she's safe. I feel her warmth and softness. With that concern silenced, I can turn my energy toward keeping shit together until this passes.

It doesn't take much longer. The lights flicker, then go dark, but flare to life again before anyone can groan in disappointment. A sigh of relief rises in the room.

“She did it,” Aspen whispers. There’s a fierceness to it, something like pride in someone she clearly admires.

Pride that can only be shared between us since I doubt Lucas’s warning about keeping this quiet has an expiration date.

It’s as if he heard me thinking about him. The sound of his footsteps echoes off the marble before he appears. “All right, everyone. The power is back in, and the elevators are back in use. Return to your rooms.” Nobody would guess that a short time ago, he was snarling in frustration and furious over the idea of dealing with panicked parents. Now he’s the image of calm confidence.

It seems that isn’t enough for everyone. “But what happened?” someone asks, followed by a chorus of murmurs. Only the briefest flash of impatience reveals itself on Lucas’s face. He brings it under control so fast, I might have imagined it.

But I know better than to believe that. He’s a master of concealing his inner thoughts.

Now, he’s brisk and efficient. “A fluke in this system, one of those things. Everything is working as it should now.”

“But there was an explosion,” someone points out.

“We’ll look into it, but it looks like it had something to do with the backup generator trying to jump on. We’ll have a team of technicians on it first thing in the morning.” He clears his throat, his brow lowering like he means business. “Back to your rooms. Now.” There’s no arguing with him, and we all know it.

It will mean letting go of Aspen again, though.

I hate how difficult this is. Conflict still blazes in my chest. I’m doing the right thing for everyone involved, but somehow, it isn’t enough.

Ren meets my gaze over the heads of students now shuffling away. I know what he’s thinking, and he’s right. I don’t have to like it.

“Go ahead.” I give her a gentle but firm push in Lucas’s direction. “He’ll take you back to your room.”

She hesitates, her forehead creasing in confusion. “Couldn’t you walk me back?” she asks in a trembling voice that cuts me to the quick.

If Lucas can conceal his inner thoughts, so can I. I’ve had enough practice. “I need to get back to my own room, remember? I’m not supposed to wander around on that level.” I make it a point to narrow my eyes. “You heard Lucas. The threat has passed.”

“But—”

Lucas joins us. After scowling at me, he turns to Aspen. “He’s right. I’ll take you back to your room. Everything is back to normal.”

He might not notice, but I do. Her shoulders slump and her head bows ever so slightly, like someone used to being told what to do. No matter how she feels about it, she has no say in nearly anything happening around her. Like a leaf twisting in the wind, carried by forces beyond her control.

She deserves better. Everything was so much easier before I knew it. When I could hate her.

Lucas and I exchange one last look, and I hope my lifted shoulders convey my relative innocence in this. I’m sure he thinks I’m encouraging her, but nothing could be further from the truth. I’m torturing myself for her sake. I can’t expect him to understand.

All I can do is turn my back on her and pretend not to care when she shuffles away. “That was the smart thing to do,” Ren assures me before we set off on the heels of the group.

“I don’t need your encouragement.”

“Are you sure about that? Because you look about as close to a whipped dog as I’ve ever seen.” My head snaps around, my lip curling into a sneer. “That’s more like it,” he says with a grin, and I know that was a ploy to pull me out of my dark, self-loathing thoughts.

All I can do is replay the sight of Aspen's shoulders slumping. When reality settles back in, she'll remember the way things are. A single stressful, dangerous night won't change anything.

I have to be better. I have to keep away from her for her sake and not to mention my family's.

I wish I knew how such a thing is possible.

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ASPEN

Everyone's different. Different in a way that I don't like. They're leery of me, hesitant like I'm the big bad monster of Corium capable of ruining their lives. It's infuriating since I didn't earn their respect, and it only reminds me further of the hold Quinton and his family have at the university. His promise to keep me safe replays in my mind constantly, like a bad song with a catchy beat. Even now, I hear his voice in my mind.

I want to slap myself in the face for how weak I acted the other day when we had to follow the air duct to the surface. I told myself I'd be stronger, and instead, I had a panic attack over nothing.

The shuffling of feet and constant chatter filter into my ears as soon as I step out of the elevator. Maybe this was a bad idea? *No*. Everything seems to give me a panic attack. I need to get out more. I can't continue to live like this, sheltered and afraid.

Forcing a deep breath into my lungs, I walk down the hall. My steps are firm as I keep my head held high. I've made it all but five feet when I notice how everyone is keeping a safe distance from me, their bodies pressed to the walls like they're afraid to get close. I can feel eyes on me, burning into my skin, but I shake off the stares and march on. Ever since I returned, it's been this way. Everyone is afraid, but not of me.

Before, they ignored my existence, but in a way that said they didn't give a shit, now they act like stepping too close might get them killed.

I hurry down the corridor, my palms clammy and my pulse pounding in my ears. The space clears out as students rush to their next class. I know I technically have nothing to worry about, but I find myself looking over my shoulder periodically.

In one of those moments of paranoia, I fail to notice a person in front of me. We collide, our shoulders hitting against one another's. I'm nearly knocked off my feet from the impact.

Damnit! I steady myself, my feet planted firmly on the ground. I look around, prepared to fight off whatever person is trying to hurt me. The panic of being taken again sends my thoughts into overdrive. I won't go without a fight. They won't hurt me again. I feel the fight burning through my veins, and I'm ready to throw the first punch when I look up.

Instead of an enemy, I find a girl staring at me. She's about the same height as me, long midnight black hair frames her heart-shaped face, and her horror-filled green eyes collide with mine.

She looks like a little fairy with pixie-like features, which I now notice are riddled with lines of tension.

"Oh, my god. I'm so sorry..." She bends down, and I take a step back, shaking my head.

It was an accident. There's nothing malicious going on, I tell myself, yet all I can do is stare at her, my throat tightening with words that I want to say but can't get out.

She extends her hand out to me, and I notice then that my pen rests against her palm. Almost angrily, I snatch it from her, making certain I don't touch her hand.

"I apologize. I'm such a clutz. I really need to pay better attention to where I'm going."

"It's okay." The words finally squeak past my lips.

The way she takes a step back, her features tightening with fear, I know whatever threat Quinton gave out must've been bad.

Before I can tell her everything will be okay, she rushes past me. I'm so flabbergasted by the interaction all I can do is stand there. My thoughts shift. I don't want people afraid of me just because of Quinton.

I want people to leave me alone because they know better and because if they don't, I'll make them. I want to be strong enough to care for myself, not stand in someone else's shadow.

After a moment, I pull myself together and continue to the library. As soon as I step through the double doors, I exhale out all the negative energy. Looking ahead, I spot Brittney standing at the circular desk. She looks up as I approach, a smile on her face. While I'm always glad to see her, today, there's an impending question on my mind. I fold my arms on the surface, leaning in and whispering.

"What was that really all about? The hack, I mean?"

Though we're alone now that everyone is in class, Brittney's eyes dart around like she's looking to make sure nobody overhears us.

"It was Phoenix, and it was much more than a hack. The bomb in the stairwell was him too."

"Shit, I knew it."

Brittney frowns. "He swears he wasn't trying to hurt anyone. He told me he paid off the janitor to place the bomb in the stairwell. He only wanted to talk to me since I've done everything I could to put distance between us."

"Couldn't he have found a better way? One that wouldn't potentially kill us all?"

Her brows draw together. "I was certain I could fix the hack, but when he didn't get a response from me, he detonated the bomb. I never thought he would take it that far. After that, I had no option but to talk to him, especially when he told me he had another placed somewhere else that he would detonate if I didn't."

I grit my teeth. "So you talked to him then? Is everything okay now?"

She shakes her head. "It's okay for now. He wants to meet in person, so I have to meet him in the city. I told him I wouldn't come if he did anything stupid like this again."

I want to tell her not to go, but there's no way around it. It's either meet him or wait for another bomb to go off.

"He sounds extremely toxic."

"Tell me about it. Now I have to get him to leave me alone without risking my job here or hurting anyone I care about."

I'm both angry and sad for Brittney, but I have no idea how to help her with Phoenix. "You know I'll help however I can."

"I know you would help, but there isn't anything you can do. Phoenix is my problem, and I'll have to kick him like a bad habit."

I smile, and she continues, "Anyhow, enough about me. It's time for us to do some work. Can't have Lucas thinking all we're doing is reading and talking about our fictional book boyfriends." Brittney smiles, her eyes twinkling.

"What ever do you mean?" I smirk back, the heaviness on my chest lifting instantly. "Romance novels are educational."

"Ha, yes, very, but not the education you need." She laughs, and though the last thing I'm in the mood for is pretending to concentrate, I follow along as dutifully as I can. At least it means spending time with a friend who cares about me instead of having to face terrified students everywhere I turn.

That same sense of being feared clings to me after the lesson as I cut through the halls on my way back to my room. I'm right back where I started. I never knew before that fear and hatred could be two sides of the same coin. Now, instead of feeling like I have to apologize simply for breathing the same air as the people who now make it a point to avoid me, I have to bite my tongue against the impulse to beg them not to be afraid.

While wondering why they can't simply see me for who I am. I'm no threat to them, or at least I wouldn't be if they treated me as an equal. Only if they continue harassing and abusing me will their lives be affected.

And in extreme cases, ended.

I'll never be sorry those monsters paid with their lives. After all, they took a life that night. My baby was innocent, fragile. Tears form at the back of my eyelids at the mere mention of our baby. I blink them away because crying isn't going to change what's already happened. I'm too wrapped up in my troubled thoughts to notice someone approaching. "What an unpleasant surprise it is to see you here."

My head snaps up to find Nash smiling at me. No, that isn't quite right. There's nothing natural or friendly about his expression. He reminds me of a shark and how empty their eyes look while their teeth flash right before they eat you.

That's exactly how he looks now. Like I'm his next meal.

And there I was, wishing people would stop avoiding me.

Sucking a breath into my lungs, I stand taller, making myself seem bigger. One thing I'm not going to do is cower. I'm no longer that girl who was used as a doormat, bullied, and treated like shit by her peers. I'm not a rat anymore. I'm Aspen Mather.

And it's time that Nash knows what will happen to him if he messes with me. That very thought keeps me from running back to my room. I will never become anything to these people if all I do is run away.

"I could say the same to you," I reply sweetly.

Ignoring my comment altogether, he asks, "Where's the fire you're running away from?"

"No fire," I say in a voice so smooth it hardly sounds like my own. "I was going to my room." I offer a brief, tight smile I imagine looks more like a grimace before attempting to sidestep him.

He's too fast, matching my movement with his own, so he's still in front of me. "I could walk you if you want."

As if I didn't already know something's up.

"I know the way to my room," I say through clenched teeth.

“Of course, you aren’t living on the same level as the rest of us anymore, are you?” His voice is almost silky. It almost hides the venom running beneath his words.

If there’s one thing I’ve gotten used to, it’s venom.

“No, I’m not. I’m above you now.” I smile as his eyes narrow. “Anyway, I’d better get going.”

“What inspired the move?” he asks, falling in step beside me.

My pulse picks up, my palms going slick. I don’t like this. It would be one thing if he insulted me and moved on, but somehow, this feels deeper. More serious. Deliberate.

“Does it matter?” I fire back.

“I mean no, not really, but as you know, my father is a founding member of this school. I definitely feel like he should know what his money is being used for, or should I say, who his money is helping.”

I barely withhold an eye roll. “My parents paid for me to attend this school, so where I sleep is the least of your concerns.”

Something malicious flickers in Nash’s eyes, and I don’t miss the way his fist clenches or the ripple of rage that works its way through his body. “I haven’t seen you around the halls much. Going from class to class. Don’t tell me they’re letting you live here without going to lessons.”

“If they were, that would be their business, too.” I look down at the books I’m clutching to my chest like a shield. “I’m taking classes.”

“I’m sorry. Am I making you uncomfortable?” Now he’s solicitous. His voice drips with honey. I’m sure it would poison me if I took a taste. What is this? I’m so tired of games, wondering if everyone around me has an ulterior motive.

Except with Nash, I don’t have to wonder. There is something seriously wrong here, even if I can’t quite put my finger on it.

I force a smile. “I’m in a hurry, that’s all.”

“Back to your room.”

I mutter something that sounds like a confirmation.

We’re almost at the elevators. My salvation... until the brief, horrifying idea of him getting in with me makes my stomach churn. As nauseating as it is being trailed by him, the thought of being trapped with no escape is so much worse. My heart is beating triple-time, and I’m afraid I’ll have another panic attack like I did before climbing into the air vent. Please, don’t let that happen. I don’t want to be at his mercy.

“It seems a shame, you being all alone. Be sure to let me know if you need a little entertainment sometime. I heard you can be a lot of fun to hang out with.” Where would he get that idea?

I jam my finger against the button and beg silently for the doors to open. Maybe if I ignore him, he’ll go away.

“No comment, huh?” All of a sudden, he’s practically on top of me with one forearm against the wall over my head. The weight of his body almost pins me to the wall. “Don’t be modest. I’m trying to compliment you.”

I can’t breathe. I need to run. I have to get away. I can’t let him hurt me. Nobody will hurt me so long as Quinton is here. He doesn’t need to be with me in the physical sense for his protection to save me. That knowledge is the only thing that keeps me from either running blindly down the hall or collapsing in a shaking, teary heap thanks to all the foggy, painful memories rushing back when Nash gets too close to me.

That won’t happen. Not this time. I’m safe.

It gives me the courage to press a hand against his chest and shove with all my might. He falls back a step, more likely out of surprise than thanks to my nonexistent physical strength. “Leave me alone,” I warn, coming as close to a snarl as I ever have. I almost sound like Quinton.

For the first time, Nash offers a genuine smile. His eyes light up like he’s excited. “And what will happen if I don’t?”

“Do you really want to find out?”

The ping of the elevator couldn't have come at a better time. What's even better is the fact that a handful of students file out, talking and laughing, providing cover for me to slip inside and frantically press the button leading to my level. Thankfully, Nash is smart enough not to follow me inside the elevator. Instead, he stares at me with a hateful glare until the door shuts.

Once I'm alone, I lean against the wall, gasping for air. It seems strange how I start shaking now that there's no danger when I managed to hold it together before now.

Earlier today, all I wanted was for people not to be afraid of me because of Quinton.

Now, I wish they would. Nash, in particular.

What's his sudden interest all about?

And why do I get the feeling he's not done with me yet?

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QUINTON

There was a time when I couldn't understand the concept of addiction. I knew it existed. I knew it ruined lives and shattered families. You don't grow up in my world without hearing stories like that. Wealthy families whose kids had nothing better to do with their time and money than ingest or inject it.

And I admit to wondering how they could ever let things get that out of hand. I asked myself why they couldn't simply walk away from whatever had taken a stranglehold on them. Why couldn't they will themselves back to health?

Now, I understand. Only it isn't drugs or alcohol my system craves.

How am I supposed to exist at this school, knowing Aspen is so close yet so far? How am I supposed to function when all I seem to do lately is work out in a vain attempt to exorcise my demons and pace my room like a caged tiger?

I haven't seen her since the night of the attack. I've watched her, yes, observed her going about her routine. I know she's safe. I know she's as well as can be, all things considered. Physically, she's healed from her experience.

Emotionally? That's another story. I can offer her safety and protection, but I can't erase what happened. My craving for her body, her smell, and her

taste is just as overwhelming as the need to comfort her. To be with her when she's hurting and provide an ear if she needs to vent.

Here I am, Quinton Rossi, and I would happily listen to a girl vent about her feelings. What has she done to me?

Fuck. I need to hear her voice if I can't see or touch her. And I know I can't because it would be too dangerous. If I told myself otherwise, I would be no better than the addict who tells himself *just one more time*.

Sometimes, one more time is all it takes for everything to come crashing down.

The number to her new phone is programmed into mine, and I call it, still pacing, my body a mass of knotted muscles. "Pick up," I mutter when it rings three, four, five times. "Why won't you pick up?"

Suddenly, I realize she won't pick up because she doesn't know I'm the person calling. She wouldn't have my number saved to her contacts. I shake my head at my stupidity while texting her.

Me: It's Q. Pick up.

This time when I call, she answers. Still, she doesn't say anything at first. "Are you there?" I ask.

She exhales, and the sound strikes me as something similar to a sigh of relief. "It is you."

"Who else would it be? Who would have this number?"

"I don't know." She lets out a shaky laugh. "You're right. It doesn't make much sense. I'm just jumpy, I guess."

My mouth opens, and I'm about to ask why that is, but good sense prevails. After everything she's been through, she has every right to be jumpy. Even so, I've already promised her safety. Why isn't that enough?

It's not easy to suppress my impulse to flare up in anger. "Remember what I told you. You're safe. You have me to protect you. Anyone who thinks they can so much as look at you the wrong way will have me to deal with."

She's quiet again, too quiet for my liking. "Aspen?" I prompt. "Is something wrong? Is there something I should know?"

This time, there's no hesitation. "No, nothing like that."

"Then what is it?"

"It's one thing to hear something and even know it, but sometimes, it takes a while for things to sink in."

"All you need to do is trust me."

"You're right, I'm sure." She doesn't sound so sure. I hate not being able to see her, touch her, hold her. I need to stare into her hazel eyes and find the truth she's concealing.

Perhaps I need to settle for the next best thing. The only way we can connect that won't lead to me making the mistake of fucking her again is to do it this way. I can hear her voice. My memory and imagination can fill in the rest.

"You sound tense."

"I guess I am. I mean, I feel like I'm always waiting for the other shoe to drop." Another long pause. "I never know what to expect from you either."

"You know what to expect."

"Do I?" She laughs, but there is no humor. "Because you act the opposite of how you should. Pushing me away and being cold isn't how to make me forget you. I know you don't mean it. I wish you'd tell me what you really want. I mean, really truly."

"What I really, truly want right now is to have you here with me. In my room."

She goes silent. Did I go too far? Is it too soon? I only told her the truth.

"What?" she whispers.

"I want you here with me. In my room. I can't help it."

"But you don't want me. You only want to have sex."

If only that were true. “What’s the difference?”

“Quinton.”

“Aspen. I want you. There’s no truer thing in my life. I never feel as good as I do when I’m inside you.” I pause a beat. “And you never feel as good as you do when I’m inside you.”

“Don’t speak for me,” she warns.

The fight is draining from her voice, whether she knows it or not.

“Don’t pretend you don’t wish we were together. We both know it isn’t true.”

“But...” Her sigh is heavy. “It’s different now. After... you know.”

I know, and I would happily kill the fuckers again for everything they took from her. She can’t even take pleasure in her body without remembering how they defiled her.

“You can’t let them control you now. I know I’ll never understand what you’re going through, but I know that. You deserve to move on.”

I’m ready for her to accuse me of having a vested interest in whether she ever has sex again. Instead, she whispers, “I want to. I don’t know if I could ever feel good again. It’s like I’m broken now.”

My heart stirs. It’s not an everyday sensation for me. Now, I’m determined to do something other than kill. I want to prove her wrong. I want to show her that she’s many things but broken is not one of them.

“You’re not broken. You’re stronger than you’ve ever been. You’re also beautiful. Intelligent. Kind. Brave. You’re so many things nobody could ever change. And you deserve to claim every part of that.”

“Where is this coming from?”

“Do you have to ask?”

She’s quiet again for a moment. I feel I’m about to be told to fuck off, but like always, she surprises me again. “Will you help me?”

“Help you?”

“Feel good? I mean,” she blurts out, “without being here? I’m not ready for the actual act yet. But if you could talk me through it... I want to see if I’m still capable of...”

If I didn’t already want her, the self-doubt she’s wrestling with would be enough for me to agree. She deserves to enjoy her body again. She deserves everything, and I want to give it to her.

“Yes. Whatever you need.” Meanwhile, my cock’s twitching. This might be about Aspen, but he wants in on it.

“I’m going to lie down,” she says. I do the same, lying back on my bed with my feet on the floor.

“It’s just the two of us,” I remind her in a gentle voice I hardly recognize. Only she could bring this out of me. “You’re safe.”

“I know.”

“What are you doing?” I close my eyes and imagine her in bed.

“Wondering why I brought up the subject at all.”

“You don’t have to do anything you don’t want to. But.” My cock twitches again, thickening now. “You could start by running your hands over yourself—on top of your clothes. Focus on how it feels. Describe it.”

At first, she says nothing. Her breathing is slow, even. “It feels good, I guess.”

“That’s a good start.”

“I’m touching my legs, starting at my ankles and moving up my calves... my thighs...” Her voice catches.

“Relax. Go with it.”

She makes a noise of agreement. “My inner thighs. It doesn’t feel like anything yet. Like if I was in the shower, washing.”

“Close your eyes,” I suggest. “Imagine I’m with you. Focus on nothing but the sensations and the sound of my voice while you drag your fingers over your soft thighs. Your skin feels like silk.” When she lets out an approving sigh, I know my instincts are on point. She needs to be reminded of how beautiful her body is even after what it’s been through.

“Hang on a sec. I’m going to take my pants off.” While she does, I take the opportunity to undo my own and lower them enough to free my straining cock. Her tiny sighs bring to mind memories so vivid it could be her hand stroking me.

“You have all the time in the world,” I remind her between long, slow strokes. “Was I right about your skin? Is it as soft as always?”

“It is.”

“And does it feel good?”

“... it does.” This time, her voice isn’t indecisive. It’s encouraging.

“What about the rest of you? When you touch other places?”

“Like my boobs, right?” She snorts. “You can say it.”

The humor is also encouraging. She’s not afraid or closed-off. “Your tits, then. What about those?”

A small whimper has me biting back a groan. Listening while she wakes up her body is hotter than I thought. “Yeah. Still feels good.” She breathes. “You can rest easy.”

“Like I could rest easy where your tits are involved.” I can almost taste them, her rosy nipples standing up for my tongue to sweep across them. Can practically feel her back arching when I close around one and suck it between my teeth. Fuck me.

“Tell me what you’re doing with them.”

“Brushing over my nipples. I’ve pulled down the bra cups so I can touch them.”

“Nice visual. You’re so hot, taking what you want.” Her whimper drives me on. “Controlling your body and your pleasure. It’s hot as fuck.”

“You’re saying you want the girl to be in control when you’re fucking?”

“I wouldn’t go that far.” We share a short laugh that makes me wonder if I’ve ever felt so connected to her.

“It feels good. Mmm... I’m even getting wet. I can feel it.”

I clench my jaw before anything reckless comes out of my mouth. Pushing too hard might scare her off.

“What do you want to do about it?” My fist tightens, pumping faster now that I have the image of her wet, glistening lips in my mind’s eye.

“I don’t know. I want to touch myself there. I’m starting to ache.”

“I’m right here with you,” I murmur. “Do whatever feels right. If you want to touch yourself down there, go ahead. It’s your body, remember. You know what you like.”

Her breathing is all I hear for a while until a groan vibrates through the phone. “Oh... Q...”

In my head, she’s under me, writhing and moaning now that my fingers have delved into her wet folds. Parting them, catching her nectar, slicking my fingers before I slide them deep inside where it’s hot and tight. Precum leaks from my tip, and I can’t hold back a groan no matter how I try.

“Are you touching yourself?” she asks in a shaky whisper. “Is that what that sound means?”

“Is that okay?”

“Mm-hmm. I like to think of you doing it while I’m doing this.”

My strokes quicken at her encouragement. “I had to. Listening to you is too much.”

“It’s good. Almost like we’re together.” She moans a little louder now, more insistent.

“That’s right. Build yourself up. You’re so beautiful, so perfect...”

“Quinton... oh, my god...”

“What are you doing? Tell me,” I beg.

“My fingers. Running them up and down my lips. It feels amazing.”

“Fuck, yes, it is.” Her breathy voice is doing things to me. Driving me crazy. She whimpers, and I could come from the sound alone. “Take your time. Enjoy it.”

“Mm-hmm.” Only I wonder how much longer she’ll be able to take her time now that she’s on fire like I am. “Incredible. It almost hurts, but it feels so good.”

“Do you want to touch your clit?”

“Yes,” she whines. “Oh, my god, yes.”

“Do it. Make yourself come.” My balls begin to tighten, but I hold off, wanting to come with her. She’s on her way; I can hear it in her voice and the quickening of her breath.

Her sharp gasp opens my eyes, and for one second, I think it’s over. Something stopped her. Instead, she sighs. “Holy shit. Oh, Quinton, yes.”

My fist is a blur, and I’m almost too breathless to speak, but I have to. I have to make sure she knows she’s safe. “That’s right, Aspen. Take what you deserve. Imagine me inside you, filling you up.”

“Oh, my god...” She’s straining, so close, at the edge. “I think I might...”

“Let yourself go. Come for me.” Her moans turn into high-pitched cries, and she’s doing it. Fuck, yes, she’s coming. They couldn’t take this from her.

The first spurt of cum hits my abs in time with her final, drawn-out cry. “Yes!” she gasps, then again, and I could fucking cheer even now with my heart pounding and the last drops of cum oozing from my head.

She did it. I knew she could.

We both grow quiet once it's passed, and I strain my ears to catch any sound from her. "Are you okay?" I ask. Was it too much?

"Mm-hmm." There's a teary sound to it. "I didn't think I would be able to. In fact, I... don't think I could have without you."

"Now you know you can. Because you were brave enough to try." I get up to clean myself off, unable to shake the feeling of having won a battle against those fucking bastards. They can't control her.

"Thank you." She sighs, a little shaky but content. I can't believe how my arms ache to hold her close and stroke her hair.

"Me? I didn't do anything but offer encouragement."

I hoped she'd laugh or at least snort at me. Instead, she replies, "You did more than that." For once, I'm at a loss for words, so I leave it there, satisfied for now.

Though I know, my satisfaction won't last long. Eventually, phone sex won't be enough to ease my constant cravings.

I've never doubted my strength before. Now, I don't know how I'm supposed to keep fighting.

ASPEN

“*A*m I boring you?”

It isn't until Lucas's pointed question that I realize I allowed my mind to wander. As always, it found its way to Quinton.

It's been days since we had phone sex, and I haven't seen him since, though that isn't surprising. Outwardly, we have to stay apart.

I can't help but wonder how much longer either of us will be able to stand it.

That doesn't mean I can insult Lucas by zoning out during his lesson. “I'm sorry,” I murmur, even knowing how pitiful and empty it sounds. “I didn't know I was daydreaming.”

“Is that all it was? A daydream?”

He doesn't need to speak the words for me to understand what's on his mind. He's worried I was thinking back on that night. “Nothing like that,” I assure him with a genuine but brief smile.

“I'm glad to hear it. Maybe we can get back to business, then?” He arches an eyebrow.

Before he can get started, there's something I need to get off my chest. I've been thinking about it ever since my run-in with Nash. He's avoided me since that day in the hall. The few times our paths have crossed, he hasn't

spoken a word and is usually in the company of others. Every time I manage to get away unscathed, I thank my lucky stars.

Deep down inside, I know my luck can't last forever.

"I was wondering if you could arrange something for me."

One simple sentence has the power to make him close up. "I wasn't aware you were in a position to request arrangements." The slightly chilly tone takes me back to my earliest days here and how cruel he was. How dismissive.

"It's nothing special. I'm not trying to put anybody out. It's only that I wondered if I could have self-defense lessons. With Quan, I thought." I bite my lip and try to read his expression, but he has a way of masking his thoughts.

His mouth opens, and I hold my breath, hoping I didn't push too hard. I don't think I'm asking for too much, but who's to say? I also thought I deserved edible food when I first arrived at Corium, but obviously, I was in the minority on that, too. I've come to learn that what seems reasonable to me can be construed as anything but.

The ringing of his cell phone cuts off whatever he's about to say. He casts a doleful eye toward the device, sitting facedown on his desk, before his gaze hits me again. "Are you in danger? Is that what this is about?"

"No," I lie. Technically, I'm not sure it is a lie. Just because I got a bad feeling about Nash doesn't mean he's going to do anything. He and Quinton are friends, right? Surely, if people he's barely acquaintances with are too afraid to look me in the eye, his friends must know how much it means to him that I'm left alone.

Even so, it never hurts to be prepared. If I've learned one thing in my time at Corium, it's that.

Still, Lucas looks uncomfortable, his brows pinching together like he has a headache. I'm sure that's what I am to him. One great big headache from the start. "I think it might be a better idea if I'm the one to teach you."

Right. How stupid of me. As far as most of the staff around here is concerned, I'm still less than nothing. I don't think I'll ever forget Brush suggesting they leave me here during the gas leak. Knowing I could easily die on my own. There's a reason my lessons are with the only three staff members who have ever shown me a hint of kindness or consideration.

Still, Lucas? There's no doubt in my mind he could be a dangerous man, but there's a difference between knowing how to handle a weapon and knowing how to use his body to defend himself. "You?"

When his eyes pop open wide, I fear I've made a mistake. He surprises me by chuckling. "Try not to sound so surprised. What? You think I'm an old man who doesn't have it in him?"

"Not even close." After all, I watched him kick that door down. This is a powerful man. "I was just surprised you would suggest yourself, that's all. You know, I didn't think you got your hands dirty like that."

"It might surprise you how dirty my hands have been." He strokes his jaw, wearing the rueful smirk of a man with stories to tell. Something tells me I might not want to hear many of them. Then he looks me up and down. "I'm sure I could teach you what you need to know to defend yourself. You might not be able to beat an assailant to a bloody pulp, but you'll know how to get yourself out of a situation and make them regret ever attacking you in the first place."

Nash's face floats in the forefront of my mind. That smile of his reminds me so much of an empty-eyed shark. His snideness, the way it always sounded like there was more to what he was saying than was visible on the surface.

How quick he was to invade my personal space.

"You're smiling," Lucas points out, and I didn't notice until he said it. He doesn't need to know why.

"I think I would like that a lot," I decide. I might have a trick or two up my sleeve the next time Nash decides to place himself in my path.

His phone rings again, and I feel I should say something this time. "I can leave the room if you need to get that."

“No. One thing you have to learn, Aspen, is no one will respect your time if you don’t respect it first. If I dropped everything the moment my phone rings, I would get nothing done.”

“Good point.”

“Back to the matter at hand.” He strokes his jaw again, this time wearing a thoughtful expression. “You know, I could teach you several moves that might be considered dirty fighting. I think that would serve you well since you don’t have size or strength on your side. I would need your consent to teach them, though, and you would have to promise not to use them unless you know there’s no other choice. Do you understand what I mean?”

“I think so.” It’s clear from the narrowing of his eyes that it isn’t good enough. I sit up a little straighter. “Yes. I understand.”

“That’s fine. We’ll get started during our next session together.”

I can’t help myself. What’s the worst he could do? Refuse to answer? I’ve faced much worse. “How is it you know those dirty moves? Have you ever needed to use them on anyone?”

For a moment, indecision washes over his face. I get the feeling he wants to tell me, but wonders if it’s a good idea. Finally, he gives in. “I’ve done a lot of fighting in my day. I’m not talking about fistfights in the schoolyard or getting into a brawl in a bar over a girl. The sort of fighting I did held much higher stakes.”

Oh. Now I’m not sure I want to hear more. Should I be surprised? One look at Lucas Diavolo, and it’s clear the man could be very dangerous under the right, or rather wrong, circumstances.

At the same time, it occurs to me that he’s the sort of ally I need. “You mean, a fight to the death?”

“Does that shock you?”

“Before I came here, I would say yes,” I admit after giving it a little thought. “But after everything I’ve seen and learned, it doesn’t anymore.”

He sighs heavily. “I can’t say it pleases me to hear you say that, but on the other hand, that’s a good thing.”

“What do you mean?” This isn’t what I came here to learn, but I don’t care. I’m getting another sort of education.

“Once you understand every threat, once you know the worst that could happen to you, nothing can surprise you. There are moments, especially in a fight, when you’re face-to-face with somebody who knows they’ll either have to kill you or be killed—when a split second of indecision or surprise can make all the difference. If nothing surprises you, you have the advantage.”

I can sort of understand, though I doubt the brutality I’ve experienced will prepare me for the future. How could it?

On the other hand, now I know better than to blindly trust anyone, ever. Even the friendliest smile can conceal a dagger. Maybe he has a point.

“Did you have to do a lot of fighting?”

“I needed to survive, and the high stakes meant a large payday. At the time, I had little choice.” He doesn’t sound regretful. I guess when you do what needs to be done to survive, there’s no room for regret.

It’s astonishing how my outlook has changed since I’ve been here. Months ago, I would have been horrified at the idea of sitting in the same room with somebody who used to fight to the death for money. Now, I’m finding it easier to put myself in his shoes.

And I’m so glad I asked about self-defense lessons. I’d much rather learn from Lucas than from Quan, anyway. I just never imagined Lucas would volunteer.

When Lucas’s desk phone rings this time, he growls. “This is ridiculous.” Yet when I move to get up, he shakes his head to stop me. “I’ll put an end to it. Don’t worry.”

All I know is, I wouldn’t want to be the person on the other end of the line when he answers. “What?” he barks. I have to remind myself not to shrink back in my chair.

When his face falls an instant before he turns away, I can't help but wrap my arms around myself. Something is very wrong. Immediately, my mind goes to Quinton. What if it's something about him? Maybe Scarlet is in trouble or Ella. After they were so kind to me, it would cut me like a knife if anything bad happened.

Not to mention the way it would crush Quinton. I couldn't handle that.

"Thank you." Yet Lucas doesn't hang up the receiver right away, standing with his back to me, lowering the receiver until it hangs at his side.

Finally, I can't take it. "What's wrong?" I whisper over the lump in my throat.

His shoulders rise and fall before he turns, replacing the receiver. "That was one of my associates." He's not looking at me. Why isn't he looking at me?

"It's something bad, isn't it?" He sighs but offers no reply. "Please. Tell me. Remember what you just said about facing things so you're not surprised by them. I can face it."

Finally, his eyes meet mine, and I know right away that this is going to be bad.

"I am very sorry to have to tell you this," he begins in a tight voice, "but there's been a report from the prison where your father served his sentence."

Served. Past tense. This can't be real.

"Evidently, there was an attack." His forehead creases, his lips pulling downward at the corners. "And your father was killed."

Every last bit of air in my lungs rushes out of me all at once. He hasn't laid a finger on me, but he may as well have kicked me square in the stomach. For one brief, terrifying moment, I'm sure I'll never be able to take another breath. My body is going to shut down because my brain is shutting down. Not Dad. Please, no.

But I do breathe, and though it couldn't have taken more than a split second to inhale, it feels like a lifetime. Instead of going gray around the edges, the

world rushes back to me in full color. Even though I wish it wouldn't.

"Aspen." The next thing I know, Lucas is crouched in front of me, searching my face with concern in his eyes. "Keep breathing."

"They beat him?" I manage. I'm going to be sick. I just know it. I've hated him so many times for what he did, for how he ruined our lives, but at the same time, I still loved him. He was still my dad. I always knew he didn't mean to ruin me.

"Honestly, I didn't get details."

"But he's dead? For sure?"

"I'm afraid so." He touches my hand, shocking me. I yank it back like his touch burns, and all he does is nod slowly. "I understand. Nobody around here has made their feelings about your father's secret. I'm sure my sympathy falls flat after what you've been through."

My head bobs up and down. That's all I can do. My mind doesn't want to wrap around it, and my heart certainly doesn't, but that doesn't make it any less real.

"But I am sorry for you. That much, you can believe."

"What about my mom? I have to call her. Oh, my god, she's all alone. How is she supposed to deal with this on her own?"

His eyes dart away, and I realize there's more to this. "Did you hear something about her, too?"

"All we know is she's still missing."

Now the world spins around me. The only thing that keeps me centered and conscious is the pressure from my nails digging into my palms. I clench my fists tight enough to break the skin, and the pain centers me. I won't break down. I can't break down. Not here. Not in front of him or anybody else at this fucking school. This is what they all wanted. They wanted him dead for what he did. Now, they've got what they wanted. I won't let them celebrate watching me crumble on top of everything else.

“I need to go to my room.” I stand, forcing my legs to stop shaking long enough to support me.

“I’ll walk you and—”

I shake my head before he can finish, making a beeline for the door. “It isn’t far. I’ll be fine.”

“You shouldn’t be alone right now,” he warns, but I ignore him, marching down the hall with my head down, fists swinging at my sides. If I clench them much longer, they’ll cramp up, but the alternative is much worse. I’ll shatter into a million pieces otherwise.

Only once I’m alone, with the door between me and the rest of this ugly, awful place, can I let it go. I lean my back against the door and slide down its length, curling up in a ball on the floor and sobbing for everything my family has lost.

QUINTON

I'm on my way out of the gym after a particularly grueling workout when I first catch wind of something being wrong, or at least off.

There's an energy in the air that didn't exist earlier today or even an hour ago when I first got on the treadmill for a run. Groups of students cluster in the halls, whispering and muttering among themselves. I pass without commenting or revealing interest, but keep my ears tuned to the gossip. They're too wrapped up in whatever they're excited about to notice me.

"Fucking rat. He got what was coming to him."

"I only hope it hurt."

"I hope it took a long time," someone adds. "He didn't deserve to go slow. I wish I was there to see it."

"Whoever it was, they deserve an award. I wonder how much Xander offered to get it done."

That stops me in my tracks. My head snaps around, eyes searching for the son of a bitch who mentioned my father's name so casually. "Excuse me?" I bark. Like magic, the chatter around me stops. A few girls even gasp and cover their mouths with their hands. It's like until this moment, I was a ghost.

He shrugs. "Hey, like the asshole didn't have it coming to him."

Someone else chimes in. “For real. Of everybody here, you have the most reason to want that rat fucking dead.”

“Mather?” I ask. “He’s dead?”

“Just one of those things.” A round of laughter erupts, the easy laughter of the good guys when the bad guy has been eliminated. As far as they’re concerned, all is right in the world again. Justice has been served.

Six months ago, I would have agreed with them. Six months ago, I would have popped open a bottle of champagne and drained it before going down to the prison and pissing all over the corpse. He was a rat who fucked my entire life, and he deserved to die.

That opinion hasn’t changed.

It’s me that’s changed.

Instead of going to my room for a shower, which was my intention before hearing the news, I head straight for the elevator and take it up to Aspen’s level. She must’ve heard if word has spread the way it has. There isn’t a doubt in my mind that someone took pleasure in delivering the news personally. Probably more than one someone.

I didn’t expect her to answer at my first knock. “Aspen. Open up. It’s me.” When all I get in response is silence, I knock louder, barely stopping short of pounding. “Aspen. Come on. Let me in.”

She wouldn’t do anything extreme, would she? *Dammit*. “At least let me know you hear me.”

She does better than that. The knob turns, and a moment later, I’m treated to the sight of her red, tearstained face.

The fact that I’m sweaty doesn’t seem to matter. She launches herself into my arms, holding me the way I’d imagine someone would clutch a life raft in the middle of open water.

I maneuver us into the room and close the door, locking it before lifting her over my arms and carrying her shaking body to the bed. She won’t let go long enough for me to place her on top. I have no choice but to kick off my

shoes and lie down with her. For a long time, the only sound in the room is her wracking sobs and my soft murmuring. “I’m sorry. I really am.”

After what seems like an eternity, her sobbing turns to soft weeping. “It must have been so horrible,” she whispers. “When I think about how scared and hurt he must have been...”

I closed my eyes and sigh. Yes. It must have been terrible. I’m sure whoever did it didn’t spare her father a moment’s pain. He would have been lucky to catch a shiv to the kidney when the guard turned his back, but something tells me his death wasn’t that merciful—not after what he did. Men like him don’t receive the benefit of mercy.

“You can’t think about it,” I soothe, stroking her hair while she continues to cling to me. “It will only hurt worse the more you think about it. If he was in pain, he isn’t anymore. You can’t let yourself imagine it.”

“How can I not? He was my dad! I know he was wrong. I know he did bad things, but I still...”

“Go on,” I murmur, my lips close to her ear. “You can say it.”

“I loved him.”

“I know. Even when we hate our parents, we can’t help but love them.” I should know. Here I am, lying in her bed, doing everything I can to help her keep it together, and all the while, I know my father is responsible for this. At least, I seriously suspect it. Who else has the pull or the resources?

To say nothing of the grudge he held. *We* held. It was always going to end this way. The more I think about it, the more surprised I am that it took this long.

“I know you’re only pretending to care.” She presses her face against my shoulder, but nothing could muffle the bitterness in her voice.

“That isn’t true.”

Finally, she lifts her head, hitting me with a look of disgust. “Come on. You hated him. Everybody did. Don’t pretend you aren’t glad he’s gone.”

Why does she insist on putting me in this position? Isn't it enough that I'm here, holding her, doing everything I can to provide comfort when so few around here would? Haven't I already proven how much she means?

"Don't you know two things can be true at once?" Using my thumb, I catch fresh tears as they spill over her lashes. "No, I won't pretend I liked him or agreed with what he did. He was still your father, and that means something, too. I'm not an entirely heartless bastard."

"I know you aren't." She buries her face again, trembling. "I'm still so ashamed to say I loved him. Love him."

"I know. I've been ashamed to admit the same thing about my own father. If there's one man who doesn't deserve it, he's the one."

"I can tell you love him. You get a look on your face sometimes when you're around him. You and your whole family."

"I didn't know we were that transparent."

"You can't hide love." She might as well be talking about us. A part of me thinks she might be.

Her grip on me tightens until she practically squeezes the air out of my lungs. "What am I going to do? He's gone, and Mom is still missing."

"Still?" It doesn't come as a surprise. I'll play along for her sake, even though I doubt Mrs. Mather will show up any time soon. If ever.

"I don't have anybody anymore."

"That isn't true." I shouldn't say it. It'll only make things worse. How am I supposed to allow her to continue this way, feeling so alone? "You have somebody. And not only me, remember. You have Brittney. Lucas seems to have taken a liking to you. My mom and sister love you."

"Your dad hates me, so I think he cancels them out."

"He doesn't hate you. He wouldn't have let you step one foot in our home if he did. You're not alone."

She goes stiff. “I want to know who did it. Who killed him? I need to know. And Mom. I need to know what happened. I can’t go the rest of my life without knowing.”

I would warn her of how sometimes, not knowing is for the better. I would advise her not to kick the hornet’s nest. To leave things where they are and do her best to build a future since knowing the truth won’t change anything, but I can’t do that because I love her, even if I can’t say it out loud. I know what she needs to hear.

“I’ll find out for you. I promise.”

She looks up at me, and there’s that trust again, shining in her eyes. She trusts and needs me. “You will? You’re sure?”

“If it’s what you need, yes. Whatever it takes.” I hate the sense of writing a check I can’t cash, but it’s too late now. I’ve already committed.

“Thank you.” She exhales in relief. “I don’t know what I would do without you.”

“You’ll never have to find out. You’ll always have me to protect you.”

She wiggles against me, sliding a leg between mine. Soon we’re tangled from head to toe. I wonder how much more I can take before the desire to comfort her shifts into another sort of desire. I only have so much self-control. Especially when she wiggles a little and rubs her thigh over my crotch. Give me strength. Of all things she needs now, my erection poking her stomach isn’t one.

Once again, she wiggles her leg, and I have to wonder if it’s accidental. I pull my head back to look down at her. She’s already peering up at me from beneath her lashes. “What are you doing?”

She bites her lip. “You don’t know?”

“I thought I knew, but it doesn’t seem like now would be the time you’d want to do that.”

“It’s all I want.” Her hands clench, twisting my shirt in her fists. “I need something good. I need to be close to you.”

“Aspen, are you sure about this?” My body doesn’t care about questions and second thoughts, but what I feel for her is more than physical. I’m not a completely heartless bastard. It hasn’t been that long since her ordeal, and phone sex is one thing, but this?

“Yes.” She exhales out the word while melting against me. “Please make me feel good, Q.”

My conscience and my cock battle it out for a moment or two before she slips a hand between us and caresses my thickening member. “I need you. And I trust you.”

Fuck me. How am I supposed to say no to that? “If you’re absolutely sure.”

“I’ll let you know if I change my mind.” I can accept that. I can also accept her tits pressed against my chest and her hand now stroking the bulge between us. “Can we take it slow?”

“Whatever you need.” And I mean that. My arms tighten around her as my hands reacquaint themselves with the curves of her body. For a little while, that’s all we do, touching. Stroking. Getting back to that place where she feels comfortable.

I don’t know if it’s her need for connection or the fact that we haven’t done this in so long, but by the time I cup her ass and squeeze with more force than before, she’s moaning my name. Everything in me wants to go faster, to take her and fuck her until she passes out.

It wouldn’t be right. One of us has to keep that in mind.

“Slow down,” I murmur in her ear before kissing the lobe. “We have plenty of time.”

She has ideas of her own, it seems. “Touch me. Please.” She pries my hand from her ass and wedges it between her thighs, over her jeans. I barely apply pressure, rubbing in slow circles. Her head falls back, allowing me to place soft kisses up and down her throat. I only thought I remembered how her skin tastes, but there’s no memory vivid enough to measure up to the real thing.

Her fingers tangle in my hair, tugging before pressing my head tight against her throat. Her hips move in time with my hand. There's a desperation to her. She'll do anything to forget what she learned today, if only for a moment or two. I'll give her what she wants because it's all I can do.

"I've got you," I whisper when she clings tighter than ever, whimpering and mewling like a kitten. "You can let go. I'm right here."

"Yes... oh, Quinton..." She lets out a cross between a broken sob and a moan before her thighs clamp down around my hand. I hold her through it, murmuring encouragement and comfort. I know how difficult it must be, trusting again like this. That knowledge is all that's keeping me from tearing her clothes off and ravaging her. I'm so hungry.

Her eyes flutter open. The dazed look in them is gratifying. "More. Please." She tugs at my shirt and tries to raise it over my back.

"You mean it?"

Her head bobs up and down. I pull far enough away to remove the shirt and toss it off the bed. The simple sensation of her hands on my skin is heaven.

When she goes still with a soft gasp, I look down and remember the tattoo she hasn't yet seen. "What is this? It's new." She runs a thumb over the inked image.

"What do you think of it?"

Her eyes dart away from it and meet mine before she goes back to studying the work. "I think you wanted to commemorate surviving a bear attack. It's beautiful work."

"I designed it myself."

"You did? Wow." She still doesn't get it.

"Concentrate on the way the fur is arranged," I suggest, watching her brow furrow in thought. "There's a hidden message."

"A hidden..." Her mouth falls open as her finger traces the letters. "It's my name."

“That’s right. Hidden in plain sight.”

“I love it.” Her eyes sparkle when they meet mine again.

“I hoped you would.” I lift her hand from my arm and kiss her fingertips. “You’re always with me.” Instead of kissing her fingers, I brush my lips against hers this time. When she parts them to touch her tongue to mine, it’s all I can do not to growl into her mouth.

I roll us from our sides until she’s under me, then take my time touching her. Giving her the chance to stop things. She doesn’t, encouraging me with her breathless sighs when I unbutton her jeans and helping me work them over her hips and down her legs.

It’s when I work her sweater up over her tits, preparing to toss it on the floor with my shirt, she freezes. I do the same. “What is it? You need to stop?”

She shakes her head, but her scrunched expression tells another story. Her eyes are squeezed shut, her mouth set in a painful line. “What’s wrong?”

“I don’t want you to see. It’s so ugly.”

“Nothing about you is ugly.”

“It is. A... scar.”

I don’t remember her having scars—

Motherfucker. It wasn’t enough to violate her. One of them had to leave a permanent mark. I call on every ounce of my control to keep from tearing the room apart and making things worse.

She’s still distressed, which softens my rage. “Whatever it is,” I murmur, “it’s a sign of how resilient you are. Brave. Strong. It doesn’t have to be an unhappy reminder. It can remind you of how much you’ve overcome.”

“But it’s so ugly.”

“It belongs to you, which means it isn’t.” My heart is in my throat just the same as she pulls her arms free and raises the sweater over her shoulders. There it is. One of them fucking bit her hard enough to leave a scar.

I'd take it away if it meant wiping out every last memory of that ordeal. All I can do is lower my head and press my lips against it. "You're still perfect," I announce before kissing it again.

When I lift my head to look at her, there are tears in her eyes. But she's smiling. "Thank you."

I answer with one kiss, then another, and soon we're too wrapped up in each other for any more words.

Every step of the way, I expect her to stop me, but she doesn't. When I remove her bra and cup her tits. When I take her nipples into my mouth, reacquainting myself with their taste and the way she claws my shoulders when I tongue them. I kiss a trail down her body, worshiping every inch of skin my lips touch.

Her panties are plastered over her soaked pussy. I look up at her, questioning, and she answers by tugging the waistband down over her hips, nodding. Her aroma makes my mouth water, and the sight of her excitement coating her lips has my cock threatening to burst out of my jeans. I have to open my fly to relieve the pressure before diving into her pink, dripping folds.

But slowly. Carefully. This isn't taking ownership or claiming what I want. It's making sure she knows I still want her. She's still as gorgeous and hot and perfect as ever. Nothing can ever take that away, and she needs to know it.

I tell her with every sweep of my tongue over her lips, every drop of nectar I lap up, every probe of my tongue against her dripping hole. She's so brave, giving herself to me, opening up again. She deserves all the pleasure she can handle.

It's not long before she's riding my face, and I let her do it, giving her what she needs most while her body takes the rest. My approving groans only push her higher, and by the time her thighs squeeze tight enough to deafen me, I understand there's more to this than satisfying my needs or even gratifying my ego by making her scream my name.

It's still just as gratifying to hear it, though, so loud even her thighs can't block out the sound of my name repeated until she loosens her grip and falls back against the mattress.

She's lost in a fog of satisfaction, her body flushed, her chest rising and falling with every ragged breath. "Mmm... that was nice."

"Seemed like you enjoyed it," I point out, chuckling between kisses against her inner thighs while her fingers run through my hair. Every fiber of my being is screaming its need to be inside her. My cock aches, the wet spot on my shorts a testament to how much her arousal turns me on. I've never had to fight the urge like this. I've never met anybody worth the fight until now.

When I stretch out over her again, she takes my face in her hands and draws it closer to kiss. "Thank you." Her legs wrap around my hips, drawing me closer. It's agony, holding back when my covered cock pushes up against her pussy.

And she senses it, pulling back, her eyes searching my face. "I'm about ready to come," I confess through gritted teeth. "You're too tempting."

"You don't have to resist." She reaches down to lower my jeans.

"You're sure?"

"Absolutely."

Fuck, I can't fight it anymore. I need her too much, and she wants this the way I do. "I'll go slow." She nods, biting her lip, then moans when my head lines up with her quivering hole.

Instead of impaling her with one quick, deep thrust, I ease my way inside. It's the sweetest torture, entering her an inch at a time. Her muscles tighten around me, drawing me deeper, the way her legs draw my hips closer.

Rather than withdraw right away, I remain in place, kissing her while she clings to me. When I grind my hips, she moans into my mouth and threatens to make me come, but I fight it off in hopes of making her come with me.

We move like this, working together, my cock buried deep inside her while I grind against her clit. It's unreal how right it feels. How much better than

anything ever has. Her body wrapped around mine. The way she clings to me and moans into my mouth with every slow, sensual grind stimulating her clit and G-spot at once.

“Come with me,” I grunt between kisses, and she whimpers in agreement before her muscles begin to tighten. To ripple. She’s almost there, and oh, fuck, it’s so good.

The familiar tingling at the base of my spine suddenly explodes. There’s nothing left but to hold on to each other to keep from falling apart while I come until my ears ring and cum leaks out around my cock, mixed with her juices.

Holy shit. I’m almost afraid to lift my head from the pillow behind hers once I finish roaring my release. I’ve never been that real with anybody before. That tender and open and considerate. Only Aspen.

The way she strokes the back of my neck tells me I have nothing to worry about. “Thank you,” she whispers like a prayer in my ear while our breathing slows and reality leaks back in.

I’ve lost myself to this woman. I can’t bring myself to care when she’s all I’ll ever want.

Even if every second we spend together is a mistake.

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ASPEN

*I*t's always the same.

He walks into the shower room and realizes he's alone with nothing but the sound of dripping water echoing off the cold tiles. Does the hair at the back of his neck stand up? Do his instincts scream at him to go, to turn around and get out of there?

It doesn't matter. It's already too late.

When the door behind him opens, he knows it's over. He's been waiting for it, expecting it even. Occasionally, hoping it wouldn't come to pass, that he would be safe, but he's seen enough angry glares and heard enough knowing snickers. It was always going to end this way.

Three men enter the room. They're dressed in orange prison jumpsuits and wear identical murderous expressions. They look at him like he's garbage, but then again, that's how everyone has looked at him since he arrived.

But now, there's no one to stop them. And when a flash of something metallic and sharp gleams in the very corner of his eye, the strangest sense of relief washes over him. At least it will be quick. That's the best he can hope for now.

Until another one of them punches his open palm, his smile widening. "I've been looking forward to this," the man growls, and my father understands they have no intention of being merciful. Not until his blood paints the

walls, the floor, not until it pools over the grimy tile and mixes with the water lingering around the edges of the drains.

“Aspen. Aspen, wake up.”

My eyes pop open, and I realize I can’t breathe, my chest is too tight, my lungs won’t fill. I can’t see anything in front of me but darkness, making it easy for the image from my dream to follow me into awareness. I’m not there. There’s no shower room, no bright fluorescent lights. I’m safe.

I’m in Quinton’s arms, and Quinton is doing everything he can to calm me down. “You’re safe. You were having a nightmare.”

Only a nightmare. The same nightmare that insists on playing in my subconscious every time I close my eyes in the past two days. Some details might change. Sometimes, he’s in the prison laundry. Sometimes, there’s a riot elsewhere in the prison to draw attention from a murderer ordered to slice his throat.

Everything I know about prison I’ve learned from TV and movies. I don’t know if anything in my imagination is true or realistic. I only know how vivid it seems when I’m caught in the middle of a dream.

And if I fell back to sleep right now, I know I would only pick back up where I left off—like hitting pause on a TV show.

I force myself to breathe more slowly, counting four beats for each inhale, then four on the exhale. Slowly, my heartbeat settles to a more reasonable speed, and the tremors rattling my bones cease. “That’s right,” he whispers, and his warm breath on my ear is comforting. It grants me calm and brings me back to the present.

“Thank you,” I manage once I’m settled down enough to speak.

“Are you okay?”

I shake my head, and his arms tighten around me. My body is curled against his, the little spoon to his big spoon. I know I should feel secure like this, and I do, but even Quinton Rossi isn’t enough to save me from my dreams. That’s the one thing he can’t do.

“You remember what the doctor suggested?”

“I don’t want drugs.” Quinton talked to Dr. Lauren yesterday after I kept waking up in the middle of the night. She offered some sleeping pills, but I declined.

“It’s just something to help calm you down to sleep better.”

“I know, but how does she know I won’t get locked into one of those dreams and not be able to get out?” I’ve already told him all about it, about how I both witness Dad’s murder while also seeing it through his eyes. Through his thoughts.

Of course, I know this is all my imagination. There hasn’t been any confirmed explanation of how my father came to lose his life, not that I expect one. If there was, I wouldn’t want to hear it. Though I’m sure not much could be worse than what my imagination has already come up with, I don’t need any of those images cemented in my brain as being the truth. So long as I can tell myself it’s all in my head, I can bear it.

As well as I’m bearing it so far, that is.

“I think the idea is more like blanking you out, so you won’t dream. Knocking you deep into sleep. You need more than an hour at a time. Nobody can last long that way.”

“You never sleep for very long.”

“I manage more than an hour at a stretch without...” He cuts himself off, but I know what he was thinking. Without waking up in a cold sweat, without screaming, without almost falling out of bed.

I’m too tired to argue. I’m too tired for anything. “I don’t know. Maybe.”

“Do you want me to go talk to her?”

“It’s the middle of the night, isn’t it?”

“I’ll call in the morning.” He presses a kiss against my jaw, snuggling me even closer. “I’ll take care of it.”

Rather than asking him not to go, I bite the inside of my cheek. I don't want him to leave me alone in his room. I haven't been alone in two days. It made more sense for me to stay with him than the other way around since technically, he's not supposed to wander around that level the way he can elsewhere. And while Lucas is willing to overlook my missing lessons for a few days, I have no doubt Xander would fly to Corium at the first opportunity to make sure I leave his son alone.

"Are you hungry? I can make you something to eat."

My stomach churns at the thought of taking a single bite. "I'm fine for now."

"Aspen. You've hardly eaten anything in days."

"I told you, I don't have an appetite."

"But you need to take care of yourself. You need to let me take care of you." When all I do is sigh, he goes for the throat. "He wouldn't want you torturing yourself."

How do you know what he would want? Why would you care? Right now, Quinton is the last person in the world who deserves my bitterness. It's a knee-jerk reaction after months of being hated by everyone around me. Almost dying more than once because of their opinions of Dad. All of a sudden, it matters what my father would have wanted?

"Maybe later," I concede. "I just want to stay like this for now."

"Whatever you want." I know better than to think the argument is over. He's going to push me later on. I know I have to eat and drink and take care of myself, but right now, it almost seems unfair for me to do that when Dad is dead and Mom...? She could be, too, for all I know. She might have already been dead by the time I got home after the gas leak before...

I squeeze my eyes shut, pushing away the thoughts threatening to bubble to the surface. There's already more than enough to keep me on edge and unable to function without that terrible night coming back to haunt me.

We fall into a peaceful silence, but I know better than to think Quinton has fallen asleep. It's enough for us to just lie here, wrapped up in each other,

waiting for morning to come. Things seem more bearable in the daytime.



WHAT TOOK YOU SO LONG?

I force myself to swallow back the question threatening to tumble from my lips when Quinton opens the door. I don't want him to know how I practically counted the seconds from the time he stepped out of the room until now, sitting cross-legged in the center of the bed, willing him to come back.

It's one thing for him to take care of me, but everyone has their limits. The last thing I want is to push him away by clinging too tight.

"The doctor only gave me a few pills," he explains, pulling a small packet from his jeans and leaving it on the nightstand. "She said you shouldn't have any problems with nightmares if you take one. It will knock you right out. And if you need more, she's happy to provide them, but she can't give them out too freely. Not even to you."

"I understand." The idea of sleeping without dreaming seems too good to be true, but I trust her. She's one of the few people around here I actually trust.

He sits on the bed, taking my hand. There's something so comforting about his touch. Warmth flows from my hand up my arm, across my shoulders, loosening the muscles. Almost like I'm standing under a hot shower. "She asked if you were eating, by the way. I wasn't about to lie about it. And she warned me if you don't have something today, you might have to drink more of those terrible smoothies to get your nutrients."

"Anything but that," I murmur, rolling my eyes.

"Let us take care of you. All we want to do is make sure you get through this. You know that, right?"

His words should bring me comfort the way his touch does, but I'm still too bitter to accept it at face value. "Sure, you and the doctor, and a couple of other people. That's not the opinion of everyone around here, I'm sure."

The way he averts his gaze tells me I'm right, though I didn't need confirmation. I doubt I've earned any sympathy.

"You know you're still safe here, right? That won't change. Everyone knows better than to fuck with you."

Everyone? I can't help but wonder. I haven't told him about that run-in with Nash a while back. I'm not even sure whether it would be worth telling him about it in the first place. Why start trouble where there doesn't need to be any?

Besides, I don't want to ruin this time together. Things are bad enough without me bringing drama that may or may not exist into the mix.

Eventually, I'm going to have to leave this room. Not only because it would be unhealthy for me to become a recluse. Life, such as it is, needs to go on. There's a limit to the allowances people are willing to make for the grieving.

"How did you do it?" I whisper, threading my fingers through his.

"Do what?"

"How did you go on with life when you hurt so much over Adela?" His sharp intake of breath tells me I hit a nerve. I knew I would. He still doesn't talk much about her, though at least he doesn't have to pretend with me that she's still alive.

"I can't imagine having to pretend," I confess. "But on the outside, you were fine. Normal."

He blurts out a dark laugh. "Normal? I'm not sure I know what that means."

"You weren't a basket case the way I am now."

"You didn't see me when it first happened," he reminds me in a quiet voice. At least he isn't angry with me for bringing her up. "As for carrying on with life, you've done the same. I know you're tired of hearing this by now, but you're much stronger than you give yourself credit for." It's like the same song stuck on an endless loop.

That doesn't mean I don't appreciate his encouragement. "I wish I saw myself as strong. I mean, I've broken down. I can't stand the thought of being away from you for the twenty minutes it took you to see the doctor and come back."

When he reaches for me, I scoot across the bed so he can wrap me in his arms. I lower my head to his chest, pressing my cheek against it, listening to his heart's steady, reassuring beat. "I don't like leaving you either," he admits. "It isn't easy for me to know you're hurting and know there's nothing I can do to take the hurt away. I can only try to help you through it."

"And you are." My arms slide around him, linking behind his back. He's my lifeline, the one thing keeping me grounded. Holding me together when it feels like the slightest jolt will leave me shattered in a million pieces.

No, it's better that I don't say anything about Nash now. I don't want to bring him or anybody else into our world. Not while I have him like this.

I have no idea how much longer this can last. Being together, the two of us and nobody else. His presence is all I've craved ever since returning to school, and now I have it.

I don't want to spoil it.

QUINTON

Finally, she's asleep. So deep asleep, I've checked more than once to make sure she's still breathing. Doctor Lauren wasn't kidding when she warned those pills would knock her out.

Since I haven't been able to get to the gym, I settle for a modified version of my workout routine here in the room. Push-ups, crunches, pushing myself until sweat rolls down my back and drips from my chin. Even my heavy breathing isn't enough to make Aspen stir from her cocoon of blankets.

No matter how much sweat drips to the floor, there's no calming the storm inside me. The questions, the rage. The concern overrides everything else.

She doesn't need to know I visited with more than the doctor earlier before she took a pill and went to sleep. It's not a betrayal, keeping things from her. Deciding what she needs to know.

Besides, she's already aware of plenty. How everyone is still celebrating Mather's death. Taking sadistic pleasure in knowing how he must have suffered. They're sharks who smell blood in the water, and they're circling. They know better than to fuck with Aspen. I checked in with Ren, who's my eyes and ears as he goes about his normal routine while I hang back to take care of her. All it takes is a sharp look from him to remind them of the consequences should they attack her when she emerges from isolation.

What I've struggled with all morning and feel like I should warn her about is Nash. I hadn't seen him since bringing Aspen to my room but knew he must have been celebrating with everyone else. We happened to cross paths as I was leaving the medical wing.

"There he is. Just the guy I've been wanting to touch base with." He goes so far as to clap me on the shoulder like we just won the championship game or something like that.

"What's going on?"

He bursts out laughing. "You're kidding, right? This place has been like Christmas. Don't tell me you're not glad that rat bastard got what he deserved. Your family suffered worse than anybody."

"Sometimes the wheel turns slowly, but it does eventually turn."

"So the Rossi family is vindicated." He cups his hands around his mouth and mimics the roar of a crowd before jamming them into his pockets. "Now, maybe the Valentine family can have that same peace. What's left of them, that is."

Instantly, my hackles rise, but if there's one thing I'm good at, it's concealing my inner thoughts. "I didn't know you were so close with them."

"I'm not, but let's face it. If it could happen to them, it could happen to anybody. If it's not one threat, it's another, right?"

"We should all keep that in the back of our minds. There's always a new threat waiting to rear its head on the heels of the last one." This is taking too long—besides, even without the knowledge of Aspen waiting for me, I wouldn't want to go any further with this conversation. My father's warning rings out in the back of my mind. Tread lightly.

"You see Aspen around here? I heard she basically locked herself in her room and won't come out."

What the fuck does he know...or think he knows? "She hasn't been around much since we got back from break, so it's not a surprise." I lift a shoulder and try to remember how it felt when I genuinely didn't care if she lived or died. "She's doing us all a favor by hiding."

“That’s a good point.” Before I can get away, he lifts his chin toward the doors leading to the medical wing. “Why were you visiting the doctor? You feeling okay?”

“Just a little under the weather. I hope it’s nothing contagious.” I cough into my fist, and he takes a backward step. “See you around.”

Now, with my shoulders and arms burning too much to support me through one more push-up, I roll onto my back and stare at the ceiling, my chest heaving. It isn’t the ceiling I see in front of me, though.

It’s Aspen, lying on that filthy floor, caked with blood and cum and barely alive. I did what had to be done for her sake.

Though I might have sentenced her to death if the connection is ever made between her and what happened to the Valentine family.

By the time I get up and head for the shower, she’s still sleeping soundly. It isn’t until I emerge from the bathroom that she begins to stir.

For a moment, all I can do is stand in the doorway and watch, overcome with feelings so deep they almost knock me off my feet. Who knew something as simple as watching someone wake up could be so compelling? She stretches and yawns, sighing softly, still stuck between sleep and awareness.

Then she opens her eyes and offers a sleepy smile. “Hi.”

“Hi.”

“How long was I out for?”

“Only around four hours or so. I expected you to sleep a lot longer than that.”

“I probably would have if my bladder wasn’t about to burst.” I step aside so she can get past me, walking around the bed on my way to the dresser.

Something stops me. Instead of getting dressed, I pick up the pillow Aspen slept on, still warm and smelling of her shampoo. I lift it to my nose, my eyes closing so I can focus solely on her scent. I inhale as much air as my lungs will hold, willing myself to commit every part of her to memory.

When she opens the door, I'm still standing with the pillow in my hands. Our eyes meet, and whatever she sees in mine makes her sigh. "I have to go, don't I?"

I want more than anything in the world to tell her no, that we'll get through this together and to hell with the rest of the world. But I can't ignore the obvious. For her sake or mine. "I'm afraid so."

Her chin quivers, and she may as well take a knife to my heart for all the pain it brings me. "I don't want to be alone," she whispers.

"You know I'm always here. You can call me, text." That clearly offers no comfort, and I can't blame her. I lower the pillow to the bed and reach for her. "It's for the best."

Instead of walking into my arms, she stays where she is. "Would you please explain why it's so important we stay away from each other? And don't give me any more of that pushing me away bullshit like you did before. I'm not buying it. Why is it so important nobody sees us together? If everybody knows they're not allowed to screw with me anymore, what's the harm? They already know you are protecting me."

I drop to the bed, leaning forward to lower my head into my hands. She was always going to want to know. She deserves to know. "Do you think this is easy? Pushing you away? Haven't I proven to you what you mean to me? I would burn the world down for you."

"But you won't walk down the hall with me."

"I can't have anybody know we're linked." When she responds with silence, I add, "Especially after what I did to Matteo's family. That isn't what gets glossed over. You should know by now how deep a grudge can run."

The shifting of the bedsprings tells me she takes a seat at my side. "Nobody knows you did that."

"Here's hoping." I lift my head to find her looking distressed. "Truthfully, I can't say for sure. There is a chance of someone putting things together. Finding out what happened to you and connecting that to the family's demise. All it takes is one asshole who thinks they're smart seeing the two

of us together and adding things up for you to be in worse danger than ever.”

She closes her eyes, her mouth falling open. “Because they’ll know you did it for me.”

“Exactly. And it’s not only you. What would happen to my mom? To Scarlet? I have to keep them in mind, as well.”

“Why didn’t you tell me before?”

“I didn’t want you blaming yourself.” It looks like she’s going to protest, and I shake my head before she can get a word out. “Don’t say you wouldn’t. We both know that would be a lie.”

She takes my hand, squeezing tight. “Okay. We’ll do it this way. I’ll stay away from you, and you’ll stay away from me. For everybody’s sake.”

“You have no idea how it burns me up inside, knowing I have to leave you alone.”

“Now that I understand why, it will be easier to manage. Not knowing why you pushed me away was worse than anything else.” The brave little smile she wears nearly rips me in half. How can she be brave after everything she’s suffered?

I reach for her with my free hand, burying it in her hair and drawing her face close to mine. We look into each other’s eyes for an instant before our lips meet in a long, slow kiss. My whole body ignites, urging me for more. My chest aches, knowing it has to stay with a kiss.

If my enemies have their way, it will be our last.

I have no intention of letting that happen.



AT FIRST, when I hear the insistent knocking on my door, I think Aspen must have come back. I was about to turn in for the night, and now I wonder if she’s too afraid to sleep alone in her room. On one hand, the fact

she would come to me is gratifying. She knows she's safe with me. I want nothing more than to be her comfort and protection.

On the other hand, if anyone saw her...

"Quinton? Please, open up." That's not Aspen's voice, but it is one I vaguely recognize. And it's thick with tears.

I open the door to find Brittney weeping, and immediately my heart leaps into my throat. "What happened? Where is she?" I take her by the arms and barely stop short of shaking her.

"No, she's fine. As far as I know, anyway. A-and I c-can't imagine how." Tears rolled down her cheeks, leaving trails of mascara behind. "I did what you asked."

Shit. I sit her down on the bed, and she wraps her arms around herself before rocking back and forth a little. "You got into the phone?"

Her head bobs up and down before a broken sob tears itself out of her. "The video. He had the video. Oh, my god—"

We've never had a close relationship by any standards, but now we are united in this. Our perspective isn't precisely the same, but we both have reason to be shaken to the core by what we saw. I can't imagine that would be easy for a woman to witness, even knowing now that Aspen is safe and healed physically.

I hand her one of the bottles of water on the nightstand, intended for Aspen when she was here earlier. "I am sorry you had to see that," I murmur, and I mean it. I wouldn't wish it on nearly anyone.

"How could they? Those monsters. I didn't know..."

"You couldn't have." I leave a box of tissues beside her and wonder at myself. When did I grow a conscience? When did I start caring about people?

What a disingenuous question. It's Aspen. That's the tie that binds us. We have her in common, and Brittney clearly cares deeply about her.

I take a seat on the other side of the tissue box, absorbing this. Nash had a copy of the video, as I suspected he might. For once, I can't say I'm glad I was right.

"How could anybody do that?"

It's a rhetorical question, the sort nobody can answer. I've done some terrible, even unforgivable things, but the depravity recorded in that video is beyond even me. "I don't know."

"I feel filthy after seeing it."

"I'm sorry. I really am. If it wasn't so important, knowing for sure what Nash knows about that night, I wouldn't have taken the risk of you watching it. Really."

She drinks some water, then blows her nose. All I can do in the meantime is ask myself how Nash came to possess the video. Matteo must have sent it to him, or maybe Rico. How many other people might have seen it? How many people can tie her to a family who so mysteriously ended up dead only days later?

Once Brittney has calmed down, I ask the next logical question. "What did you do? After you saw it?"

"You mean besides throwing up?" She runs a hand under her eye to catch a stray tear. "I planted a virus on the phone. It wiped everything and is untraceable. He'll never know what happened."

"Thank you. Really. And I trust you'll keep this between us."

She moans softly. "How am I supposed to pretend I didn't see it? The next time she's with me, I have to act like I don't have the first idea?"

"You'll do it because you love her. And because if she's ever going to move on, she needs to know everyone around her isn't thinking about it whenever they set eyes on her." Our gazes meet, and in hers, I see the pain I feel inside. "We have to think about her, not ourselves."

"You're right. And God knows she has enough going on right now."

"Also true."

“I checked to see who he was messaging. He didn’t send the video out to anyone, but there was one number he kept texting and calling a lot. It just said D as the contact in the phone, but I traced the number and found out her name is Delilah Wallace. She seems to be connected to the Valentines somehow. I’m sending everything I have on her to your email.”

In a surprising move, she turns to me, grabbing my arm. “What are you going to do? Now that you know he had it. What happens to Aspen?”

“As long as I breathe, no harm will come to her ever again. I’m going to fix this. I promised her, and I’m promising you.” That seems to satisfy her, and she releases her grip on me.

The only trick now is working out exactly how I’m going to do it.

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ASPEN

*M*y stomach is in knots. There are wet spots on my jeans from wiping my sweaty palms so many times. I've been sitting here for only a few minutes, but it feels more like a few hours.

"Sorry to keep you waiting, Aspen," Dr. Lauren apologizes as soon as she enters the room. "You'd think we'd have better printers for such an elite university." She tries to lighten the mood with a joke, but I can't bring myself to lift the corners of my mouth even a little.

I'm too nervous, too scared of what she is going to tell me today. I haven't told Quinton I came here to get checked. I wanted to know for myself first.

Dr. Lauren takes the seat in front of me, placing a folder on her lap. "I went over the ultrasound and all your tests again. Even contacted a friend of mine who is an OB/GYN to be sure since this is not my expertise. She agreed that my original diagnosis was correct. There is no permanent damage. You should have no problem conceiving children when you are ready."

I suck in a breath, filling my lungs with much-needed oxygen. "Are you sure?"

"Yes, I've run every test possible. The drug they gave you most likely caused you to have a miscarriage. Your reproductive organs are all healthy, and though you had some internal bruising, there is no permanent scar tissue." Dr. Lauren gives me a reassuring smile, and this time, I'm able to smile back.

“Thank you. This really means a lot. I was so worried.”

“I know you were, and I am so glad I had good news for you. Now that we know you can get pregnant, would you like me to get you some birth control?”

“Yes, that would be great. I want kids, but I would like to wait a little. I have too much to figure out before I can be responsible for someone else.”

“Don’t worry. I have plenty of options for you.”

Dr. Lauren takes her time explaining different birth control to me, and I decide on getting the depo shot. One less thing to remember every day.

When I’m finally done and walking out of medical, I feel ten pounds lighter. Not wanting to waste my good mood, I head straight to the sunroom instead of going back to my apartment.

Something about sitting in the sunroom brings my spirits up even more. I’m sure it can’t be anything as simple as getting vitamin D in my system, but it can’t exactly hurt either. When I’m here, things feel simpler. Cleaner. It soothes my soul in a way even the library doesn’t.

I tip my head back, soaking in every bit of light filtering through the branches above me. Naturally, I chose this tree to sit against, the tree where Quinton and I had our moment in front of Vito. I still can’t believe that happened even now. It seems strange to have a fondness for the tree where something like that took place, but then not much about my relationship with Quinton makes sense on the surface.

Certain things can’t be put into words, things that can’t be reasoned. Emotion, intimacy.

Living in a fog for a week left me behind with my schoolwork. Everyone’s been understanding, something I’ve not quite gotten used to yet. I won’t take advantage of their kindness anymore. I need to pull myself together. Whatever happened to my parents has been done. It’s in the past. I can’t do anything to change it now. All I can do is change how I cope.

If there’s one thing I’ve learned how to do here at Corium, it’s cope. That, and Q, are the only reasons I’m still alive.

I lose track of how long I've been reading. It could be minutes, or it could be an hour. That's the beauty of being absorbed in reading. Time melts away. Only when I hear footfalls outside the sunroom of someone approaching do I glance up, my face half-hidden by the hair hanging alongside it. I'm rarely disturbed here, which is the main reason I choose to visit.

It doesn't make sense, the way my heart swells when I see him. He's beautiful in the sunlight, his dark hair shining, his graceful movement bringing to mind a sleek cat. This is hardly the first time I've set eyes on Q, yet for some reason, he still has the effect of a jolt to my heart. Like somebody put a set of paddles against my chest to shock me.

It can't be an accident, him coming here while I happen to be studying. Though he's avoided me since I left his room, I'm never without the sense of him being nearby. I don't know why that is. I only know it's a comfort.

He wanders across the room rather than look my way, covering the large space with slow, easy strides. Just a guy enjoying the sunshine. Stopping in front of a tree at the other end of the room, he sits, his knees bent and his legs spread slightly. When he rests his head against the trunk, he closes his eyes. If I had the talent, I would paint him. He's the most beautiful thing I've ever seen, with the sunbeams dancing off the planes of his cheek and forehead, highlighting his striking profile.

I can't sit here and stare openly at him for fear of somebody coming in and seeing. It's killing me not to be with him when all I want with every ounce is to run to him and throw myself into his arms. Now that I know the whole story and the stakes for all of us, it's easier to resist the craving.

Easier, but not easy.

I turn my attention back to my book though my concentration is shot. Not that I'm upset with him over it. I feel lighter and happier than I have in days, all thanks to setting eyes on him.

It shouldn't surprise me when my phone buzzes with a text, but the sudden sound startles me.

Q: Are you okay? How are you doing?

I glance up at him, but he's not looking my way.

Me: Is it safe texting me?

His response is immediate.

Q: These phones are secure. I wouldn't have given it to you if I thought anyone could hack it.

That's a relief. I've been too afraid even to do that after learning of why he pushed me away, worrying somebody might catch on. Now I know he's not completely out of reach.

Me: I've been okay. Trying to catch up on the work I missed. But getting by.

Q: I knew you would because that's who you are.

That's what I needed to hear. How does he always know exactly what I need most? Just like he always knew how to cut me with a well-chosen word. Then and now, we are connected by something invisible but strong. Unbreakable.

Q: Do you need anything?

Me: No, I'm fine. I have everything I need. Well, except one thing.

I glance up in time to see him grin while his thumbs fly over the screen.

Q: Is that why you chose that particular tree to sit under?

I should have known he would mention that. I might even be worried about him if he didn't.

Me: I love this tree. It's my favorite tree.

I look up from my phone to find him looking at me before we both avert our eyes. Even though we're alone here, it feels crucial to pretend we're not paying attention to each other.

Me: Should you even be here right now? It's dangerous.

Q: I wanted to make sure you're safe.

Me: You could have sent me a message and asked.

His response doesn't surprise me.

Q: There are certain things I need to see for myself.

I can't be annoyed. It's endearing.

Me: Still, it's dangerous. You probably shouldn't stay for long, just in case.

He's not as quick with his reply this time.

Q: I know. At least now I can picture you sitting under that tree. I need something to get me through my loneliness, if you know what I mean.

He adds a wink emoji to the end of it, and I can't help but giggle, even if I manage to keep it quiet.

A minute later, he's gone, leaving me alone again. But I'm never really alone. I always have him with me.



IT ISN'T until the sun's down and the sky goes dark that I pry myself off the ground. My butt and my back are tight after being in the same position for so long. A quick stretch loosens me up before I sling my backpack over one shoulder and walk to my room. The halls are mostly quiet, with everyone in their rooms before dinner, yet I make it a point to keep my head down and walk fast. Certain habits can't be undone overnight.

Sometime during my short walk, I get a new text message.

Q: Did you get back to your room all right?

I smile, leaving my bag near the door and flopping back on the bed. He's always thinking about me. My dark guardian angel.

Me: Safe and sound. What are you doing?

Q: You mean besides checking on you? Let's see. Thinking about you. Fantasizing about you. Missing you. It's been a full day.

Nobody would guess how funny he is when he's not busy being a big, scary guy.

Me: Sorry to take up so much of your schedule.

Q: There's only one other way I'd rather have it, and that would mean you being here with me or vice versa.

Even though my heart aches at our having to be apart, knowing he's in this with me makes all the difference. It doesn't heal the wound, but it eases the pain. God knows I've had enough of that.

Now that we're not face-to-face, there's something I'm tempted to ask him. I haven't had the nerve to bring it up in person. I don't want to watch his reaction for fear that it might hurt to see. We've never really talked about the baby. I don't even know if he would have wanted me to keep it had we found out while I was pregnant.

I don't think I could take it if he was dismissive or brushed it off. Not if we were in front of each other. Now, though, I have the courage.

Me: Can I ask you something?

Before he sends a response, I type out my question before I lose my nerve.

Me: If that night never happened, and I was still pregnant, what would you have done if I came to you and told you I was going to have a baby? What do you think your reaction would have been?

For a long time, my question sits there on the screen. There's no ellipsis to indicate he's typing a response. I should've known better. I shouldn't have brought it up.

Finally, after holding my breath nearly long enough to pass out, a new message pops up.

Q: I would call you right now to talk about it, but I don't want to risk anybody passing by and hearing. I want you to know that.

Me: I understand.

And I do. We can't take any chances.

Q: Had I known, had you come to me and told me you were pregnant, I guess it would've come as a shock.

Me: An unhappy shock. You know I didn't get pregnant on purpose.

Q: Aspen, when I say it would have been a shock, that's all I mean. I would have been shocked at first, as I'm sure you would be. And it might have taken a little time to wrap my head around it.

Tell me about it.

Me: That's true.

Q: But I would've loved our baby. I need you to know that, and I'm sorry I didn't tell you before. I didn't want to heap one more heartache on top of another. I didn't know if I could even mention it to you yet.

I'm so relieved I could almost cry.

Me: I didn't want to mention it to you either. I was so afraid you were glad.

Q: Glad? That our baby died? You have it all wrong. I would have done everything in the world to be a good father and to support you both. I would have protected that child to my dying breath, just as I will for you. You never have to question that.

I have to put the phone down for a moment in favor of covering my face with my hands and crying out all the tears I've held back so far. We could've been happy. We could've been a family, the three of us. There's no doubt that Quinton means every word he says. He isn't handing me platitudes now that there's no way to prove he doesn't mean them. He does mean them.

How much more do I need to lose before fate decides to give me a win? I remind myself not to ask that question because I might find out. And the only thing I have left besides Brittney is Quinton. I couldn't stand to lose either of them, but especially him.

He texts after a few minutes.

Q: You okay?

Me: Yes. It's a lot, is all.

Q: I know. And we've already been through enough.

A soft whimper escapes me, and I'm glad he can't hear.

Me: I saw Dr. Lauren today. She ran a few tests to confirm there was no permanent damage. She said I should have no problem having kids later in life.

Q: That's great. I'm glad you have that peace of mind.

Me: I wish I could be with you.

Q: I know. More than ever. Imagine me holding you right now. That's all I want to do. I'm with you right now, and you're in my arms with your head against my chest, and there's nothing in the world that can touch us.

I close my eyes and focus on his words. It's almost enough to make it feel real.

Almost.

QUINTON

I never thought I would develop a fondness for the sunroom, but it's quickly becoming my favorite place now that Aspen and I have made a routine of meeting up there a few times a week. If it were up to me, we would see each other every day, but neither of us is naïve. Tempting fate is one thing, but giving it the middle finger is another.

I have more to worry about than her alone. That's something I remind myself of on a daily basis, and the point drives itself home with every phone call from Scarlet.

Lately, she's been more interested in Aspen than in me. My jaw dropped when she whispered she knew about her father's murder. When I demanded she tell me how she found out, she was her usual blithe self. "Word gets around. I'm not supposed to know, but I heard about it."

Obviously, she hasn't put two and two together and guessed our father had something to do with it. I'm still not sure, but it seems most everyone else is. I've lost track of how many times I've caught someone staring at me with an inquisitive expression as if they wonder how my family pulled it off. It's for the best. These assholes have no idea how close I've come to beating the shit out of them.

She might pick up little bits of information here and there, but by and large, my sister is innocent. So is my mom. Remembering that and what might happen to them if I let things get out of hand here is sometimes all that keeps me grounded.

Though there's no denying the warmth that floods me when I step into the sunroom to find Aspen sitting under our tree. We've never carved our initials into it or anything corny like that, but it's still ours. The fact that it means something to her means the world to me. After a quick once-over to make sure she is doing well, I head over to my customary spot clear on the other end of the room. There are a few people here, lying on their backs to soak in the rays, but otherwise, we're alone as always. Now that I've made it a habit to stop in every day or two, it seems less out of the ordinary. No one will think twice about me being in the same place as her.

That's what I need to tell myself.

There's a message from her waiting for me by the time I sit down.

A: Took you long enough to get here. I was getting worried.

Me: Remember, we can't make this look too scheduled.

A: I know. I was worried, is all.

I do my best to hide a grin even though my back is to most of the room.

Me: You never have to worry about me. How are you today? We fall into our usual back and forth, comparing notes. She tells me about the self-defense lessons she's getting from Lucas, which is an excellent idea I wish I had thought of. How was I supposed to know he would develop a liking for her? He wouldn't have volunteered to be her tutor if he didn't care. Knowing she has him on her side has gone a long way toward blunting the knife-edge of my concerns.

Me: You'll have to try those moves out on me sometime. Show me what you're working with.

A: I owe you one, don't I? If I recall, you choked me out once.

Me: You're never going to let that go, are you?

I ask though I know she shouldn't. I'm not proud of myself for a lot of things.

A: Not a chance.

She assures me, adding a winking face at the end so I know she's joking, or at least only half-serious.

Though this isn't close to the ideal arrangement, it has a certain charm. I can understand now why men and women back in the day used to correspond through letters and get to know each other that way. It's almost easier to share myself like this, to say things I couldn't find the words for if we were face-to-face.

Not that our discussions are usually very deep or heavy. Normally, we talk about our families, the sort of getting to know you stuff most people cover early in their relationship. Our relationship didn't exactly start in the usual way. We didn't do too much sharing.

Another thing she's taught me: the importance of turning toward happy memories rather than away from them. In the months following Adela's death, the mere thought of her was unbearable. Walking through rooms where we used to play together as kids. Seeing her empty chair during the rare times the family managed to get together for a meal. Passing her bedroom. It was like a burning coal in my heart. The pain was excruciating.

Now, I can smile. It isn't easy talking about her for long stretches, but I find myself wanting to do it more and more. I want Aspen to know who she was, especially since the two of them had a connection I knew nothing about. They would have gotten along so well if things were different.

She avoids talking about her father, and I don't know if that's because of what he did or because the wound is still raw. Instead, she tells me about the good times before everything went to hell. She was popular and got perfect grades. Neither of those two facts surprises me in the least. I've seen how smart she is, and as for popularity, I have no doubt if it weren't for her father's traitorous actions, she would be the most popular girl here. She's beautiful, funny, whip-smart. She would have instructors wrapped around her little finger and be surrounded by admirers.

Male admirers, especially. That wouldn't last long once I set my sights on her, of course. No one competes with me once I set my mind on what I want.

I used to hate her father for what he did to my family. The way he did everything he could to avoid being sentenced, thinking he could get one over on my father. As if we didn't have enough going on surrounding Adela, though, of course, he didn't know about that. Nobody did.

Now I hate him more for what he did to Aspen. She had her whole future mapped out in her mind. She was going to college, then med school to become a doctor. I have no doubt her compassionate nature would make her an excellent healer. He robbed her of that. He robbed her of so many things.

He put her life in jeopardy. I hate him for that more than anything else.

A: I think I might still want to try to go to school for it. Med school, I mean. I don't know how I'd make it happen, though. My life hasn't gone in the straight line med schools tend to favor, you know?

Me: If it's what you want, we'll make it work.

I won't go so far as to make promises until I'm sure, but it seems I could help her make that happen. She shouldn't have to sacrifice her dreams because of her father's reckless decisions.

Darkness falls, almost surprising me. It's too easy to become absorbed in our conversations. Time ceases to mean anything.

A: I'll go first.

By the time I glance away from her message, she's already standing, picking up her backpack. I shouldn't check out her ass, but I'm only human. There's only so much I can do to control myself when she's involved.

Before gathering my things and leaving the room, I wait for ten, maybe fifteen minutes. Even though I should go to the gym, it isn't the same as it used to be. I need the exercise, but the roiling, burning rage that once carried me through punishing workouts doesn't exist anymore. I'm still on the lookout, still questioning the motives of nearly everyone around me, but the pain I wrestled with on first arriving here this year isn't all-consuming anymore. I don't need to work myself to the point of exhaustion to keep from killing anybody.

“Hey. Q.”

I lift my gaze, looking farther down the hall, and my heart sinks. Vito. It's been weeks since that night, the attack, climbing through the vents. I hope he doesn't think that made us friends.

Still, I lift my chin in greeting. Once we're closer, I ask, "What's going on?" Not exactly friendly, but not nasty either. I'm still not sure if he's a friend or foe, and I would hate to alienate a potential ally.

The way his eyes sweep the hall tells me he has something of importance to share. He crooks a finger, leading me to a quiet alcove. I follow, my suspicions on high alert, ready to react to whatever this is about.

He doesn't keep me waiting. "I wanted to give you a heads-up," he murmurs.

"About what?"

One more look up and down the hall. "Nash."

It's a challenge remaining straight-faced. "What about him?" I ask as if the name means nothing.

He barely stops short of rolling his eyes. "Let's cut to the chase, shall we? He thinks he knows something. I'm not going to ask you for details, so don't worry about that."

"I won't."

"But it seems he's become obsessed with learning what happened to the Valentine family over the holidays."

I blink. "What does that have to do with me?"

This time, he does roll his eyes. "Anyway, you might like to know he's suspicious. Of her." He never mentions her name, but there's no need to. And he knows it, unfortunately.

"Why?"

"Of that, I am not so sure." Either he is the world's greatest actor, or he's telling the truth. "He won't say. I've asked him more than once, but he only gives me this strange smile and tells me I'll see."

I don't know how much more of this I can take without exploding. Vito has never been my favorite person, but it would be a shame to take my sudden rage out on him when all he's trying to do is help.

There's one thing I need to know over anything else. "Why are you telling me this?"

He dips his chin, hitting me with a sour look. "You can drop the act with me. I've seen all I need to see of the two of you to know she's more to you than a toy you can toss around. And she's a nice girl, despite her pedigree." That we can agree on.

So it's not enough for Nash to keep his suspicions to himself. He's going wide, dropping hints. How the fuck did he have that video in the first place? The burning need to go to him, to tear parts of his body free until he confesses is almost too much to resist.

But that would mean admitting I know about the video. That I, too, know about that night and about why the family died. I can't implicate myself like that when it means the lives of those I love.

"Thank you." I don't dare say more, but he doesn't seem to expect it. He only gives me a firm nod before walking away. I wait a moment or two before emerging back into the hall, my feet slapping against the floor with every purposeful step.

If he doesn't quit this, I'm going to have to kill him, and there isn't a doubt in my mind that I'll enjoy it, but for now, a workout will have to be sufficient.

I'm on my way back to my room when my phone vibrates in my pocket. The tiny hairs on the back of my neck stand on end. I'm not sure why, but it makes sense as soon as I pull my phone from my pocket. My father's name flashes across the screen. Without hesitation, I hit the answer key and bring the phone to my ear.

"We found her...the mystery girl." My father's deep voice fills my ear. It takes a moment for my mind to catch up with his statement.

"Found her..." I repeat out loud.

“Yes. I’m going to need you to come home so we can deal with this.”

“Of course.” I grit my teeth, knowing what’s going to come next. I’ve never killed a woman before, never even considered it, but for Aspen, I’ll do anything, kill anyone. I’ll burn the fucking world down for her.

“Be ready in twenty minutes,” my father orders, and then the line goes dead. I pull the phone away from my ear and stare at it for a moment, wondering if there are any lengths I won’t go to protect Aspen.

I don’t have to think for long. Anyone who had a part in hurting her will pay dearly. Aspen has and always will be mine.

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ASPEN

I stare at my phone, reading the text from Quinton for the hundredth time.

Q: Can't meet tonight, but I promise I'll make it up to you.

It's the last text I got from him, and that was yesterday afternoon. Since then, I've texted him half a dozen times and got no response.

My mind is reeling, coming up with every bad situation and scenario possible. Why couldn't he meet me? Is someone onto us? We've been so safe, making sure we don't sit together and aren't seen with each other. I stare down at my phone, willing my heart to stop beating like I just ran a marathon.

The ground our relationship stands on is unsteady. We can't be together, but somehow, we can't be apart. If anyone suspects he killed the entire Valentine bloodline for me, horrible things will happen.

I text him another text message, asking if he's okay, and hit send. I know better than to assume something terrible happened to him. After all, his father is the head of the mob, and Quinton isn't your typical college boy. He can protect himself just fine. Still, there's this nagging worry at the back of my mind.

Putting my phone on the nightstand, I grab the book I was reading earlier and open it to a new chapter. I need to get my mind off Quinton. A fictional book boyfriend will have to do.

I've barely read the first paragraph of the chapter when my phone vibrates against the wood. I drop the book like it's on fire and lean over to grab my phone. My stomach tightens with anticipation of Quinton's incoming text, only it's not him who texts me. It's Brittney.

Brittney: Hey, I need your help with something. Find me in study room E in the library.

The excitement of getting a text from Quinton fizzles away. He's probably fine. Meanwhile, Brittney needs my help, and I'll do anything at this point to keep my mind off Q. I type out a quick *on my way* message and hit send. Then I roll out of bed and grab a cardigan off the chair, tugging it on while I slip my feet into a pair of ballet flats.

I didn't have anywhere to go today, but I still got up, put on a pair of black leggings and a T-shirt. I even braided my hair just to have something to do.

Once I'm dressed, I head out the door, making sure I have my phone and room card. The hall is quiet like always as I step out of my room. It isn't until I get to the next floor that things become a little more hectic. Most of the students are already in class, but a few stragglers rush down the hall, passing by me without a glance.

I withhold the incessant need to peer over my shoulder and see if anyone is following me. I'm a basket case at best, waiting for Nash to jump out and try to corner me again.

The thoughts disappear as soon as I reach the library, the huge arched doors calling to me like a beacon. To me, home is anywhere a good book can be found, and this place is full of them.

With a beaming smile, I walk into the library and head straight to the study rooms at the back of the library. Stopping once I reach room E, I grab the door handle, and open the door. I flip on the light switch, and the room fills with light.

As soon as I step inside and find Quinton standing there with a smirk on his face, his inky hair disheveled, and his dark brown eyes turning molten, I realize this was a setup for something else entirely.

Without speaking, I rush forward instead and wrap my arms around his middle. I bury my face in his chest, his spicy scent filling my nostrils and calming me instantly.

He returns the hug, squeezing all my fragile pieces back into place. We remain this way for a few lingering seconds, neither of us wanting to let go. His lips graze the top of my head, and a shiver works its way down my spine.

When we finally pull away from each other, the words flow out of me like an overflowing sink.

“What happened? Why couldn’t you meet me?” I try not to sound as desperate as I feel, but I hate feeling like I’m being kept in the dark. I know he’s doing what he can to protect me, but I want to know what’s going on, too, especially when it concerns me.

Something dark flickers in Quinton’s eyes. “My father called, and I had to return to North Woods. It was a quick flight home. Nothing bad happened. I didn’t anticipate being gone long, which I wasn’t, but any time away from you seems like forever.”

I grin, pushing up onto my tiptoes. “You said you’d make it up to me, though...” My voice trails off.

Licking his lips, he nods and steps back, turning to grab something off the table behind him. He returns with a white box in his hand. I’m almost afraid to look inside.

“Open it,” he says, pushing the box into my hands.

“What is it?” I ask, feeling giddy. “A present?”

“Open it, and you’ll find out.”

My grin widens, and I pull the tabs out and flip the box open, exposing the contents. Inside are six hand-dipped chocolate strawberries. My mouth waters at the sight of them. Before I can pluck one out of the box and put it in my mouth, Quinton is moving. He grabs one of the perfect strawberries and holds it by its little stem above my mouth.

“Let me feed you.” He practically growls, and the sound ripples through me. I open my mouth, and a low groan escapes my throat as my lips close around the delicious chocolate-covered piece of fruit.

Sinking my teeth into the strawberry, I chew slowly, savoring the taste as its juices flood into my mouth.

My eyes remain on Quinton’s the whole time, the desire and adoration he has for me swirling in his eyes. Months ago, I never could’ve seen us here. He was angry and lost, and I was the girl he could use to make himself feel better. Slowly, he realized we were equals, and I learned that I’m stronger than I ever thought.

“Was that the surprise? Because while the strawberries are amazing. I’m more excited to see you.”

Quinton flashes me a toothy grin and reaches into the front pocket of his jacket. My heart stills in my chest. My eyes close in on the velvet box. I never know what to expect when it comes to him, but this is a complete surprise.

“I saw this one day while browsing online, and I had to get it for you.” I nod, unable to speak while waiting for him to open the box. “While we aren’t together, and I’m not sure we ever will be, not like we want to be, but I want you to know what I see when I look at you.”

He flips the box open, and I withhold a gasp at the sight of the silver necklace shaped like a flower. It sparkles in the lighting, and I swear I can feel tears at the back of my eyes. It’s such a stupid thing to cry about, but it’s unlike Quinton to give me something.

“It’s beautiful,” I croak.

“It’s a lotus. In many cultures, the lotus is seen as pure, regenerative, and a symbol of rebirth.” I nod, unable to tear my eyes from the beautiful piece of jewelry. Using his other hand, Q gently lifts my chin, forcing my gaze to his. “I picked the lotus because even when its roots are in the dirtiest of waters, it still somehow finds a way to bloom into a beautiful flower.” No words I can say would rival what he just said to me. I’m beyond speechless, and we both know it.

“I...” I try to speak, but nothing comes out.

“Shhh, you don’t have to say anything. You don’t need to tell me that you love it. I can see it in your eyes. I just want you to know that I see your strength. I know the waters are dark, and it’s hard to wade through the darkness sometimes, but you’re strong, and in the end, you will bloom into a beautiful flower.”

“Oh, my god, Quinton. Stop.” The tears I’m blinking back break free and trail down the apples of my cheeks without approval.

“Fine.” He smirks. “Turn around so I can put it on you.”

I do just that, moving my hair out of the way so he can clasp the necklace together. Once on, I whirl around and face him again. His gaze moves from the necklace, which rests perfectly against my chest and back up to my eyes.

“All right, I’m done being mushy...” His voice trails off, and his hands find my hips, his thumbs hook into the sides of my leggings. “I’m famished, and I’ve got an appetite for something only you can offer me.”

The way he’s looking at me right now, like he wants to devour me whole and not stop till I’m begging him to, should terrify me, but it doesn’t. Quinton has been the only constant in my life since I arrived here, the only person to help me, the only person to give a shit about me. Even with how unconventional and wrong the start of our relationship was—if you could even call it that.

Yes, our love was born from hate, but aren’t the best love stories born in some type of tragedy? Is it really love if you don’t have to fight for it to some degree?

“Hey!” Quinton’s voice pulls me back to the present, his luminous gaze bleeding into mine. “I’m sorry... I didn’t mean...” I can see the wheel spinning in his mind. He thinks he’s moving too fast; he doesn’t realize the only person to replace all the bad memories in my mind is him.

“Don’t. Don’t stop. Don’t apologize. I want you to make me forget. Replace the bad with good,” I whisper against his lips.

My approval is all he needs, and in a second flat, he has the door closed. Together, we both tug at my leggings to get the stupid fabric off. I let out a gasp when he picks me up by the hips, crosses the room, and places me on the table.

With a valiant effort, he slowly nudges my knees apart, and I let out a hiss as the cold air kisses the wet seam of my panties.

“Are you wet for me, Aspen?” He questions, his voice serious. He doesn’t even have to ask. The evidence is plain as day.

“I want you,” I whimper, reaching for him. He shakes his head.

“Tell me what you want me to do to you....”

This isn’t our first time together, nor is it the first time he’s made me beg for him to do something, but this feels different. Intimate. Like he’s wanting me to lead the way. His fingers trail up and down my thighs. The sensation gives me goose bumps, but after a moment, a thought pops into my mind. *How could he want me after they used my body? After they broke me like they did?*

“Don’t think about them. They have no right to be inside your mind. It’s only us. Only me. Focus on my touch.” Quinton’s soft voice fills my ears, and his hot breath fans against my face. How is he so intuitive of my thoughts? I fist his shirt in my hands, wishing the stupid fabric wasn’t there.

“Touch me,” I urge, the desire for something more pooling low in my belly.

“Where? With what?”

I pull away and look up at him, my eyebrow raised. He grins down at me because we both know that he knows what I want.

“You’re going to have to do better than that. Use your words.”

I lick my suddenly dry lips, my cheeks heating at the thoughts running rampant in my mind.

“I want you to use your mouth and fingers on me.”

I feel the bulge in his jeans, feel his arousal for me. I want him. The need pulses through me with every beat of my heaving heart.

“And where do you want me to put my mouth and fingers?” he whispers into the shell of my ear, his fingers still trailing against my thigh. I shiver, my nipples harden inside my bra, becoming painfully stiff peaks. I reach out, take his hand, and guide it between my thighs, all while leaning back against the wall.

His palm presses against my core, and I buck my hips forward, an onslaught of sensations working through me.

Quinton looks up at me, his thick lashes fan against his cheek as he smiles. “That was beautiful. I can’t wait to see you come apart on my tongue and for your juices to drip down my chin.”

I clench around nothing, my skin flush, my pulse thundering in my ears. I need him to touch me, or I’m pretty sure I might die.

Licking his lips, he traces the seam of my panties before moving his hands upward, dipping his fingers into the waistband of my panties.

I lift my ass and watch as he slowly pulls them down my legs, his dark eyes on me every second. My panties fall to the floor, and his fingers dig into my hips, pulling me to the edge of the table.

My legs fall apart, and I’m left exposed.

“Fuck, Aspen. You’re so wet for me.” Quinton groans, his hands moving to my inner thighs. The whole world slips away when he leans forward and traces my pussy lips. “Your little clit is begging to be sucked...” He looks up at me, mischief in his eyes.

Before I can force a coherent response out of my mouth, he’s on me, his fingers spreading, and his tongue flicking my clit. I keep one hand on the table for balance and sink my other hand into his hair, tugging at the strands, urging him on.

“Oh...” I groan and bite at my bottom lip to stop myself from screaming in pleasure. An orgasm builds low in my belly, and every flick of his tongue against my clit pushes me closer.

“Fuck,” he growls against my folds. “You’ll never guess what you taste like.”

Heart racing and wanting his mouth back on my pussy, I squirm against the table. He laughs, and the sound echoes through me.

God, I love him.

After a moment, he enters me with two fingers, fucking me slowly. My toes curl in my flats, and I clench around the thick digits, my orgasm getting closer and closer with every shallow thrust.

Staring me in the eyes with my juices glistening against his lips, he whispers, “Mine. You taste like mine.”

“Shit, Quinton,” I curse, the orgasm barreling through me, causing my entire body to quake. My eyes roll to the back of my head, and my nails dig into Quinton’s hair. I gush like a faucet, my release exploding against his tongue. As I come down from the high, he continues to fuck me with his fingers, his mouth still suctioned against my swollen clit.

Another orgasm starts to build, and the sensations are too much. I try to clamp my legs closed, but Quinton continues, his eyes lifting to mine, a glint of need reflecting back at me.

“Oh, god. I can’t.” I try to push him away once more, but he continues his assault on my pussy, his fingers moving faster, his lips sucking my clit into his mouth.

There is no escaping the pleasure, so I let it consume. Like swimming in the ocean, I’m pulled deep into the waves, my entire body spiraling, my lungs burning for air as I’m dragged deeper and deeper.

Then it lets go, and I’m flung to the surface. I gasp as another orgasm slams into me, and I press my thighs against Quinton’s head, squeezing him tight. Light blinds me, my fingers and toes tingle, and slowly, I drift back down to reality. As I’m coming down, I force my eyes open and find Quinton moving from between my legs.

He stands to his full height and leans forward, his lips finding mine. His kiss is fire, dipped in desire, and I want to give myself to him. To dissolve

into smoke so I can fill his lungs with my essence. I taste myself on him, and it only heightens my desires.

He breaks the kiss and presses his forehead against mine. After a short while, he pulls away and comes to sit by me. Wrapping an arm around me, he tugs me into his side.

The bulge in his pants is painfully obvious, and I need to take care of him. I need to make him feel the way he made me feel.

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QUINTON

I'm well aware of how risky it is to meet her here, but holding her in my arms as she recovers from the orgasm I just gave her makes it all worth it. I already dread the moment I have to push her off my chest and leave her to carry on the charade.

The only silver lining about leaving the library is being able to go back to my room and jerk off. My dick is painfully hard, pressing against my zipper, just fighting to get free.

“Why don’t you let me take care of you?” Aspen murmurs into the crook of my neck. Her breath almost tickles against my skin as she talks. “I want to make you come.”

She shimmies her body over mine, rubbing her knee over my crotch, making me groan. “Fuck, Aspen. You don’t have to.”

“I want to. I want to make you feel good.” She pushes herself off slightly, moving down my body while running her hands over my chest and stomach.

By the time she makes it to my zipper, I worry the flimsy thing will burst open. My cock is so hard, I’m surprised it hasn’t. She flicks the top button open and frees my aching shaft. Her breathing is labored, but her hands are steady, and her movements are sure.

Licking her pink lips, she pulls my boxers aside and wraps her soft fingers around my cock. Precum leaks from my swollen tip as she applies the

slightest pressure.

Closing my eyes, I tip my head back because if I keep looking at her, I won't be able to stop myself. I'm gonna grab her, throw her on the ground and fuck her until she screams my name. I can't do that to her. I can't fuck her like I used to... like I really want to.

I feel her move, and my whole body is tingling, anticipating her touch. Her wet, hot tongue presses against the underside of my dick, and she licks upward slowly. My balls tighten, and when her lips wrap around the mushroom head, I almost come undone.

Groaning in half pleasure, half pain, I concentrate on not moving, leaving my muscles aching and stiff.

Aspen pushes her head down, taking as much of my length as she can. She gags a little when the tip of my cock bumps against the back of her throat, but she keeps going, bobbing her head up and down while sucking me into her mouth.

It feels like heaven. Everything about her feels so right, so perfect. I can already feel my orgasm building when she suddenly pulls away, leaving me yearning for her touch.

"I don't know if I can do this." She huffs.

I blink my eyes open and gaze directly into hers. "You're in control, Aspen. Take your time. You don't have to do anything if you don't feel comfortable."

"No, I don't mean it like that. I want to do this, but I want you to take control. I want you to treat me like you used to... when it comes to sex, I mean," she quickly adds.

"I don't know if that's a good idea." She doesn't know what she is asking for.

"Please, Quinton. I trust you, and I know you won't hurt me."

"I hurt you before."

“Not like this. Even at your worst, you never took it too far... and you always took care of me after.”

Once again, I am reminded of how special Aspen is, how strong she is. Even after everything I’ve done to her, after all the things she had to endure, she still somehow finds it in her to trust me.

“If it gets too much, I want you to tap my leg.”

“I will.”

Still, a voice in my head tells me to treat her gently. She only thinks she wants this. Once I get into it and take her the way every fiber of my being drives me to do, she’ll panic. I’ll stop immediately without question, but the damage will already have been done. And I’ll have to carry the memory of the hurt in her eyes for the rest of my life.

There’s no denying the ache in my balls. I need satisfaction, and I need it now, or blue balls are on the menu tonight. And there she is, on her knees, looking up at me. Trusting me. Wanting me to use her. What did I do to deserve this woman in my life?

I stroke her hair for a moment before allowing my hand to tighten. “Open your mouth,” I mutter, holding my shaft in the other hand. “Wide.”

She parts her lips, her breath quickening. It’s too much. I can’t fight it. I need to lose myself in her.

I sink in deep, surrounded by wet warmth. Her tongue slides along the underside of my shaft, and I groan as blissful sensations radiate from that point outward. “That’s right. Nice and deep. Take all of it.” Instead of letting her decide how much she can accept, I force my way deeper, hitting the back of her throat. She gags but holds on.

I slowly pull back, watching my spit-slick cock slide out, then back in. It’s almost hypnotic, transfixing me. Aspen places her hands on my thighs for support. I meet her eyes and lift my brow. She responds with a sweep of her tongue around my head. Fuck me.

“Relax your throat,” I warn, and now I take her head in both hands. My heart’s already hammering, and instinct has me hanging on by a thread. I

want to take. To use. To empty myself in her. But she's Aspen. *My Aspen.*

My Aspen who wants this. I have to give her what she wants, too. If this is her way of proving to herself she's brave, who am I to stand in the way of that?

I hold this thought in my mind as I take another deep thrust, holding her head in place. She grunts but doesn't tap me. I grit my teeth and try again, making sure she can handle it. Her eyes meet mine, and there's something in them like reassurance.

The first hard thrust makes her grunt again. "Just hold on," I whisper, my hips moving in a smooth rhythm. So fucking wet. "Suck it."

Her lips tighten, her tongue's pressure increases, and stars explode behind my eyelids.

My instincts take over, driving me faster. I can't hold back anymore. Aspen moans in approval, and oh, fuck, the vibrations from her mouth travel straight to my balls and make them lift in preparation.

I look down at her, on her knees before me, with saliva dripping down her chin. Her nails dig into my thighs, but she's not tapping. She's still with me. My fingers clench, pulling her hair and making her brow crease, but she refuses to stop this.

"That's right," I whisper. "Suck my cock. Show me how much you want this."

She moans again, telling me how she enjoys me using her this way. Taking what I want no matter what.

"You'll take everything I'm about to give you, aren't you?" I mutter, driving myself harder with every thrust. I'm on the edge between control and abandon, holding on by a thread.

"Mm-hmm." It's barely intelligible with her mouth full. She tries to take a breath, but I force my way back inside, my balls slapping against her chin.

"You're going to take every drop of my cum, so nobody knows how filthy we were here, aren't you?"

“Mm-hmm.” She holds my gaze, her face now red, eyes wide. Every touch of my head against the back of her throat makes her grunt until there’s nothing but one long, continuous note filling the air.

“And you love it, don’t you? Huh?” I nod her head slightly before chuckling. “Get ready. Milk my cock with that mouth. Suck me dry.”

She braces herself, eyes squeezing shut. She’s mine, completely mine, and she craved this as much as I did. Willing and ready to accept my load. That’s the thought that pushes me over the edge, making me bury myself balls deep in her mouth until her nose hits the base of my cock. An instant later, I unleash the first blast, followed quickly by the second and third.

She takes it all, holding it in her mouth until I go still. My head is spinning, my heart pounding. Her lips slide over me one last time before releasing. I look down in time to watch her swallow what I didn’t shoot directly down her throat.

I loosen my grip on her head until my hands are now stroking her hair. “Are you all right?” I ask before helping her to her feet. Rather than leave it there, I gather her in my arms. Her heart flutters madly against my chest.

“I’m fine. Everything was fine.” She smiles up at me. “I’m telling the truth. That was exactly what I needed. And what I wanted to give to you, too.”

There are moments when I’m not certain she is real. This is one of them. How could anyone be this sweet and generous and perfect, especially after everything she’s faced? Instead of closing herself off to the world the way so many others would, she keeps moving on. Testing herself. Proving she’s strong enough to take ownership of everything she nearly lost.

“And that was okay for you, too?” There’s still a trace of innocence in her eyes. She’s so eager to please me. Do I deserve her?

“What do you think?” I have to laugh against her neck before kissing the spot where her pulse has slowed to something closer to a normal rate. She giggles softly, and somehow, that’s the best part of all. The sound of her lightheartedness. I would do anything to hear it again—preferably every day for the rest of my life.

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ASPEN

I'm smiling like a little girl as I turn the page in my book, eager to see what the hero and heroine will do in the next chapter when my cell phone rings.

Sliding a hand into my pocket, I tug the device out, hitting the answer button as I read the name on the screen: *Lucas*.

"Aspen." Lucas has never been one for wasting time on pleasantries, but he sounds unusually brusque. "I need you in my office. Now."

This can't be good. I know better than to ask questions. "I'll be there in a minute." And during the course of that minute, an array of ugly scenarios play out in my head all at once. What's the emergency? He sounds like something's very wrong. My stomach's in knots by the time I reach his door, which he swings open before I've knocked.

As it turns out, I couldn't have imagined the reason for this visit. "Have a seat." He directs me to the sofa before handing me a tablet. He taps the screen to wake it up from dark mode, and the image frozen there is like a hand around my throat, cutting off my air.

He perches himself beside me, leaving enough space between us so I don't feel crowded. "First of all, I want you to know I learned more about your father's passing."

A nice way to describe the murder of the man whose face I'm staring at. "What did you hear?"

“If you’re worried whether he suffered, don’t. His death came quickly.”

Confusion is strong enough to pry my eyes from the image of my father’s face, so I can search Lucas’s instead. “Really? But how would anybody know for sure?”

“I have it on good authority. I’m sure you would rather I not go into detail, so I’m going to ask you to trust me. He died quickly and as painlessly as possible, which, given the circumstances, might’ve been the best he could hope for.”

The outcome doesn’t change, but at least I know the ugliness from my nightmares was only my imagination. “I’m so relieved to hear that. You don’t want to know what’s been going on in my head all this time. I try not to think about it, but still. Sometimes I can’t help it.”

He offers an understanding smile. I wonder how much ugliness he’s seen and whether he can compartmentalize it the way I’ve tried to.

“I’m glad I could offer reassurance. As for what you’re holding, that’s a video I received. It was created for you. Addressed to you. I haven’t watched it,” he assures me, answering a question I was too afraid to ask. It would hardly be the first time my privacy has been disregarded.

The tablet is shaking. No, that’s my hands doing the shaking. A final message from my father. He’s wearing an orange jumpsuit, the way I always imagine in my dreams, with a gray cinder block wall at his back. His attention is focused squarely on the camera. There I was, thinking I would never hear his voice again. But now I’m too afraid of what he has to say to cherish the opportunity.

“I’ll leave you alone,” Lucas murmurs, standing.

“No, please. You don’t have to go. I’m not sure I want to be alone for this.” He offers a small shrug before sitting again. His body language screams tension like he’s poised to help if I can’t handle what’s coming.

Deep breath. You can do this, Aspen. My heart is thudding wildly by the time I tap the screen, starting the video.

Dad wears a sad smile. “Aspen.” Instantly, tears spring to my eyes. “Honey, it was important to me that I get this message to you.” He sounds worn out, but there’s a firm determination under the tenderness in his voice.

“I never had the chance to fully apologize. I am so sorry for what my choices and my mistakes did to you. You deserved none of this. I need you to know how much I love you. You’ve been a gift. One bright, good thing in the middle of the mess I’ve made. I’ve been proud of you all your life. Since I ruined everything, the strength you’ve shown only makes me prouder.”

My chin quivers. I’m not sure how much more of this I can take, and according to the progress bar at the bottom of the window, there’s still a lot to go.

He draws a deep breath. “There’s something you need to know. I don’t want you carrying around the shame of having me as a father for the rest of your life. You deserve to know the truth.”

It’s almost like his eyes are burning into mine. They’re so intense. “Though I always loved you like my own, I’m not your biological father. You were adopted shortly after your birth.” He pauses, almost like he’s waiting for me to absorb this.

It’ll never be enough time. This can’t be true! I cover my mouth with one hand, shaking my head. No way. He’s just saying this to let me off the hook, right? Permission to cut him and Mom out of my heart forever and move on. That must be it.

“We kept it a secret to protect you, sweetheart,” he continues. “Your mother was a good woman, from what I heard. Her name was Charlotte, but I’m afraid that’s the only concrete information I ever learned about her. I know she was a good woman because she understood your father—your biological father—was a dangerous man who couldn’t be trusted with you. She was scared to death of him, and she loved you enough to keep her pregnancy hidden from his family. I also knew your father, and he wasn’t exactly a family man. He would only have placed you and your mother in harm’s way from day one.”

“I can’t believe this,” I say. My mind doesn’t want to accept it. I want to stop the video, but curiosity won’t let me. I have to know everything. Even if it hurts.

“When you were born, Charlotte wanted to give you up for adoption, but she was scared of putting it on paper. She didn’t want to leave any chance of your father finding you. We knew we couldn’t have any children naturally, so we agreed to raise you as our own daughter. I don’t know whether we ever would have told you about this, to be honest. I’m sorry to say, Charlotte passed away years ago, but before that, she occasionally checked in, and we shared pictures with her. I don’t want you to think your birth mother abandoned you or didn’t love you. She just cared about you so much that she let you go.”

He clears his throat, leaning a little closer to the camera. “I also want you to know we always loved you like our own. If you remember nothing else, please, remember that. I know that I’ll be gone by the time you watch this. And that’s my choice, Aspen. Know that, too. I know what I’m headed for, and it’s what I want. Because it’s what’s going to keep you safe. I know you don’t understand, but please, trust me.”

He snickers, lowering his eyes. “I know that’s a lot to ask, considering what I’ve put you through. Please, remember the good times. Remember how loved you were. That was no act. I did, I do, and I always will love you. You don’t have to worry about me holding you back ever again. This is the last gift I can offer, and I offer it with all my heart.”

He sits up straighter, gives a firm nod, and the video ends.

I don’t know how long we sit in silence, Lucas and me. I don’t know if either of us is breathing.

Not my parents. They were never mine. How could I have never seen it? How didn’t I know? I should have felt something, right?

“Aspen...” Lucas’s voice has lost some of its strength. One look at him tells me he’s just as stunned as I am—wide eyes, mouth slightly open. “I had no idea. I assure you, none of us knew.”

“I understand.” That’s not true. I don’t understand anything. My whole life has been a lie. My real father was so dangerous my mother didn’t think we’d be safe around him. She was so afraid he’d find out that she hid me and gave me up right after birth. How many times did she think about me? Did we ever meet, and I didn’t know? He made it sound like they knew each other. What if she wanted to check on me?

This time, there’s nobody to provide answers. Everybody involved is missing or dead. I’ll never know.

“You look shaken up,” Lucas informs me. “Are you going to be all right?”

“Do I have a choice?”

He offers what could pass for an apologetic smile. “When it comes down to it, none of us do. You’ve been through enough to break a dozen full-grown men, but you’re still standing.” His brows draw together. “Everyone has a breaking point, though. I want to be sure you can get through it.”

“I can.” I hardly hear myself. I’m only saying what I know he wants to hear, anyway.

“Do you need me to walk you back to your room?”

“Actually, I don’t think I want to be alone right now. If you don’t mind. Could I stay here for a little while? Not for long. It’s only that I don’t think I should be alone with my thoughts.” I can see myself spiraling in my room with no one to talk to.

“Do you need to talk?”

“Not necessarily. But I might. I can’t think straight yet.”

He nods, rising, and crosses the room. His back is to me, but I hear ice hitting a glass before liquid follows it.

When he turns around, he’s holding a glass of amber liquid, extending his arm my way. “It seems to me you could use a drink.” He has no idea how right he is.

QUINTON

Ever since I heard about Mather's death, I have wondered if my father had anything to do with it. A part of me hasn't asked yet because I don't want to hear the answer, and if he did kill him, I don't want to keep it from Aspen. Which means not knowing seemed like a good alternative—until now.

Hearing about the video message Aspen's dad recorded before his murder raises a new set of questions. Who set up the recording and sent it here, and most importantly, who is Aspen's real father? Clyde made it sound like he knew who her father is and if he is so dangerous and unfit to be a father, do we have to worry about him finding out?

Those questions and more led me to flip open my laptop and open a video chat with my dad. As usual, it doesn't take him long to answer my call.

"Quinton, everything okay?"

"Yes, everything is fine. I just wanted to ask you some things."

"I figured you would call soon. I'm guessing this is about Clyde Mather?"

"Yes, did you kill him?"

"Not myself."

I suppress an eye roll. "You know what I mean. Did you have him killed?"

“Yes, and no. It’s complicated, Quinton. I did have something to do with his death, and I am the one who set up the video for him.”

This doesn’t come as a surprise, as I figured he was involved somehow, but I still hate that I know now. “Do you know who her real father is?”

“No, I don’t. I asked him, and he wouldn’t tell me. I also tried to figure it out, going back to the time she was born and who Clyde was associated with at the time, but so far, I’ve come up empty.”

“Why do I feel like you are not telling me everything you know?”

“I tell you everything you need to know, but nothing that will make your life harder. You’re just going to have to trust me on this. I did what’s best.”

I wish I could believe him.

“I’m probably not coming home for spring break.” I change the subject.

“I figured you wouldn’t. Your mother and I actually already talked about coming to see you instead.

“Sounds good. It’s not really too bad here once you get used to everything.”

“If you say so.” My father grins, knowing damn well it’s not the scenery making me want to stay. “Tell Mom and Scarlet I said hi.”

“I will. Be safe.”

The screen goes blank, and I close my laptop, just as my phone rings with a new message.

Rick: Your guest is being difficult today. Do you want us to take care of it? We can make her more comfortable.

I’m sure they could, but I also know “making her more comfortable” to Rick and Bruno means roughing her up to keep her quiet. That’s the only language those two meatheads speak, and though their skills often come in handy, this guest needs to be treated with finesse.

Me: Leave her for now. Don’t bring her food. I will be there in a few hours.

Rick: Got it, boss.

Being nineteen, I probably shouldn't be used to people calling me boss but being Xander Rossi's son has its perks. Though I am technically not their boss yet, they have called me that since I was fifteen. I guess they are trying to get used to it, knowing that I will be the head of the Rossi empire one day.

Getting up from my desk, I tuck my phone in my pocket and slip into my heavy boots. Grabbing my jacket on the way out, I leave my room.

Ren is sprawled out on the couch playing a video game while wearing his headset. He slides it off his ear when he sees me.

"Going somewhere?"

"Yeah, heading back to the airport."

"Trouble?"

"I hope not. I just don't trust Rick and Bruno to handle this without taking it too far. You know how they are."

Ren only nods. I don't have to explain more to him. "Don't get frostbite. It's fucking cold outside." He slides the headset back in place and continues his game.

On my way to the surface, I text the pilot we have on standby to meet me on the helicopter pad. He meets me at the large metal door leading outside, and we walk to the helicopter together.

"Where are we heading to?"

"Blue Ridge Airport." I climb into the helicopter after him and slump down in the seat. Ren was right. It is fucking cold. Even with my heavy clothes on, I am grateful to be out of the icy Alaskan wind as I close the door.

It's only a thirty-minute flight to the Blue Ridge Airport, a tiny, abandoned airstrip along the Takotna River. The place was too perfect for my needs. Out in the middle of nowhere, surrounded by nothing but tundra, but close enough for me to fly to on a whim.

We land smoothly despite the high winds. I pull my hood over my head and zip up my jacket.

“I won’t be long. Wait here,” I order and push open the door. I climb out of the helicopter onto the icy concrete and shove my hands into my pockets.

It’s only a few hundred feet to the hangar, but the short walk is enough to have my exposed face numb and my lips painfully sensitive. Cursing the freezing weather, I speed walk to the side door of the large building.

I pull my hands free and punch in the six-digit code on the lock. It disengages, and I push the door open. The inside is not much warmer, but at least I’m out of the elements.

Pushing my hood down, I walk into the large part of the hangar toward the backend offices. I pass the small plane that brought my two guys and guests here, wondering how that piece of shit even made it out here. Half of the wing is rusted and looks like it’s gonna fall off at the slightest breeze.

Shaking my head, I continue to where my guests are staying. As I walk into the back of the hangar, I hear my guys’ drunken laughter echoing through the hallway.

I find them in one of the old offices, throwing playing cards on a table that is covered in empty liquor bottles and half-eaten bags of chips.

“Enjoying yourself?”

“Quinton!” Bruno greets like he is seeing an old friend. I have half a mind to remind him that I am not his friend, but he technically hasn’t done anything wrong, and this is not the job you have to stay sober for. So I’m cutting him some slack.

Rick seems just as drunk. His eyes are glassy, and even sitting down, he’s swaying a little in his chair. “We did as you said, didn’t bring her food, and left her alone,” he slurs.

“Good.” I don’t have to tell them what would happen if they had disobeyed me. Bruno is missing his little finger because he did not listen to my father once. That’s not something you forget.

Leaving the two behind, I make my way farther into the building. As I get closer to my guests, I can hear the low thump of something banging against the wall in a rhythmic pattern. Smiling to myself, I pass the room of my first guest and continue to my second.

Her room is quiet, but that doesn't mean she's not causing trouble. I unlock the door with the code on the number pad and push the heavy iron door open. I don't see her sitting on the cot, and since that's the only piece of furniture in the room, she can only hide behind the door.

I step inside, anticipating her attack. She jumps out from her hiding spot like a bat out of hell, swinging her tiny fists at me. I subdue her with ease. Grabbing her by the wrists, I push her backward until she falls onto her cot.

Immediately, she loses her vigor, realizing what a vulnerable position she is now in. "What do you want from me?"

"I want to know your ties to the Valentine family?"

Her lips press into a tight line as she raises her chin in defiance. She keeps her back straight, and her hands curled into fists beside her body, as if she is attempting to look brave. But it's hard to take her seriously with her small frame and uncombed auburn hair falling off her shoulders in tangled waves.

"I guess you are enjoying your stay too much. All of this could be over if you tell me what I want to know."

"Sure, you just let me go after, right?" She snorts. "I know the only reason I'm alive is because you want something from me. I'm not stupid. As soon as I tell you, I'm dead."

"You watch too many horror movies."

She rolls her eyes at me. "Like I said. I'm not stupid. I know who you are."

"If you know who I am, you should know I don't play games, and I stand by my word. Tell me how you know the Valentines and the Brookshires."

"I have nothing to tell you."

"I guess you still need a little more time. Lucky for you, I'm not in a hurry. You may stay here indefinitely if that's what you want."

“I want to leave.”

“Then tell me what I want to know.”

“No... I’ll find a way out of here,” she mumbles under her breath.

“A way out? Like the hole you’ve been digging with the spoon from yesterday’s lunch?”

She doesn’t move, her body stiffer than ever, but her eyes move toward the east wall ever so slightly, giving her away. The back part of this building is not metal like the hangar that stores the airplanes. These rooms were added later for storage and are nothing more than large cinder blocks held together by concrete.

It’s not easy to get through, but if you have nothing but time on your hands, digging a hole through—no matter how slow—is possible. She has already scraped an inch deep around one block, making it almost possible to move the heavy piece.

“I’m not sure where you think you are going, but I assure you, nothing but snow-covered earth surrounds this place for hundreds of miles. You would freeze to death in a few hours—unless a hungry animal got to you first.”

“I’ll take my chances.”

“And I’ll take that spoon. I’ll let the guards know not to provide you with any more silverware.” Stepping right up to the bed, I hold out my hand, waiting for her to hand me the spoon.

She stares at me for a moment, playing innocent, but quickly realizes that I’m not going anywhere. She finally huffs in defeat and digs the utensil out from underneath her thin pillow.

Grabbing it, I shove it into my pocket and turn to leave. Pausing at the door, I glance over my shoulder. “I am not in a hurry, but my patience has an end. If you don’t talk soon, I will let my guys have free rein, and trust me, they are not as civil as I am.”

Her gulp is loud enough for me to hear across the room; her eyes fill with fear, but she still keeps her lips pressed together. Pulling her knees up to her

chest, she wraps her arms around them, looking more vulnerable than before. If I didn't know she was somehow involved with the Valentines, I would probably feel sorry for her. Unlucky for her, I don't.

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ASPEN

*M*e: Where are you? Is everything okay?

The one thing I've been able to rely on lately is my secret meetings with Quinton in the sunroom. They're the bright spot in my life, especially now when things look so dark and murky. Just when I thought I had things figured out, Dad had to throw me a curveball like that. I still can't wrap my head around it.

I also can't stop thinking of him as my dad. I guess I don't have to stop. In all other ways, he was my father. Flawed, yes. But he loved me. So much, according to him, that he sacrificed his life to keep me safe.

I wish I knew what that meant. Then again, do I want to know? Sometimes you overturn a rock, and nothing but worms and bugs slither out from underneath. Sometimes it's better to leave the rock as it is.

Me: I really need to talk to you. Why won't you at least tell me you're okay? I'm freaking out a little.

I want to talk all of this over with Quinton, texting from across the room the way we always do, but he hasn't shown. This isn't what I need, not right now. He's my stability. And if anything happened to him... I don't want to think about it. Yet none of my messages have been enough to earn a response.

Me: At least let me know if you're not going to be able to meet with me. Otherwise, I'm going to worry myself sick.

It's a little late for that. I already feel nauseated.

If anything happened to him, I would hear about it. Word travels fast around here. I might not exactly have any friends, but I still catch gossip simply by walking down the hall. Quinton may as well be royalty at Corium. No way would they be able to keep from gossiping about him if something went wrong.

What if something went wrong between us, though? That's a trickier situation. I can't imagine what that would be. I thought everything was status quo.

I look down at my book, but I can't see a word of what's on the page. Not with the questions plaguing me, worry twisting my guts until I'm afraid I'll throw up. My skin feels too tight like I'm going to explode from it. I have to get up. I have to move. Otherwise, I'll lose it here and now, under our tree, of all places.

Me: I'm going to head out. I thought I would let you know in case you decide to stop in and find me gone. Please, just let me know you're all right when you get a chance.

I tuck the phone away before gathering my things and heading out. Should I stop by the library to talk with Brittney? No, I decide, tracing my steps to go to my room instead. I don't have many options around here.

What am I going to do in my room? Pace around? Like I haven't done enough of that. Much longer, and I'll wear a hole in the floor.

Disappointment is one thing, but this? Quinton is my lifeline, one of my only respites in this entire school. I only thought I understood how much it soothes me to see him—I had no idea, as it turns out. What am I supposed to do now that I can't, when I was so looking forward to it?

By the time my door closes, I still have that prickly feeling. I shake out my hands, stretching, but it doesn't do any good. I would go down to the gym, but that isn't exactly my speed. Besides, do I want to be alone with people who still hate me and have heavy equipment at their fingertips?

Finally, I realize there's only one option left. I head to Lucas's office. The assistant from the front has long stopped acknowledging me walking in. I'm

not sure if Lucas told her to let me walk in whenever, or she just stopped giving a shit. Either way, I'm glad I can come and go as I please.

"Is everything all right?" It's sort of nice how concerned he is when he sees me. Normally, I'd wonder if he pities me, and I would hate that, but he seems to genuinely care.

"I need help. It's not an emergency," I'm quick to add before he can overreact.

"What is it?" He backs up, allowing me into the room.

"Would you give me a self-defense lesson? I know we don't usually meet now, but I feel like I could use it."

He lowers his brow. "Has someone been threatening you?"

"Not really. I just have all this energy." I shake out my hands, bouncing up and down on the balls of my feet. "Anxiety. And when we finish our lessons, I always feel capable and stronger."

His eyes narrow a fraction, his jaw tightening. For a second, I'm sure he's mad at me for interrupting whatever he was doing. I wouldn't blame him. Who am I, anyway? Barging in and demanding he change his schedule.

"Why don't we go to the gym?" he asks, and I can breathe again. "Give me a few minutes to change into something more appropriate." Finally, something is going my way today. I don't mind going to the gym with him as a chaperone. I dare anybody to so much as look at me the wrong way.

It turns out the gym is empty when we arrive. "What did you have in mind?" Lucas asks while I follow him to an open area where racks of free weights are against the wall. Mirrors are lining the walls so people can check their form or whatever it's called.

"Show me something. Anything. Something to defend myself."

He folds his arms, lips pursed like he's thinking. "I may have a better idea. What if you attacked me?"

The idea is so outrageous I can't help but laugh. "Sorry," I offer when he scowls. "Me? Attack you?" I look at the mirror, and the sight of our

reflection almost makes me laugh again. We're like David and Goliath. He is a mountain of muscle, and I'm, well, me.

"We aren't going for realism here, Aspen." He snorts, shaking his head before planting his feet at shoulder width. "I'm telling you to attack me. That's an order."

"What am I supposed to do?"

"Whatever comes naturally. I'm your enemy." He cups his fingers in a beckoning gesture.

I'm not sure if this is some sort of game or what. Could he blame me for being confused? One thing's for sure: he's not joking. He bends a little at the waist, planting himself in place. "I'm waiting."

My first attempt isn't very strong because it's half-hearted. This is so strange. I'm supposed to be protecting myself from him, not the other way around. I rush him, hands outstretched, shoving his chest. A slight breeze might as well have blown through the room for all the good it does.

"Is that all you've got?"

"I'm not sure how much I can give."

"Give it everything." He locks eyes with me. "I mean it. Whatever it is, I can take it. Attack me. Beat the hell out of me if you have to. Just do it."

Okay, then. I take a few deep breaths, pumping myself up, and this time when I charge, I hit lower, near his center of gravity. I manage to rock him back on his heels, but he swats me away like a fly. "Come on, Aspen. I'm standing in your way. There's something you want, but you have to get through me to get it. What are you going to do?"

Funny. He sounds a little more the way he used to. Colder. Harder. The sound of it sparks a fire in my brain. He underestimated me. They all did. They looked at me and saw what they wanted to see.

A growl tears its way of me, and I launch myself at him, driving him back a few steps. He shoves me away, but I don't give up this time, circling him

and shoving him from behind. “That’s more like it.” He pivots, facing me again, shifting his weight from side to side.

When I feint left, he follows, so I lunge right and take his wrist in my right hand. Holding his arm up, I drive my left elbow into his ribs once, twice. This time he grunts, puffing out a big gasp and doubling over. “You’re quick. You have that on your side.”

I also have rage on my side. Months of pent-up aggression I’ve had no way to vent are now ready to burst free like a dam broke. He’s not Lucas right now. He’s everybody who’s ever hurt me, disparaged me, tormented me.

Before he can straighten up, I get him in a headlock. The crook of my elbow is beneath his chin, my forearm wrapped around the other side of his neck. I push against it with my other hand, using the leverage to squeeze tight.

I look up in the mirror. Is that me? The girl I see in the mirror is powerful. Strong, capable.

Lucas recovers quickly, sneaking an arm around my stomach to use as a pivot point before sweeping my legs back. I end up head over heels, the room spinning around me before I land on my back hard enough to knock the wind from my lungs.

“Come on.” Now he sounds a little winded, probably because I cut off his air for a second. “Let’s see what else you can do. Unless you plan on lying on the floor and taking a nap.”

I get on my feet and shake it off. We circle each other slowly, both of us wary. I charge him, but he catches me, holding me at arm’s length. We grapple until I use one of the moves he taught me. Flinging his arms away before driving my shoulder into his midsection hard enough to take him down.

I can’t believe it. I actually knocked him down.

“All right.” He stares at the ceiling for a moment, catching his breath. “That, I didn’t expect.” He rolls away before jumping to his feet. “I hope if I was a real threat, you would have kicked me while I was down.”

“That’s dirty fighting.”

“And if I was threatening your life, you wouldn’t have to question whether the fight was dirty or clean.” He places a hand over his stomach and offers a wry chuckle. “Someone taught you well.”

I don’t have time to react before he lunges. The next thing I know, I’m on my back again, thanks to the way he efficiently took my legs out from under me. He stands over my prone body, hands on his hips. “Don’t let your guard down,” he instructs. “Because your opponent might fight dirty, too. Come on. Get up. Keep going.”

Right, I have to keep going. It doesn’t matter how tired I am, how sore I am. My entire existence is a fight. I stand, rolling my shoulders before getting in a fighting stance. I throw myself at him, and he repels me. I do it again and again, getting in whatever blows I can deliver. An elbow to the ribs, a knee to his midsection. He doubles over, and I deliver an elbow to the back of his neck—not as hard as I could since I’m not trying to seriously wound him. I still have enough presence of mind not to be too reckless.

And when I do it, I’m not hitting Lucas. I’m hitting Matteo and everyone who hurt me that night. I’m hitting Nash for making me feel unsafe. The ones who laughed at me. Who described the torture they thought I deserved. All of their faces swim in my mind’s eye. It’s only when my cries of rage fill the room and echo off the walls that I realize I’m making a sound.

By the time I’m finished, ready to drop from exhaustion, I feel empty. In a good way, though. Clean. There’s no room for anxiety or regret or any of it when I’m so damn tired.

And successful. Lucas pushes himself up onto one knee, his breathing labored after the beating he received. “How do you feel?” He looks up at me from under his brow.

“Better.” I drag an arm over my forehead to catch the perspiration that’s beaded on my skin.

“Good. That was what you needed.” He stands up straight, almost smiling as he looks me up and down. “You’ve been holding out on me. On all of us.”

“What do you mean?”

“When you first came here, you were a mouse. Timid. Jumping at your own shadow. Now, you’re a true warrior. Use your anger. Harness it like you did a minute ago while using me as a punching bag, and you might get through this yet.”

I don’t ask him what he means by this. I don’t need to. We both know I’m going through a war I did nothing to start.

At least now, I’ll have the memory of knocking the big man on his back whenever I feel weak or helpless.

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QUINTON

*I*t's late enough by the time I get back to Corium that I assume most of the people residing within its walls are asleep. I'm glad to be back inside, far from the punishing winds and snow of the tundra. What a difference, considering where I've returned from. I never thought Corium would feel like a haven, but it does. Remembering the cells in that hangar makes me more grateful than ever to live comfortably.

If I ever need a reminder of why it's important to exercise caution in my doings, I only need to remember what I've done to my enemies. I wouldn't want to be on their side of the situation. Who knows? My tormentor might end up being even more sadistic than I am.

Though I doubt anyone would have more reason than I do. Because no one but me has Aspen.

On the way to my room, I power up my phone. The texts she sent throughout the day pierce me with guilt.

Me: I had some things to take care of. I'm back now.

I send the message before continuing down the halls and into the elevator to my level. All the while, my message sits unread.

Is this some kind of game? Does she think she's going to win? If she does, she's forgotten who she's dealing with.

Me: Turn around? Is that what you're telling me? I'm sorry I was out of reach. It couldn't be helped.

Once again, the message comes up as being delivered but unread. My jaw tightens in unison, with my hand tightening around the phone. Rather than send another text I'm sure will go unread, I will call her once I've reached my room. The phone rings once, twice, without an answer. Her voicemail doesn't pick up either. Has she turned off her phone? Why would she do that? If this is a game, I'm not playing.

"Leaving so soon? You just got back." Ren sounds amused, stretched out on the couch, watching me stalk past on my way out of the apartment. I tell myself I'm going to check on her and make sure she's well. I'm genuinely concerned since she ought to know better than to leave me hanging. That's a big part of why my shoes slap against the floor like it insulted me somehow.

The rest is outrage. Me, of all people. She's going to ignore me. Nobody ignores me.

I pound on her door, not caring if any of the faculty hears. "Aspen. It's me." At least she doesn't keep me waiting long, flinging the door open and glaring at me.

"Oh, you're alive. That's good to know."

It's only for the sake of discretion that I'm able to keep my voice low. "You would know I'm alive if you would check your phone. I've texted and called."

"I just got out of the shower and was drying my hair." At least she isn't lying. The smell of shampoo is stronger than usual when I enter the room, and her hair is silky soft and smooth as she brushes past me. "But forgive me for not being at your beck and call. When you couldn't bother answering a text from me today to tell me you were alive, at least."

"When did it become a rule that I have to jump every time you snap your fingers?"

She sighs and flops down on the couch, looking defeated. "It's not a rule. You don't owe me anything. I just worry when you ignore me."

“I wouldn’t ignore you.” It never occurred to me she’d take it this hard. “Don’t make more out of this than there needs to be.”

“It’s more than that,” she admits. “My whole day basically revolves around you. Yes, I go to class and hang out with Brittney, but that’s not what I look forward to. I don’t know what to do. I feel lost without you. When I can’t talk to you, I freak out.”

Fuck. I didn’t realize how much she depended on me. Pride fills my chest for being needed. For her to trust and want me so much makes me almost happy. But knowing that there is no way this arrangement can be permanent puts a huge damper on my joy.

“Everything I do is for you, but you can’t rely on me for your happiness.”

“You’re all I have.” She shakes her head slowly, mournfully. “You just disappeared.”

“I was gone for half the day. That’s not the same as disappearing.”

“I didn’t know when you would be back or if you would ever come back.”

“I wouldn’t just leave like that.”

She barks out a sad, bitter laugh. “I guess I’ve just had the rug pulled out from under me one too many times. I expect the worst every time now. Where were you?” she whispers the last part. “Tell me, Q. Unless you’re going to start hiding things from me.”

I doubt she would much enjoy the truth, not yet at least. “I can’t tell you everything, Aspen. Not now, not ever.”

“I know that, but knowing and being content with it are two different things. I don’t know if I can do it.” Rather than blow up at me, she sits on the edge of her bed, hands clutched between her knees. Staring down at them, she asks, “Why are we doing this?”

“We didn’t have to do this. If you had—”

“That’s not what I’m talking about. Why are we doing this?” Using one hand, she gestures back and forth between us, her eyes downcast. “What’s the point? We can’t be seen together. Nobody can know we even speak to

each other. I live my days like they're filler between the times I get to see you. Time I need to pass until the next real, important thing happens. It's pitiful."

She raises her eyes, turning her head to look at me with what looks a lot like disappointment. "I can't spend my life being so dependent on you."

"I agree. I want to be there for you, but we can't sneak around forever. I want you to be happy and live your life. I don't know how you can do that with me around." None of this is right. Even if, in the end, it would be for the best.

"Tell me something, and be honest: is there a chance of this ever going anywhere? You and me? Is there any possibility of us having a future?"

I wish I could tell her yes, we do. I'm always going to be a part of her life the same as she'll always be a part of mine. There's no questioning it, no fighting against it. We're meant to be.

Convincing myself I can have everything I want in my childish fantasy. I can keep my family safe while seeing Aspen on the side. I can maintain a strange relationship with her in which neither of us can acknowledge the other in public. The truth is, I have to choose one or the other—for her sake.

Because we have no future. There's no hope of it. And it would be unfair to her to keep her hoping for more. If I care about her, I have to let her go.

"No, there is no chance. I'm sorry, Aspen. Maybe it's better if we just stop talking altogether." No matter how it kills me to think about it. I was right before; it would be better if she hated me.

"I understand." She nods slowly. Her eyes are wild, as if she is trying to process everything.

"I'll keep protecting you around here," I murmur. "That's not going to change. You won't be harassed or bullied."

"Thank you," she replies in a voice so small I can hardly hear it. "And thank you for being honest."

I wish her thanks did anything to ease the crushing sense of this being completely wrong. My brain might tell me it's the right thing to do, the fair thing, the logical step. Yet it means never touching her again. Never holding her, stroking her, tasting her. How do I wrap my heart around that?

It's too much, being in the same room as her. Looking at her, smelling her, surrounded by her—it's all too much.

I leave in a hurry, closing the door quietly before heading straight to my room. I hate myself. I hate this school. I hate everything and everyone. And I want someone to hurt as badly as I'm hurting now.

It so happens Ren is the first person I see, still stretched out on the couch. One look at me, and he knows what's happened. I must wear it like a sign around my neck. "You know it's the right thing in the end," he says.

"How do you know what happened?"

"Call it my psychic abilities." He rolls his eyes, sitting up and reaching for a small box on the coffee table. "Or you could call it the fact that I know you well. Take your pick."

"Fuck off," I mutter with conviction I don't feel.

"Here." He withdraws a joint from inside the box, along with a lighter. "Relax, take your mind off things." Right now, anything I can do to forget for a little while looks like a good idea.

ASPEN

When there's a knock on the door, my heart jumps. Thank God he came back.

I'm going to tell him I'm sorry. I'm going to tell him I don't want any of this. How am I supposed to get through my days without him? Whatever it takes, I'll do it. So long as we can make it work.

That's why I open the door without asking who's on the other side. I'm that desperate to get to Quinton.

Nash pushes his way into the room before I can stop him. "What a nice welcome. I knew you could be friendly if you had the opportunity."

There's no hope of running from the room thanks to him forcing the door closed. I can only stumble backward. "Get out of here."

"Who's going to make me?" He stands against the door, giving me no way out. "Not you. I've seen what happens when you're overpowered, Aspen. You don't put up much of a fight."

"What are you talking about?" If only Quinton had stayed another minute or two, this wouldn't be happening. Why won't he come back?

"You don't remember? Well, you weren't in very good shape, so I guess you wouldn't." There's that shark smile. Those empty eyes. "We spent a very special evening together. You were feeling sort of foggy, though."

There's only one night he could be talking about, but it can't be true. "No. You weren't there."

"Wasn't I?" He raises an eyebrow. "Are you sure?" No, I'm not sure, but I don't remember him. He's never come up in any of the broken memories. Not in the nightmares, either.

But it would explain so much at the same time. The little comments. The way he looks at me like we share a dirty secret.

"Not only was I there. I'm the one who gave you that little cocktail, which you should really thank me for."

"I hope you know I just did you a huge favor..." Nash's words ring in my ear. Nash... it was him. He gave me the drug. And now he wants me to thank him?

"I know what he did." His voice is low, smooth. "Quinton, I mean. Q killed everybody involved, along with the entire Valentine family. Don't lie. We both know it's true." His smile widens. "But he forgot about the guy who recorded the festivities. It was a hell of a memorable night."

Oh, my god. He's telling the truth. Nobody would lie about something like that. The fact that he knows about it at all tells me it's true. "You're a monster. You're a fucking evil piece of shit."

He responds with a grotesque pout. "Considering I'm the one who gave you the drugs to dull everything, you should thank me."

"Fuck you."

Another pout. "Sorry. I didn't get the chance. Too busy recording the event."

"You know, I was pregnant. I lost my baby because of what you did that night."

His cold laughter chills my blood. "Then you should thank me twice. I did the kid a favor. Why would they want a mother like you?"

I can't believe anybody could be this much of a monster. After everything I've seen, been through, nothing is worse than this. He can stand there and

laugh when I tell him he helped kill my baby. He's not real. He doesn't have a soul. How could he?

I turn away, my head spinning, my heartbeat pounding in my ears like a drum. I can hardly see, and I'm panting for air. He killed my baby. He killed my baby, and he's laughing about it.

"Come on. Maybe we can have a little more fun tonight. That's why I came here, you know. I didn't get my turn back at the warehouse." I hear him coming toward me, crossing the room. Sirens blare in my head. He's going to hurt me. I have to stop him. He killed my baby.

I take hold of my bedpost, and my eye falls upon what's left of dinner. And there, sitting on top of my plate is a steak knife.

"Come on. You might even end up liking it this time." Nash's hand lands on my shoulder like a deadly spider. His touch is soft but instantly tightens into a vise grip. "Not that I give a shit. I'm going to fill your holes, and you're going to take it."

I pivot, raising my arm to shoulder level. He never sees it coming.

The steel sinks into his chest, cutting off his nasty laughter. I pull the blade free and plunge it down again. He lets go of me, covering the red blooms spreading over his shirt. He looks down, then up at me, his mouth hanging open and his eyes bulging.

Again. Again. In and out, harder, faster. He drops to the floor on his back, gasping, blood soaking through his clothes, splashing me every time I withdraw the blade. I feel it on my hands, warm and sticky. And it feels good. A rush of something like joy rolls over me, and I laugh.

Until the wave subsides and pulls back and leaves cold, hard truth behind.

I stare at Nash's dead body sprawled out on the floor. Blood seeps from the multiple stab wounds decorating his chest like a piece of art. I should probably be freaking out right now, screaming and crying. I should feel terrible for what I've done, but all I can think of is how relieved I am that he is gone. No... it's more than a relief. I'm... proud. I'm proud of what I've done.

For the first time, I feel like I'm taking control. For so long, everyone around me dictated my life, chose what I would do, how I live, and who I am. They used me and my body. Not today. Today, I'm the powerful one. I'm the one clutching onto a bloody knife. I'm the one who decided to end Nash's life. Now I have to live with the consequences. Surprisingly, I'm not scared of it. Whatever is coming, I'll face it. I find comfort in knowing that this is my choice and that I rid the world of him.

My breathing is unexpectedly calm. My heart beats in an even rhythm as I set the knife onto the counter and wash my hands in the sink until the water runs clear.

After I dry my hands, I find my phone on the coffee table and swipe the screen open. Since I only have four contacts in my phone, it doesn't take me long to find Ella. I hit the video call button and take a seat on the couch, so she will only see me and the wall as my background.

It doesn't take long for her to answer. Her familiar face calms me even further, making me smile.

"Aspen, is everything okay?"

"Yes, I just wanted to tell you something, and it's important that you see me and know how serious I am."

"Okay." She sounds wary. "What's going on?"

"First, I wanted to say thank you again for everything you did for me. Especially after what my father did to you. I'm sorry about that..."

"You don't have to apologize for that."

"I know, but I still feel like saying it. Maybe if I hadn't been so naïve, things would have been different."

"None of this was your fault."

"I know that too. Before, nothing was my choice... until now. Which is why I'm actually calling. I wanted to tell you not to worry about me and don't try to help me from now on. I'm okay, really okay. So please don't worry

about me and don't let Quinton interfere. I don't want him or you in danger."

"I feel like there is something you are not telling me, Aspen."

"It's better if you don't know. I have to deal with this myself." I glance past the screen and onto the ground where the dead body is lying. "I did this, and I'm the one who will be held accountable for it. I'm not scared. I did this consciously, and I would do it again. I'm not sorry."

"Aspen, you need to tell me what you did." Ella tries to be stern with me, but I know telling her would put her in danger. It's better she finds out with everyone else.

"I have to go now, but I promise I'll be okay."

"Aspen, wait! Is that blood on your shirt? You need—" I don't let her finish. Pressing the red button, I end the call and power my phone down immediately after.

I open the door and leave it that way rather than try to hide what I've done. Why should I? I'm not ashamed. And the blood on my clothes I wear with pride, like war paint.

I walk all the way to Lucas's office with my head held high. When I pass anyone, they simply stare at me with wide eyes and their mouth hanging open. I ignore all the shocked stares and move on.

By the time I make it to the office, Lucas is already rushing out to meet me. I guess news travels faster than I can. "Aspen! What happened? Are you hurt?"

He reaches for me, but I move away, shaking my head. "I'm not. This isn't my blood. I killed Nash. He's in my room. He's definitely dead."

His face works, the muscles jumping, eyes darting over my face like he doesn't believe me. "You killed him?"

"Go see for yourself. I'm not trying to cover it up or lie about it. I did it. And I would do it again."

"Why?"

“He was there. He told me he filmed it. He drugged me.”

A few of the other faculty have overheard me making my announcement in the hallway. I hear a gasp, then the pounding of feet as someone runs along the hall, probably to check my room.

Lucas responds to none of that. He’s only looking at me. “No matter how justified your reason. I can’t do anything to help you.”

“I’m not asking you to.”

“You already have witnesses.”

“I’m telling you I understand. Do what you have to do.”

Others call his name from down the hall, shouting, freaking out. He looks their way before letting out a long breath. Maybe he didn’t want to believe it, but now he has no choice.

“Lucas!” Like they’re begging him to do something about this.

He grits his teeth, his jaw twitching while his gaze darts back and forth between me and the mayhem erupting in front of his office. He has no choice. “Take her. Put her in one of the cells.”

If they expect me to fight back, they’re about to be disappointed. I’m prepared to accept my fate.

QUINTON

What was I thinking? How the fuck am I going to fix this. She broke the one rule. The one fucking rule so sacred even I wouldn't consider breaking it.

"Just tell me where she is, Lucas."

"Quinton, you know I can't. And for fuck's sake, stop pacing."

I've been walking back and forth in front of his desk since I got here. How does he expect me to sit down and do nothing? "Tell me where she is, and I'll be out of your view."

"She is somewhere safe," he offers. The same bullshit answer he has been giving me for the last hour. "Your father is already on his way. So are the rest of the founding members."

"I don't give a shit about the founding members."

"Well, you should because they will decide Aspen's fate."

"Fuck, they will."

"Quinton, I don't like this either, but losing your cool won't help." As if his words would actually calm me down.

"Like you care about her."

“I do care about her.” To my surprise, he sounds sincere. “Obviously, I didn’t in the beginning, but I do now. I don’t want anything bad happening to her either, but she fucked up killing him, and then again, letting everyone see. There is no way we can cover this up. We have to find another way.”

“And what is that way?”

“I don’t know yet, but we will figure it out. The best thing right now is not to piss off the founding members even more. Aspen is perfectly safe where I put her. I promise she is fine.”

“I need to talk to her. Why is her phone off?”

“I’ll make sure she gets her phone and turns it on so you can talk to her. I’m also bringing her food and clothes, checking on her constantly.”

I’m still not happy about this, but I feel a little relieved. Not relieved enough to make me stop pacing, though.

My phone vibrates in my pocket, and I pull it out quickly. “It’s my dad,” I announce a millisecond before answering the call. “Dad, I’m with Lucas. I’ll put you on speaker.”

“We’re about to land in Takotna. The helicopter is waiting there, so we should be in Corium in less than two hours.”

I want to tell him that it’s not soon enough, but the rational part of my brain is still somewhat working. I know he is coming here as fast as he possibly can.

“The other founding members are also on their way, but they might not get here as fast,” Lucas explains.

“That’s fine. Gives us more time to plan.”

“How is Aspen?” my mother yells from the background.

“She is doing fine. I’m keeping her separated from everyone for safety.” It didn’t even dawn on me until now that she would be in danger if people knew where she was. For the first time today, I’m actually taking Lucas’s words for what they are. She is somewhere safe.

“Good. Quinton, stay calm. We’re almost there,” my mom adds.

“I’m trying. I just can’t sit here and do nothing.”

“Start by coming up with ideas on how we can sway each founding member to give us their vote,” my father offers.

“Fine.” I huff and take the seat in front of the desk.

“Finally,” Lucas mumbles low enough for only me to hear.

“We’ll get started on that. I’ll see you when you guys get here.” I end the call and turn my attention back to Lucas.

“So who are all the founding members? I thought I knew who they were, but apparently, I didn’t.”

“That’s because the founding members come in three tiers. The people who gave the most money to fund the school and still provide money are in the first two. Tier one is your father, Julian Moretti, Lucian Black, Adrian Doubeck, and my brother, Nic.”

“That’s the people I knew about. No one told me there were more until recently.”

“Tier two are the people who provide an equal amount of funding to the school but asked to stay anonymous. Those three are Enzo King, Alessio Bianchi, and Dr. Lauren.”

“Dr. Lauren?” That one surprises me. She doesn’t have a kid as far as I know.

“Yes, there is more to the good doctor than you think, but that’s something to worry about on a different day.”

“Agreed. So that leaves two people.”

“I see the math classes are paying off.” Lucas chuckles to himself. “Nash’s father, Nathaniel Brookshire, and Anja’s mother, Katharina Ivanov.”

“So how does the voting work?” Hopefully, the higher tiers have more voting power.

“Unfortunately, all the founders get an equal vote.”

“Fuck.”

“Yes, fuck. Nic, Julian, Enzo, and Adrian will be a yes for sure. They have been friends with your family for a very long time. Katharina Ivanov is easily swayed. All we have to do is give her something shiny. Dr. Lauren and Lucian shouldn’t be hard to get on our side either. I am not sure about Alessio, simply because I don’t know much about him. He is a wild card. I only met him once. And of course, Nathaniel Brookshire will be the hardest to deal with.”

“Nash deserved to die.”

“I agree, but making his father see it that way will be a stretch.”

“A stretch... but not impossible.” I don’t know what I need to do yet, but I will figure it out. “I can’t wait and do nothing. I’m going to talk to Vito, see if he can help with his father.”

“That’s a good idea, actually. I’ll check on Aspen while you do that.”

“Make sure she has her phone, and tell her to call me, or I will find her!” I have half a mind to follow Lucas, so I know where she is, but I also know that Lucas won’t be easily tricked.

“Calm down. I’ll make sure she calls you.”

Before I change my mind, I give him a nod and turn away. I head straight to Vito’s room, hoping he is actually there. Yes, I know where he lives, but I don’t know his schedule or where he hangs out if he isn’t in his room.

Raising my hand, I rap my knuckles against his door loud enough for the sound to travel down the empty hallway. There is no noise coming from the inside, no tv or music, but soon enough, I can hear his approaching footsteps.

A moment later, the door opens, and Vito stands in front of me.

“Quinton? To what do I owe this rare pleasure?” His eyebrow raises, but he still doesn’t look too surprised to see me.

“I need to talk. Can I come in?” I ask out of courtesy, though I am already stepping into his space.

He moves aside, opening the door farther to let me in. His room is decorated sparsely, just as I imagine every guy living here.

“Have a seat.” Vito waves toward the leather couch in front of a large flat-screen TV.

I shake my head. “I’m good. This won’t take long.”

“I’m guessing this has something to do with Aspen?”

“You heard what happened?”

“I’m pretty sure everyone has by now.”

“Your father gets a vote. If all the founding members vote in Aspen’s favor, she won’t be punished.”

“I’m aware. My father told me.”

“Do you know what your father is planning on doing? Would he vote in Aspen’s favor?”

“That, I do not know. I think he wants to come and listen to the situation first. It seems that a lot was going on we don’t know about.”

“There is...” I shove my hands in my pockets, mulling over how much I should tell him. I don’t want to tell him too much, nor too little, if it means he would help.

“Look, I like Aspen.” I suppress a growl at Vito’s admission. “But she broke the rules. I don’t think my father will look past that unless she had a very good reason to do so.”

“She did, I can tell you that much. Nash deserved to die, and if Aspen hadn’t done it, I would have.”

“Like you killed the Valentines?” I’m not surprised that he figured it out. The real question is how much does he know?

“Like I would kill anyone who did to Aspen what they did.” It’s not a confession, but not quite a denial either.

“I can talk to my father. Make sure he knows Aspen is a good person, but...” Vito rubs his jaw like he is trying to come up with a good exchange. “I want something in return.”

“Of course, you do.”

“Just a favor. I don’t have anything I want yet, but I’m sure I could use a favor in the future.”

“As long as your father votes in our favor, I’ll do whatever it takes. A favor for a favor,” I repeat the deal out loud, holding out my hand. Vito grabs my hand, and we shake on it.

“You have my word.”

I’m not sure what his favor will be, but I know it will be worth it.

ASPEN

They didn't design these cells for comfort.

I wrap my arms around myself thanks to the chill and grimace at my blood-stiff clothing. There was no time to change once Lucas announced I'd be locked up. Now my shirt is stiff with the evidence of what I did, but the alternative is taking it off, and it's too cold to go topless.

I wonder if anyone would see the humor if I pointed out this is nicer than the room they gave me when I first got to Corium. A tiny bathroom is attached to the cramped cell with nothing but a metal toilet and sink, but they both work. A tiny cot on which I'm now sitting. No blankets, though. I didn't have any in the beginning either, and I still survived.

I wonder what Quinton thinks of what I did. I'm sure he knows, the entire school knows, by now.

He did what he had to do. So did I. I hope he sees that.

Because he would be the only one to see my side, besides maybe Brittney. She must be worried. I wonder if they'd let her visit, but I doubt I'd be afforded that luxury. I'm a murderer. Not only that, but I've broken Corium's golden rule by committing murder on school property.

I can hear footsteps outside the heavy metal door before the lock disengages. It's Lucas, and his arms are full. "Oh, it's you."

“Don’t be too relieved.” Yet when he looks over his shoulder beyond the cell and makes sure we’re alone, his expression softens. “Here. I would never hear the end of it if I didn’t bring you these.” He leaves them on the bed, and I examine what he’s brought. Blankets, a change of clothes, protein bars, and bottled water.

And one more thing, tucked between layers of blanket. My phone.

“I don’t think I need to tell you it’s highly unusual, making sure the prisoner is more comfortable.”

“Thank you,” I whisper.

“Do me a favor?” He points at the phone. “Use that. Otherwise, I don’t know how much longer I’ll be able to keep Quinton away.”

“So he knows?”

“Aspen, at the current moment, you would be hard-pressed to find someone who doesn’t know.” I wonder what he’s thinking as his eyes sweep the room. Probably wishing he hadn’t warmed up to me. All I’ve done is complicate everything. “I suppose that’s all.”

“Really, thank you for this.” He’s almost out in the hall before I think of something else. “Please, can you tell Brittney not to worry about me? Tell her I was thinking of her and want her to know I’m okay. I’m not afraid.”

“You aren’t?” He looks back at me. I can’t read his expression.

“I’m not. Will you tell her?”

“I will.” I don’t know if he’s regretful or not, but he doesn’t look pleased to close the door and leave me alone again.

As soon as he’s gone, I peel off the crusty, bloodstained clothes and wash away any remaining blood in the sink. Once I’m done, I turn on the phone and wait for it to power up. Quinton must be losing it by now if Lucas went so far as to let me have my phone. I can imagine the way he must have raged to get Lucas to allow this.

He answers so fast I don’t even hear the ringing sound to signify the call connected. “What the fuck were you thinking? Doing this?” Even with him

sounding like he's ready to commit murder himself, his voice calms and centers me.

Instead of shouting or pleading, my voice is smooth. "I did what I had to do. I explained it to your mom."

"But you didn't explain it to me? Why didn't you reach out to me?"

"I didn't want you involved."

"Right. Like I'm not involved." He lets out a growl of frustration. "What were you thinking? How did you manage it? And why?"

I've already been through it so many times in my head it comes out like I'm reading from a script. "He came into my room after you left. Talking about that night and how he wanted to have fun because he didn't have the chance to do it. He was too busy recording everything. He was there, and he was the one who drugged me."

"Lucas told me." Quinton's voice is so bitter he barely sounds like himself.

"When I told Nash about the baby, he laughed. He fucking laughed! I gave him what he deserved."

Heavy breathing filters through the phone, letting me hear that his anger matches my own. "Did he hurt you?"

"He barely touched me before I stabbed him."

"Then I'm only sorry I'm not the one who stabbed that piece of shit."

"So you understand why it had to be done?"

"He deserved it. But that doesn't mean you had to put yourself in this position, Aspen. You know what this means, right? Do you understand? I mean really?"

"I do. And I don't regret anything."

"How can you say that?"

"Because it was the right thing to do. Don't you get it? I'm so tired of being the person who gets run over. Always getting hurt, always at somebody

else's mercy. Not only did he laugh when I told him about the baby, but he was going to rape me. That's what he was there for, to get what he didn't get that night. He told me so. Was I supposed to let that happen? What could I have done to stop him, short of killing him?"

More heavy breathing. "So you would sacrifice the rest of your life?" he grunts.

"I would rather die because I did something brave for once than watch my world shrink out of fear. I don't want to live that life. I finally took control. And I'm not scared of whatever is coming."

"You must still be in shock."

"Don't dismiss me. I know what I'm saying. I've never been so clear-headed."

"Goddamnit, Aspen."

It's the desperation in his voice that makes my breath catch. "I'm sorry if this makes things difficult for you."

"Difficult?" He barks out a sharp laugh. "If that's not the fucking understatement of the century. It's fucking impossible."

"What's going on?"

"Are you sure you want to know?"

"I think I deserve to."

His hesitation tells me he disagrees. Either that or he doesn't want to say it out loud. He hardly has to. I know the rules. I know what's coming. "The founding members have called an emergency meeting to decide what to do. They're on their way. Including my father. We're going to see if there's any way we can get you out of this."

"Does he think there's any chance?"

"Aspen..."

"You can tell me. It's okay."

“It won’t be easy.” Of course, he would be stubborn and refuse to accept what I already know. “But we’re going to try like hell. I know we can figure something out. After what they did to you.”

“If he took a video of what happened, there’s no proof that he was actually there. Right? Because he’s not on camera. Besides, he didn’t attack me. I’m sure the members will use that against me, too. And there’s no way for me to prove what he was going to do to me in my room. Nobody was there to hear the things he said either.”

“You can’t give up.”

“Don’t you know there’s a difference between giving up and accepting what can’t be changed?” The thought makes me laugh softly. “Maybe you don’t because you’ve never had to accept something. You’ve always been able to push through. That’s who you are. And it’s how you were raised to be. I’m the person who accepts things and learns to adapt so I can survive.”

“But, Aspen, that’s the problem now. Survival.”

“Then all I can do is spend the time I have left staying strong. I’m not going to fall apart. I won’t beg for my life. I know what I did was right, and that’s all I need to know.”

“What about the people who care about you? Don’t we get a say in this?”

“I’m sorry, but I don’t think so.”

“How am I supposed to accept that?” he demands, and from the sound of it, he’s gritting his teeth. Now, I’m sorry. Not for Nash, never for him, but for Quinton. Even after everything we said earlier, I know he cares about me. Just like I know he would have killed Nash if he’d been there. If only to spare me having to do it. Because all he’s ever done is try to protect me.

This time, I realize, I protected him. “He knew what you did,” I whisper. “What you did afterward. If I hadn’t done it, he could have told somebody. Isn’t that what you were trying to prevent all along by staying away from me?”

“Don’t do this.”

“But it is. I know it. You told me so. If anybody found out we were connected, they’d figure out it was you who killed the Valentines.”

“I know,” he groans.

“So you see, I did the only thing I could to save you, too—just like you made sure to get rid of everybody else because of me. Except if you had done that to Nash, it could’ve blown back on your family. Your mom, Scarlet. I don’t want that. In the end, this was the only way.”

I cut him off when he makes a noise like he’s about to argue. “Please, Quinton. I’ve been thinking about it. You know it’s true. This was the only way. And I really am all right with it, I swear.”

“I’m not.”

“And I’m sorry about that. But if I had it to do over again, I would.”

Someone is speaking in the background. “I have to go for now. I’m still going to do everything I can to help you. I know my father will, too. We’re fighting for you. Don’t give up hope.”

“I won’t.” Does it convince him? I don’t know. Either way, he ends the call, and now I can release the tension in my shoulders and back. I lean against the wall with a sigh, closing my eyes. Somewhere not far from where I’m sitting, Quinton is doing everything he can to get me out of this. Even if I had the heart to tell him not to bother, I know he wouldn’t listen.

But I know the truth, and I’ve accepted it. There’s no way out. I killed Nash, and there’s only one punishment for that.

Even the Rossi family can’t use their power this time. And if they can’t fix this, nothing can.

QUINTON

Once again, I'm standing out in the cold, waiting for my family's helicopter to land. Today, the only difference is that no matter how much the wind blows against me, the cold can't seem to reach me. I'm not warm either. I'm simply nothing. My body and mind are numb, and I don't think it will change until I know Aspen is safe. I am numb because I will lose my damn mind if I let myself feel.

Ren is by my side as the helicopter finally lands. My parents and Scarlet pile out of the door and rush toward us. My mom pulls me into a hug first, wrapping her slender arms around me, squeezing me with a strength she shouldn't have for such a small person. As soon as she lets go, Scarlet jumps into my arms, and my mom moves over to hug Ren.

My dad greets us both with the customary nod. "We came as fast as we could."

"I know. I'm glad you are here." Having my family support me in this way means a lot to me. They basically dropped everything and traveled for hours to get to me. "Thank you for coming so quickly."

"Oh, Quinton, you never have to thank us for something like that. Of course, we come whenever you need us," my mom coos. "Now, let's go talk to Lucas to figure this whole mess out."

"He is checking on Aspen right now, but he'll meet us in your suite."

My father and I grab the suitcases from the helicopter, and I lead my family back to the upper part of Corium and the luxurious suite where they stayed last time.

When we get there, Lucas is already waiting in front of the door.

“How is she?” my mother and I ask simultaneously.

“She is okay. I brought her clothes, food, even a fluffy blanket. Seriously, she is doing fine, oddly content with everything considering.”

“I still don’t like her being locked up somewhere.” Even if she is safe there, she doesn’t belong in a cell.

“Hopefully, she won’t be there much longer,” my mother offers.

My father opens the door with his personal code, and we all pile into the large room. I roll the suitcase into my parents’ bedroom before returning to the living area. My mom and Scarlet take a seat on the large sofa, keeping a spot between them. When Mom waves me over and taps beside her, I realize that spot is for me.

As I sit down, Lucas and Ren take the other couch, and Dad simply stands by the window.

“Nic will be here soon as well,” Lucas says. “But I have already talked to him, and we decided we are willing to do whatever it takes. Whatever we can do to sway votes.”

“That is very generous of you and your brother,” my father answers. “I didn’t realize you were that fond of Aspen.”

“Despite who her father was, she is a good kid. Besides, Nash deserved it, and his father is a fucking prick. I never liked that guy.”

My father nods, staring out the window in thought. “Of course, I have thought about the same. Katharina will be the easiest.”

“Yes, I actually already have something she wants. It’s a large diamond she’s been trying to get ahold of for years. Nic has it with him.”

“Good. I’ve talked to Julian and explained the situation. He is on our side, of course.” My father steps away from the window and starts walking across the room. “Enzo, Lucian, and Adrian also agreed to vote in our favor, as I expected. I have tried to contact Brookshire, but he has avoided my calls and left my messages unanswered.”

Lucas clears his throat. “I’ll talk to him as soon as he gets here. I have also spoken to Dr. Lauren, and we have her vote.”

“I talked to Vito, and he gave me his word that his father would vote against Brookshire.”

“Good, right now, this is as much as we can hope for.” Dad nods.

“It’s not enough. I need it to be a sure thing. I can’t let her die. I owe her so much. Not only did she save Adela but she saved me as well.” Twice actually, but I’m not going to mention that I almost got hit by a huge piece of debris, and she pushed me out of the way. That would only freak them out. “When I came to Corium, I was so lost; she somehow made me feel like myself again.”

“We know.” Scarlet smiles, punching me in the arm playfully. “I could tell she was good for you the first time we came to visit. You were different, less sad all the time.”

“Your sister is right,” Dad agrees. “I might have taken a little longer to see it, but Aspen is obviously good for you. I have thought about one more thing to possibly sway Brookshire to vote for Aspen to live... but it’s drastic, and it would affect the rest of your life.”

I don’t think I simply react. “Whatever it is, I’ll do it.”

She gave herself to me, every piece of her, and now I’m going to return the favor.

ASPEN

The worst thing about lying here on this cot and staring at a blank wall isn't the lack of control over my fate. It's not being uninformed over what's being said about me—I can imagine that clearly enough, anyway.

It's being completely cut off from the rest of the world. I might as well be in a cave, entirely on my own with no windows, no fresh air.

At least I have my phone to check the passage of time. That's my lifeline, my connection to the real world. I'm afraid of what will happen once the battery runs out. Will I live long enough to see that happen?

Quinton. What's he going through? If I have any regret, it's what this is doing to him. I know it isn't easy for someone like him to accept that he can't control everything. Some situations are out of his hands. It must be driving him crazy. I wish I could give him a little comfort, but I'm the reason for his discomfort. It might not go over well, now that I think about it. It's probably for the best that we aren't together.

I don't even know what I'm thinking anymore. I'm too tired in my body and my soul. Maybe it's better for everything to end now.

Think that as I might, the sound of shuffling footsteps outside the cell makes my stomach turn and my pulse go into overdrive. I sit up and swing my feet onto the floor, prepared for whatever is coming. At least, that's

what I tell myself. Really, my hands are clenched tight between my knees to keep them from shaking.

Am I dreaming? I can't believe it's Quinton stepping into the cell, followed by Xander. At first, I'm too overjoyed to do more than smile tearfully. I didn't think I would ever see him again before I died.

Immediately, reality sets in. This isn't a good thing. "You have to leave." I look toward the door and whisper in case anyone else is waiting beyond it. "You shouldn't be here."

"That's not going to happen," Quinton retorts.

"But it's bad for both of you, for the whole family. You're not supposed to be involved with me, remember?" I shoot a panicked look toward Xander and hope he has sense. "You both have to go. For your own good."

"Like I said." Quinton shakes his head. "That's not happening. I made you a promise, remember? I'm not going to abandon you now."

"You have to worry about your family first. They're what you should be concerned about, not me."

"If you don't mind." Xander clears his throat, giving me a stern expression. "I'm the person best suited to decide what is and isn't good for my family. If I believed coming here was truly so much of a threat, neither of us would have stepped foot through the door."

"I see. I'm not trying to tell you what to do, of course. I'm only worried."

"I appreciate that."

I look back at Quinton, who's practically vibrating with intense energy. I've seen that look in his eye before, and things don't usually end well. "How are you?" he grunts.

"Waiting."

"Waiting for what?"

"You know what. Don't make me say it. Not to you." I blink back tears for his sake.

“So that’s it? You’re going to give up? After everything you’ve been through, this is where you decide to give in?”

“I already told you. Didn’t you listen?”

“You weren’t thinking clearly.”

“Don’t tell me how I was thinking. You don’t know.”

Xander shoots his son a look that snaps his mouth shut. It’s a shame I never learned that trick. “I’m sure Quinton only hoped you would come around once given time to clearly consider the situation.”

I look at his father and wish I understood what goes on in his head. There’s no predicting him. “If anything,” I murmur, “I’m more prepared than ever. I know what needs to happen. And I know it would be a waste of time to break down sobbing or pleading for mercy I’ll never receive. I’m not going to humble myself in front of the founders if that’s what you’ve come here to ask me to do. I won’t. I’ll at least keep my dignity in the end.”

When Quinton growls, I add, “At least give me that. Let me decide how this ends.” All he does is turn toward the wall, banging the side of his fist against it.

“Aspen, this is a mistake.” Xander wears an expression of what could pass for genuine concern if it were coming from anyone else. Given our history, he can’t expect me to believe he’s really worried.

“If anything,” I remind him, “you should be glad I did this. I got rid of the last link to my attack. The last link between your family and the Valentines getting wiped out.”

“You do realize even if you admit you did it purely for yourself, no one could blame you.”

“Then if I did it purely for myself, why isn’t it enough that I’m ready to accept the consequences?”

“Because, for one thing, your father didn’t sacrifice his life for you to give yours up so thoughtlessly.”

My head snaps back. “What does he have to do with any of this?”

“I’m trying to tell you. Just as he said in the video, he sacrificed himself for your sake. That was a choice he made, to die as he did.”

“How do you know about the video?” I shoot Quinton a look, but he’s unreadable, still facing the wall. “How would you know what he was thinking?”

“Because I was there. I facilitated the video’s creation.” He stares at me, unblinking. “And I killed him.”

Any other time in my life, I would have been shocked, speechless, probably falling to my knees. But considering what I have been through in the last few days, nothing affects me like it usually would. My mind stays clear, my breath even, my voice calm.

I know it’s true. I feel it. Xander killed my father, and now, with nothing to lose, I’m not afraid to speak my mind. “You can stand there and tell me that? Like it’s nothing. How can it mean nothing to you?”

“Aspen...” Quinton warns, but I’m not in the mood to hear it. Clyde Mather might not have been my biological father, but he was my dad. He raised me. He loved me. He was flawed, and his life was already on the wrong track before I was ever born. But he always treated me like his own. I can’t help wanting to stick up for him even in death.

Xander absorbs this without reacting. “Because he wanted it that way. It was what he told you in the video, right?”

“How do I know you didn’t put him up to it?”

“What would I have to gain from that?”

I roll my eyes, unable to stop myself. I’m already looking death in the eyes. What’s the point? “Right. Because everything is a matter of gain. Everything has to be weighed and judged based on how it affects you.”

“Stop.” Quinton stands over me, and for the first time since entering the cell, he touches my shoulder. “You don’t understand.”

“Clyde reached out to me and asked me to visit the prison,” Xander explains, his voice strangely calm. “He asked me point-blank how his

choices had affected you. I didn't mince words. I admit I was hard on him but not out of anything he did to me. What was between us was understood. I explained how difficult things have been for you. He knew his life was worth nothing, either in or out of prison. The moment he stepped foot outside, if he got paroled, it might very well have been his last moment. He had nothing left to live for but your safety. The only way to remove the target from your back was to eliminate him. He asked me to do it. He wanted me to, but only once he sent you a final message."

He folds his arms, scowling. "And now you are going to throw it all away. His sacrifice. It means nothing if you give up your life now."

Somehow, it feels true. It feels like something he would have done. To reach out directly to the man he betrayed and have him be the one to end it. Why wait? At least he had control in the end of how he went. When he went. And why.

"It's too late now. We all know there's nothing that can be done. I killed Nash. And I'm not sorry."

"Nor should you be," Xander agrees. He exchanges a look with his son. "However, I believe we've come up with a plan to sway the opinion of the founding members."

"What is it?"

"You could become a Rossi. One of us. It's not a guarantee, but it would definitely make Brookshire think twice about having you killed."

"You mean you would adopt me?" It makes no sense.

He shakes his head. "You need to marry Quinton. Today, before they arrive."

My head snaps up to find Quinton staring down at me. "Is he serious?"

"Very. And we need to hurry. We need to do it before they assemble." Quinton hauls me to my feet while I sputter in surprise. This can't be happening.

“But if we are getting married, then everyone will know. I mean, they will know that it was you who killed the Valentines.”

“Probably, yes,” Xander agrees.

“Then we can’t do this. I can’t let you put yourself in danger.” I try digging my heels into the floor, but Quinton has a tight grip on my arm, pulling me along with ease.

“I told you not to worry about that. Things have changed now that your father is dead. And some new developments are going to tip the scale even more. Marrying into the family will be the final push we need.”

Ignoring the fact of him casually talking about my father’s death, I wonder if this is even real. I must have fallen asleep on the cot. It’s all a dream. Xander Rossi would never accept me as a daughter-in-law.

Yet before I know it, we’re upstairs in one of the student rooms, where Scarlet and Ella are waiting for me. I don’t even know whose room this is or why these two are here.

“Ladies, don’t take long.” Xander closes the door, and now I see a white dress hanging from the mirror behind it.

“There you are. We don’t have much time, as my husband said.” I can barely catch my breath before Ella pulls me into the adjoining bathroom. “Wash up quickly. Scarlet will worry about your hair and makeup. The shoes should fit. The dress, as well.”

“Why do you already have a dress and—”

“Face. Wash.” She can be sharp when she wants to. I suppose Xander Rossi’s wife would need a core of steel running through her to deal with that man. I quickly wash my face, then run a soapy cloth over my neck, shoulders, and arms. It’s as much as I can manage before Ella claps her hands and directs me back into the room where Scarlet awaits.

“I wish we had more time to get you all done up like a queen.” Excitement sparkles in Scarlet’s eyes when they meet mine before she touches a brush to my cheek. “Don’t worry. I’ve perfected my quick makeup game. You

never know when your plans might change, and you need to impress somebody.”

I don’t know how to respond, so I don’t bother. Besides, in the grand scheme of things, Scarlet’s makeup prowess is hardly the first thing on my mind. Ella, meanwhile, gets to work undressing me. I don’t have time to feel embarrassed since she works too fast for my brain to keep up. She’s seen me at my worst, anyway. They both have.

“How long have you had this planned?” I ask.

“Here. Step into it. Lift your feet.” Ella avoids my question, pooling the dress at my feet. I step into it, and she raises it over my legs and hips. “Don’t worry about it. We have all the details taken care of. All that matters is doing this so you’ll be safe.”

“And you’re going to make a beautiful bride,” Scarlet adds before dabbing gloss on my lips.

“That goes without saying,” Ella agrees.

All I can do is laugh. “I can’t stop thinking this is a dream.”

“It’s no dream.” Ella slides the dress’s lace sleeves over my arms. I hold my breath as she raises the zipper. No way will it fit. But it does, like a glove.

“Let me do something with your hair now.” Scarlet trades places with her mom, and before I know it, she’s sliding pins into my hair. Meanwhile, Ella crouches in front of me, sliding a pair of simple white heels onto my feet.

“You should have a little something pretty, too.” She looks almost guilty before pulling a box from her purse lying on the bed. I recognize it before she opens it. “I found it in your room. Quinton told me it might be there. I hope you don’t mind.”

“Not at all.” In fact, I love that he thought about it. The silver lotus looks perfect when paired with my white dress. She clasps it for me, and I exhale, touching my fingertips to the flower. This is all happening so suddenly. I can’t help wishing I could savor at least a bit of it.

I'm marrying Quinton today. I'm going to be his wife. It's too big to wrap my head around, but I better wrap my head around it because it's going to happen any minute now.

"The flowers!" Scarlet scurries across the room, where a gorgeous bouquet waits in a vase by the window. I didn't notice it before now, or if I did, I guess I assumed it belonged to whoever this room belongs to. Turns out it's my wedding bouquet, consisting of big, luscious gardenias and hydrangea with a few cream-colored roses sprinkled in.

"This is beautiful. It's all so beautiful." And when Ella steps away, allowing me to look at myself in a mirror hanging on the back of the door, I almost can't believe my eyes. In a matter of minutes, they've transformed me into a bride. The floor-length satin dress and its lace sleeves, combined with the pretty, feminine updo Scarlet somehow created and the soft makeup she applied, take my breath away. I barely recognize myself.

"You can't tell me you didn't plan this somehow." I look at them in the reflection, standing behind me with an arm around each other's waists. "No way you made this happen out of nowhere."

"Let's just say we wanted to plan for all contingencies when we arrived." Ella runs a finger under her eye like she might be tearing up.

"Thank you both so much. I know this isn't ideal, but..." I look at myself again and can't help but smile. "You made me feel beautiful. Like a bride. I can't ever thank you enough."

"You're going to make me cry now, too." Scarlet sniffles.

Ella waves her hands in front of her face. "No time for that. Let's go get you married."

I know there's no point in them asking whether I want to go through with this. They merely assume I do.

If it means sparing my life and getting to be Quinton's wife at the same time, I'm more than willing. In fact, I can't wait. I love him. I want nothing more than to be with him forever. No more obstacles. No reasons to pretend we aren't together.

I was ready for my life to be over. Now, it's only the beginning.

With Ella on one side and Scarlet on the other, they walk me to the library. I feel like I'm floating on a cloud, completely caught up in the moment. So caught up, in fact, I almost didn't notice Lucas waiting outside the library doors.

"We'll go inside." Ella kisses my cheek and Scarlet the other before they go into the library. A thank you is sitting at the tip of my tongue, but they are already gone before I can form the words.

Lucas looks me up and down, then smiles. "Considering the speed with which they put you together, you make a beautiful bride."

"Is this really happening?"

"It is. Are you ready?"

"How could anybody be ready for this?"

"Good point. But it's for the best if it means sparing your life." He cares. I almost can't believe it, but he really wants me to make it out of this.

One surprise follows another when he steps up beside me and holds out his bent arm. "May I walk you down the aisle?"

"I'd be happy if you did." I tuck my hand into the crook of his elbow, then take a deep breath.

It looks like I'm about to get married.

QUINTON

I've never taken the time to imagine my wedding day. I doubt many guys have. But if I had, there's no way I could have come up with this in a million years.

Still, we could do worse. The high, bowed ceilings and light streaming through the windows bring to mind a cathedral. The chandeliers add to the effect. It's more impressive than a room at City Hall anyway. It's still not as much as Aspen deserves, though.

Brittney takes a few steps back from the arch she created. "Not bad, considering I had to come up with something in record time." I have to agree. She emptied a few shelves' worth of books, creating two tall stacks before sliding one of the wooden shelves free from a bookcase and using it as an arch. I have to give her points for creativity. Beneath it stands the priest my father flew in for the occasion.

And here I am, waiting for my bride. It's all happening so fast. And if I feel shell-shocked, I can only imagine what Aspen is going through. At least she had the presence of mind not to waste time fighting or demanding an explanation. The founders could arrive at any time, and they aren't going to waste a minute.

"How are you holding up?" Julian asks. He and Nic will stand with me while Brittney stands with the bride. I don't know where Lucas is. I had imagined he would want to witness the ceremony.

“It’s a shame you couldn’t have a bachelor party,” Nic murmurs with a grin.

I don’t need a bachelor party. All I need is Aspen. I would do much more than this to ensure her safety, and I have. I’ve killed for her. I would burn down the entire world if it meant sparing her. Compared to that, exchanging vows doesn’t seem like much.

But it’s more than that. I know it. She knows it. As much of a whirlwind as this has been, inside, I know it was always meant to be this way. She was always going to be mine. There was never a choice. She belongs to me.

There’s a commotion at the front of the room, and a moment later, Mom and Scarlet are here. “She’s beautiful,” Scarlet whispers with a wink, but she doesn’t need to bother. I have no doubt Aspen’s stunning. Mom gives me a quick hug and a peck on the cheek before falling back a few steps to stand on what I suppose would be my side of the aisle if there technically was an aisle.

“It looks like we’re ready to begin,” the priest announces. He nods toward the front of the room.

I turn in time to see Aspen enter on Lucas’s arm. The rest of the world falls away, and there’s nothing but her. And they did all this in a few minutes? She couldn’t be more stunning if they had taken all day with her hair and makeup. She’s glowing, radiant. Perfect. Not that she needs the extra work. She’s always perfect.

Brittney lets out a choked sob, and Aspen’s smile widens. She hands over her bouquet before giving her friend a brief hug. She then turns to smile up at Lucas. “Thank you,” she whispers. He responds with a single nod, then moves aside to stand near Brittney.

Finally, Aspen offers me a shy smile. “Hi.”

“You’re beautiful.”

She offers me her hand, and I take it before raising it to my lips.

The priest clears his throat. “You may join both hands,” he instructs in a low voice before raising it for everyone else’s ears. “Dearly beloved, we’re gathered here to join this man and this woman in matrimony. If anyone here

can offer any objection as to whether they should be joined, speak now or forever hold your peace.”

Aspen’s hands tighten around mine, and it’s as if I can feel her fear. She’s waiting for the other shoe to drop, for someone to burst in and ruin everything. It does seem to be the way our history has gone so far.

Nothing like that happens. She relaxes her grip.

“Then let us begin.” He looks at me, then at Aspen. “Do you both enter into this marriage contract of your own free will? With the full understanding of the gravity of such a commitment?”

“Yes,” Aspen whispers.

“I do, as well.” We share another smile. It’s like something out of a dream, like it can’t possibly be happening to us. I might as well be watching another couple go through this. At the same time, I feel her hands in mine. My fingers brush over the inside of her wrist, and her pulse throbs. This is real.

“Then I ask you, Quinton Rossi. Do you take this woman, Aspen Mather, to be your lawfully wedded wife? To love and to cherish from this day forward? To have and to hold, in sickness and in health, for richer or poorer? Will you love and honor her as long as you both shall live?”

It’s the easiest question I’ve ever been asked. There’s only one answer, and when I speak, it’s with my entire heart. This might not be the traditional way of going about things, but there’s no question of whether or not I’m fully in this. “I do.”

Aspen bites her lip, cheeks flushing. Mom sniffles while Scarlet lets out a choked sob. I would look over at them, maybe shoot Dad a look to stop them, but I only have eyes for the woman in front of me.

“And you, Aspen. Do you take Quinton to be your lawfully wedded husband? To love and to cherish, to have and to hold, in sickness and in health, for richer or poorer? Will you love and honor him as long as you both shall live?”

She takes a breath, and for a split second, I fear she's going to say no. If she's so determined to face her fate, she would be stubborn enough to refuse now that she's had a moment to catch up.

"I do." She breathes before a single tear rolls down her cheek. Paired with a brilliant smile, I know it's a tear of happiness.

"Thank you," I whisper, and she laughs softly.

"Who has the rings?"

"Oh, that would be me." My father steps up, slipping a hand into his inner pocket and withdrawing a pair of gold bands. He offers Aspen an almost apologetic look. "These will have to do for now." If he knew her like I do, he would know there's no need for an apology. She isn't the sort of girl who places high value on things. Items. I intend to spoil the hell out of her once we're out of this, but not because she demands it. Because she deserves it.

And because it's a hell of a lot of fun to spoil someone who doesn't expect it.

The priest takes the rings and places them on his open Bible before murmuring a prayer. "These rings are a symbol of eternity," he explains. "A circle has no beginning or ending, as love has neither a beginning nor an end. They symbolize the eternal nature of your love and devotion."

We look from the rings to each other. Love and devotion. My heart swells because, yes, I am devoted to her. Even without the presence of a priest or prayers or promises, I'm devoted to nothing more than her protection. She's my world. And I could have lost her. Reminding myself of that only makes her seem more precious.

"Quinton, you may go first." With my heart in my throat, I reach for the smaller of the two bands. "Repeat after me. With this ring, I thee wed."

Simple words, but they mean everything. How many people have said them without any idea what it would mean to uphold their vows? How many times have they been broken at the slightest hint of conflict or adversity?

Yet here we are, having already faced more than most couples face over an entire lifetime. Is it too much to hope as I slide the cold metal over Aspen's

waiting finger that we've gotten all of the adversity out of the way already?

I make it a point to look her in the eye so she knows I mean it. "With this ring, I thee wed." This time Mom blurts out a sob, and I glance her way. She shakes her head, waving a hand for us to go on.

"And you, Aspen." She glances at the priest before taking the ring in her hand. "With this ring, I thee wed."

What's going through her head? Everything that went through mine and still is? I search her face for any sign of it, but all I see is her beauty. The way she glows. Is that hope shining in her eyes? Is she as hopeful as I am?

"With this ring, I thee wed." She slides the ring on my finger. A perfect fit. I closed my hand around hers. It's almost too much to believe, but the ring is on my hand. And it's not coming off, not for anything, not ever. I would sooner cut off my finger than ever remove it. Somehow, I know I would still feel it. Just like nothing could ever remove her from my soul.

"Then, by the power vested in me, I pronounce you are husband and wife." The priest smiles intelligently. "Quinton, you may kiss your lovely bride."

That's it. A few simple words, and we're different than we were before. We're joined completely, body and soul. Nothing is ever going to tear us apart.

"Mrs. Rossi," I murmur, taking her face in my hands, noting the dampness on her cheeks. She tips her head back, offering her lips, and I press mine to them. It's a brief, chaste kiss for the sake of everyone around us, but I offer it with everything in me. I only hope she feels all I've put into it.

Judging by her soft smile when we break the kiss, I think she does.

There's not much time to reflect on that before my mother mauls me. "I'm sorry!" She laughs, squeezing me tight. "I'm just so happy. It was so beautiful." Scarlet, meanwhile, accepts the bouquet from Brittney, who then wraps Aspen in a fierce hug.

Dad steps up and thrusts out a hand. "Congratulations, Son."

“Thank you.” Before he can let go, I clasp his hand tighter, making him turn back to me with surprise. “I mean it. Thank you.” It doesn’t seem like nearly enough, but it’s all I feel like I can say in mixed company. He seems to understand anyway, nodding before thanking the priest for his help.

“Congratulations to the two of you.” Lucas looks anything but joyous. I hardly need to be reminded of our situation, but his tense expression brings it all back. “I hate to be a wet blanket, but it would be best if Aspen were returned to the cell until the founders’ meeting takes place.”

“How much longer until that happens?” Aspen asks.

“Later today. It won’t be long, I’m sure. They won’t want to wait.”

She’s trying to be brave, it’s obvious. Lifting her chin, squaring her shoulders. She’s dressed like a bride but has the bearing of a soldier.

It’s obvious what I need to do. I’m not being separated from my wife minutes after the ceremony. “I’ll go with you.”

Her eyes go wide. “No way. You don’t belong there.”

“You’re my wife. I belong wherever you are, remember? For better or for worse?” I don’t care how corny it sounds or that everyone can hear. After everything she’s been through, the least she deserves is everyone hearing she’s worth sacrificing for. “Wherever you go. I go.”

“Very well. If you insist.” With that, we follow Lucas down to the cell. Husband and wife.

All I can do is hope it’s enough to save her.

ASPEN

“*Y*ou know, you really don’t have to do this.” It seems silly, the two of us locked together in this tiny room. “I can handle it by myself. I’m used to being on my own, remember?”

Quinton narrows his eyes. My husband. He’s my husband now. “Why do you do that?”

“Do what?”

“Insist on having your way? I’m telling you, you don’t have to be alone anymore.” He takes my face in his hands like he did after the ceremony. I still can’t believe it happened.

But I have the ring on my finger to prove it, and so does he.

“You’re my wife, remember? What I said up there, I meant. For better, for worse. In sickness and in health. Always.” He glances around the room. “Even if it means waiting in here with you. It’s a small sacrifice to make sure you aren’t alone.”

I’m glad. I don’t want to be alone, especially with our wedding to process. “Can you believe we did that?”

“Honestly, I’m still trying to catch up.”

“It all happened so fast.”

“I’m sure Dad knew before he ever left home this was how it would have to be.” We take a seat on the cot, holding hands. It’s sudden and almost awkward, but at least we’re in it together. Trying to make sense of how quickly life changed.

“He must have. Otherwise, where did this come from?” I look down at my beautiful dress.

“I’m sure it’s not what you dreamed about getting married in. But for what it’s worth, you couldn’t have been more beautiful in some designer gown. One of those big, fluffy things.”

“I felt beautiful. I think that’s all that matters.”

With his free hand, he strokes my cheek, his gaze softening. “You’re not unhappy? You weren’t given much of a choice.”

“It’s not exactly like being forced into marriage with a stranger or someone I hate.” Even now, I have to call on my courage to speak the words on my heart. “I’m pretty glad it turned out like it did. I’m happy we’re married now. What about you? You think you are going to regret this soon?”

“Never. Not for a second, Aspen.” He draws me closer, our breath mingling for a moment before he touches his lips to mine. Unlike the kiss after the ceremony, this one’s slower. Deeper. His lips move against mine like he’s a man with all the time in the world. Like we’re anywhere but this cramped room, waiting to hear my fate.

His tongue dances along the seam of my lips, and I part them gladly, melting against him at his first probe inside my mouth. The fire he ignites in my core is like magic. I lean into him, my arms sliding around his neck while his hands sink deeper into my hair, holding me in place so he can claim me with his lips, his tongue.

“You know...” He nips at my bottom lip before grazing my chin, then my throat. “There’s one thing we still have to do to make it official.”

He lifts his head, and there’s mischief gleaming in his eyes. “We still have to consummate our marriage.”

“Otherwise, it’s not official or something, right?”

He grins. "Something like that." He runs a hand down my side, over my hip. "I like this. It feels nice. Almost as nice as your skin."

When he begins inching it up, I hold his hand still and shake my head. "What's wrong?" he asks.

"I don't want to ruin it, is all. It's my wedding dress. This is special. Your mom went to all the trouble of bringing it for me." I stand and turn my back to him. "You can have the honor of unzipping me."

"Remind me to tear your clothes off the next time I have the chance." He lowers the zipper slowly, spreading the sides of the dress apart so his hands can slide over my back. "I told myself no man, other than me, would put his hands on you ever again, but I have to admit, it feels good to know it's official."

I lay the dress over the foot of the cot before straddling Quinton's lap. "Now. Where were we?" I wind my arms around his neck and settle in against him. My craving for him is too much to hold back. He's never seemed as precious to me. We might have missed out on this.

"I think I was about to get naked with my wife." His lips twitch as he holds back a smile. "Wife. It's going to take a minute for that to sound right."

"But it feels right, doesn't it?"

His hands cup my ass and haul me in closer until I'm wedged against his growing dick. "Feels pretty good to me," he growls. Yet instead of throwing me onto the cot the way I expect, he rubs me against him, teasing us both.

I don't want to be teased. I want him. All of him. An hour ago, I was sure I'd die without seeing him again, touching him again. I'm almost ready to whine with need. "Touch me," I beg before kissing him. Rather than let him do the grinding, I take over. He growls into my mouth, and wetness floods my slit.

"Where should I touch you?" he asks when I come up for air.

"Everywhere. All of me." I unbutton his shirt with trembling hands before pushing it over his shoulders. I can't be close enough to him. My heart's

pounding, but so is his. I feel it thumping in his chest when I pull him tight against me.

He moves my thong aside, and I moan in relief when he runs his fingers between my already swollen lips. “So wet,” he groans as he works his way through my sensitive folds. I rock my hips faster, bearing down on him. My body has taken over, searching for satisfaction. A single moment of bliss after so much ugliness and pain.

His lips travel my throat, my shoulder, his tongue painting my skin.

Now I’m an express train racing to the finish, rocking frantically, desperate for release from the delicious agony he’s putting me through. “Please... please...”

“Please, what?” The pressure from his finger increases as he assaults my clit. “What do you want?”

“I want... to come... oh, please...”

He chuckles against my neck, and even that is exquisite. The intensity of my arousal makes even the slightest contact feel like an explosion of sensation. The sensation of his breath makes my skin sizzle, and all I can do is whimper, helpless against it. “You ready to come?”

“Yes, oh, god...”

“You want to squirt all over my hand?”

It’s torture. He’s killing me. I hope it never stops. “Please, yes!”

“Then be a good girl. Come for me, Aspen.”

I squeeze my eyes shut a split second before it hits, crashing over me all at once. It’s like flying, soaring above the clouds with the sun in my face and nothing around me but a clear, blue sky. The rocking of my hips slows, and the sensation fades away until there’s nothing but the cell. Quinton. His arms around me, mine around him. I bury my face in his neck and offer a quiet moan before shuddering one last time.

“That sounded like fun.” He’s not finished yet, not even close. There’s hunger in his voice that calls out to the hunger in me, promising much more

than a single orgasm to mark this occasion. “Think you have another one for me?”

He lifts me slightly, giving himself room to unzip his pants and remove his dripping dick from his shorts. I take it in my hand, rubbing precum along the shaft before giving him the first slow stroke. He closes his eyes, his jaw working, Adam’s apple bobbing. “Fuck...”

Now I can control his pleasure the way he controlled mine. There are so many ways to feel powerful. I’m starting to understand that now. Having control over my life. My safety. My body.

I control my husband’s satisfaction. I control him, really—he’s entirely at my mercy, and knowing I can please him only heightens my pleasure.

Taking a page from his book, I lean in and give his earlobe a playful nibble before growling. “What do you want me to do with this?” I rasp, giving the head a slight squeeze before running my hand down to the base.

He lets out a long groan. “Put it inside you.”

I raise myself on my knees and line him up with my quivering hole before lowering myself on him. Slowly. Savoring the sensation of every inch pushing into my channel. We both grunt when I slide home, joining us completely.

He opens his eyes and looks into mine. I wonder if he’s thinking what I am. We’re married now. Forever. Tears fill my eyes, and I touch the side of his face with my palm, running a thumb over his lips as I begin to move.

He kisses me, then kisses away the tear that spills onto my cheek. “Don’t cry,” he whispers.

I don’t have the words or the breath to explain. I’m not unhappy. I’ve never been happier in my life, and I don’t know what to do with it. I’m afraid my heart will break, and all the happiness and love will spill out.

Over and over, I fill myself with him. Plunging down, lifting up, the friction building. Pushing away all thoughts of love and happiness. There’s nothing but feeling now. Desire. He buries his face in my chest, and I lean back, offering myself to him. The motion of my hips increases when his lips close

around my nipple. He sucks greedily, like an animal, and all it does is make me take him harder. Faster.

Suddenly, he lifts me, leaving me, and it's like reaching the top of the first hill of a roller coaster and stopping. My heart sinks, but not for long. He has other plans, shifting me so I'm on my back. He moves between my legs, pushing them farther apart before plunging into me again.

Yes, I like it this way. Letting him take control now while I wrap my arms and legs around him and hold him as tight as I can. I want to keep him this way forever, just the two of us. Locked in each other's arms, joined together as one body.

"Oh, yeah, that's nice. Fuck." He closes his eyes, losing himself, rolling his hips before driving forward hard enough to make me whimper when our bodies grind together.

We almost lost this. He's never been more precious.

"Are you going to come for me?" He grunts before slamming into me again. "Are you going to be a good wife and come for your husband?"

"Y-Yes!" I manage to sob, digging into his back with my nails. He hisses, gritting his teeth before driving himself forward again. "Make me come!" It's almost here. I feel it tightening my core until nothing's left but to explode or die from the sweet torture.

This is what they tried to take from me. This wild abandon. Trusting somebody with my body. The ability to let myself go, knowing I'll be safe. Every scratch across Quinton's back is an act of rebellion. Every whimper when he fills me up. I reclaim this. I reclaim myself.

"That's right." He drops to his forearms, his face inches from mine while he hammers me. "Come with me. Milk my cock."

"Oh, my god!" I close my eyes, losing myself in what's building faster than before. Stronger, too. I'm almost afraid of it, but I welcome it anyway. Nothing can hurt me when I'm in his arms.

"That's right. You're getting tighter. I feel it. You're so close, aren't you?" Somehow, he squeezes a hand between us and rubs my clit, making me jerk

my hips to meet his touch. “Let me watch you. So fucking gorgeous. Come for me.”

I couldn’t help myself even if I tried. It’s too strong, too much. I’m—

I barely bite back a scream, and my entire body goes stiff like I’ve been shocked before the tension breaks, and I sob in relief. I melt into his arms, draped around him as the flood gates open, and all my emotions come rushing out. I can’t control it. This release, this emptying of everything I’ve held inside. It feels too good to stop.

By the time it subsides, I feel calm. Clean. Peaceful, finally.

And he’s holding me. I barely noticed him coming, thanks to the intensity of what hit me. “Are you okay?” he murmurs, and his concern is touching. “Was that okay for you? Tell me the truth.”

At first, I can only nod. I’m still breathless. Once it passes, I make sure to tell him. “Yes. I’m just great.” When he rolls onto his back, I follow him, resting against his chest with a leg draped over him. For a long time, we lie together like this. Quiet. United.

Though I can’t forget what’s coming. It only makes him more precious to me than ever.

“I want you to know something.” He hooks a finger beneath my chin then lifts it so our eyes meet. “Today? Our wedding? It was more than a means to an end. Making you one of us to save you.”

I’m afraid my heart will forget to beat. “You mean it?”

“Are you surprised?”

“It’s still nice to hear.”

“Then this will be even better.” He cups my cheek. “I love you. I always will. You’re the only thing I care about in this world. You have my name, but you’ve had my heart much longer than that. And I intend to devote the rest of my life to you. My wife.”

Tears sting my eyes. I felt it or thought I did, but hearing it come from his lips is different. “I wish I had as much to offer you.”

“Are you kidding?” His eyes move over my face, and a tender smile begins to stir. “You’ve given me everything. All of yourself. Your first worry when I walked in here earlier was for my safety, mine, and my family. What more could I ask for?”

“That’s because I love you, too.” I can’t stop the tears welling in my eyes. “I love you so much. And I’m proud to be your wife.”

“I plan to live up to that pride.” He places a kiss against my forehead, then my nose, before touching his lips to mine. I settle in against his chest and close my eyes. Why can’t we be anywhere but here? We should be getting ready to leave for our honeymoon. Not in a cell, waiting for me to be judged.

At least I’ll have this moment to carry in my heart. Some people don’t get that much.

QUINTON

Luckily, Aspen had some comfortable clothes to change into after I took the wedding dress off her. Of course, I would prefer holding her in my arms naked, but knowing that Lucas could be walking in at any minute puts a big damper on that thought.

“I really hope this is the one and only time we’re waking up in a prison cell together,” Aspen mumbles, her voice still heavy with sleep.

“Look at the positive. Not many people can tell their grandkids a cool story like that.”

“I think we have a different idea of what a cool story is.” Aspen giggles, making the too-small cot shake.

“Your giggle might be the cutest thing about you.”

“Cuter than my tits?”

“Your tits aren’t cute. They’re... mouthwatering.” Just as I start grinding my hardening cock against her soft ass, the sound of someone approaching the cell makes me stop and sit up. “I guess it’s time.”

As if someone popped the bubble we built around us, the air in the small room changes in an instant. Gone is the fun, carefree, small talk as we are reminded of where we are and why we are here.

Aspen sits up with me, and we both watch as the door opens, and Lucas walks in. “They are ready. It’s time.”

Grabbing Aspen's hand, I nod and get up from the cot. We slip into our shoes and follow Lucas out into the hallway.

"We already buttered them up as much as we could. The rest is up to you. Brookshire insists on speaking to you directly. Whatever he says, keep your cool. Both of you," Lucas urges, giving me an accusing side-eye.

We spent the rest of the way up to the meeting room in silence. There isn't really anything else to say. Besides, I need to concentrate on calming myself enough not to rip Nash's father's head off as soon as I walk in there.

Lucas leads us to a large room in the upper part of the castle. In the center of the space sits a giant oval table that looks like it's a part of the castle. Around the table are all the founding members, including my father, who gives me a slight reassuring nod.

Everyone is dressed well in suits, and each person's face is an impenetrable mask, minus Brookshire, who is staring daggers through Aspen, and his beady eyes narrow further once Lucas opens his mouth.

"Take a seat," Lucas orders, and we sit down at the end of the table. Lucas takes the chair beside us. "As requested, you may ask any questions now."

"So it's true. You did marry? Is that why you killed my son? Did you think you'd simply get away with it because you are a Rossi?"

"I killed him because he attacked me."

"Sure, he did, and do you have any proof of that?"

"Her word is enough proof," I interject. "Nash has been trying to get to her for months, and he knew she was under my protection. There was no reason for him to be in her apartment."

"Maybe she invited him? Who knows, with how many guys she slept with behind your back." I curl my hand into a fist, ready to slam his face into the edge of the table.

"I didn't invite Nash. As a matter of fact, I asked him to leave. I told him to stay away from me multiple times. He wouldn't. Then he admitted to drugging me. He gave me a drug that led me to have a miscarriage."

Brookshire shakes his head. "You are lying. Many words and no proof."

"She is telling the truth. I examined Aspen myself," Dr. Lauren announces.

"I also had my personal doctor examine her right after the attack, and he agreed. Furthermore, we have a video taken with Nash's phone that proves he was there when Aspen was attacked. All of that leads me to believe it was your son who killed my grandchild."

For the first time since we entered this room, Nathaniel looks a little pale. "Those are all speculation, and even if there was some truth to that, Corium rules are clear. No death to any student can take place on school grounds."

"Of course, you are right. But these are very special circumstances, and of course, we would offer your family something as a gesture of goodwill."

"Did you make that same offer to the Valentine family? Is that why they are all dead? They wouldn't take your deal?"

"We are here to discuss Aspen," Lucas cuts him off. "The Valentines have nothing to do with this."

Nathaniel's eyes become slits. "Sure, they don't. I wonder if the rest of Corium agrees with that. Not to mention everyone we work with. Your family might be powerful, but there is an end to your reach, you know?"

"Are you threatening me?" My father raises an eyebrow.

"Of course not. Simply pointing out the truth."

"Good thing our family just expanded, solidifying one of our allies with a marriage." My father grins.

"Ally? Even if Mather wasn't dead, he would have hardly been of any help to you."

"Clyde Mather wasn't Aspen's biological father," Lucas tells everyone at the table. "I am."

What the fuck?

I expected a lot coming into this, but Lucas telling everyone Aspen is his daughter was definitely not on that list.

“You are her father?” Nathaniel sputters.

I look over at Aspen to find her staring at Lucas with her mouth gaping open and her eyes wide as can be. She definitely is just as surprised as I am.

“Yes. Aspen is my biological daughter. Nic is her uncle, and though we agree she has broken the rule, we are also willing to rectify her action in another way. My family is willing to offer you part of our territory.”

“That won’t bring my son back.”

“Neither will killing her,” Nic Diavolo says. Speaking for the first time, his voice deep and penetrating. Where my father is ice cold, Nic reminds me of the devil, cunning, and ruthless. His dark hair is slicked back, and his features, though a little weathered, you wouldn’t be able to tell based on his psyche. “But letting her live will give you and your other children peace of mind.”

“Piece of mind?” Nathaniel scoffs.

“Yes, because it means that I won’t come after your family for killing the heir of the Rossi empire,” my father adds.

“And what about the rest of you?” Nathaniel addresses all of the founding members. “Do you think we should let her live? How would that look to the rest of the students and their parents?”

“This is a blind vote,” Lucas explains. “No one has to tell you what they are voting for.”

“I guess then there is only one thing left to do. Let’s vote.” Nathaniel leans back in his chair, crossing his arms over his chest.

“Let’s begin.” Lucas nods and gets up from his chair. He grabs a large metal bowl from a display case hanging on the wall and starts walking around the oval table. “If you agree to let Aspen live, simply write an L on the paper. If you think her punishment should be death, write an X on the paper.”

Each founding member pulls out a piece of paper and quickly scribbles something on it before folding it up. I try to make out what everyone is

writing, but of course, there isn't much of a different hand motion between X and L, making it impossible to know.

I reach for Aspen's hand under the table, interlacing our fingers. She gives my hand a little squeeze, and when I glance her way, her lips form the words, "*I love you.*"

Lucas moves around the table one more time, letting everyone throw their paper back in. When he returns to his seat, he dumps all the papers out, showing everyone the empty bowl.

One by one, he unfolds each paper, and with each sight of the L scribbled down, I can breathe a little easier. The first five papers are votes in our favor, which means we're halfway through. Maybe one of those five was Brookshire's vote. There is no way to know. Lucas could open his last. Or someone else could betray us. The votes are anonymous. Would there be a way for us to find out? Fuck, why didn't I think about this before?

By the time we have only two left, I want to scream at Lucas to go faster. In my mind, he is moving in slow motion, though I know that's not true.

The ninth paper reads an L. Only one left.

I tighten my grip on Aspen's hand. This is it. The last vote.

Lucas unfolds the tenth paper. My lungs burn, and I realize I've been holding my breath.

L, it's an L.

Air fills my lungs, and I feel like I'm taking my first breath after being underwater for hours. A weight is lifted off my chest, and I lean back in my chair with a huff.

We did it. Aspen is safe.

ASPEN

I can't believe this. It's all over. It's really over.

I killed Nash. I made sure to tell everybody who could hear that I wasn't sorry and would do it again. But they're going to let me live. I was ready to die, or so I told myself, and now I've been granted my life back.

"Aspen." Quinton takes me by the arms, staring into my face, almost laughing in relief. I barely hear him. Everything around me is strangely muted yet somehow more intense at the same time. The light is brighter, the air colder. Yet my skin feels warm despite that. People move around me talking. Their mouths move, but all I hear is muffled sound like I'm listening through a door. Above it all, there's the pounding of my heart.

"I think I might be in shock." I manage to gasp. Quinton sits me down, taking my hands in his and rubbing them briskly.

"You're safe now. It's all over." Yes, he can say that all he wants. I know it's true. I don't believe it. Now I know how many surprises I can take over the course of a single day. I'm not sure I could handle one more.

"Aspen. Are you all right?" Xander appears, handing me a glass of water. "I suppose anyone could be excused for feeling overwhelmed at a time like this."

"Thank you." Above everything else, it feels most critical to thank him. If he hadn't been willing to play ball with the founders, particularly Nate's father, the outcome could have been very different.

“We do what needs doing for one of our own.” One of his own. It’s like I fell asleep and woke up on another planet. In what world does Xander Rossi refer to me as one of his own? When I think about where we came from compared to where we are now, it’s almost too much to believe.

But Quinton’s hands are still holding mine, and I feel the wedding band pressing against my skin. That’s real. Our love is real. And if that’s possible, anything is.

After a minute or two, I feel more like myself. Everything is back in focus, and my heart no longer feels like a bird frantically flapping its wings in hopes of escaping. I look across the room and find a familiar pair of eyes staring at me. Is it true? Would he have said it if it wasn’t?

I stand, and Quinton wraps an arm around my waist like he wants to lead me away. First, I need to know. Lucas must be reading my mind because he steps up and clears his throat. “Can I have a minute with you?” he asks.

I exchange a look with Quinton and nod. “Go ahead. I’ll catch up to you.” I feel his indecision, how much he wants to stay with me, but there are certain things a person can’t be protected from. Like the truth, for starters. Some things I have to face on my own.

Finally, we’re alone. I sit down again because I don’t know if I’ll be able to handle this standing. “I hope you don’t hate me for blurting that out in front of everyone,” he begins.

“I don’t. You probably saved my life.”

“Not entirely. You did a lot of that on your own.”

“So it’s really true?” I search his face, looking for signs of myself in it. His eyes, his nose, the curve of his jaw, even his ears. Sometimes when the light hits him just right, I think I see it. Touches of the face I see in the mirror every day.

“I want you to know that I had no idea there was even a child.” He paces, reminding me of a caged tiger. “Not until we watched that video together. I can’t tell you how shocked I was. Because I did see a woman named Charlotte, and the time we were together lines up with roughly the time you were born. Last I heard, she passed away a few years ago, I’m sorry to say.”

He rubs his hands together, and it strikes me as almost touching. He's as nervous and unsure as I am. "It was enough to make me want to look deeper into the situation. I had your DNA tested against mine." I won't bother asking how he managed to get a sample of my DNA. I'm sure he has plenty of options at his disposal. "The results came in earlier today and confirmed our connection."

My chest aches. "Earlier today? Before the...?"

He must hear what's underneath my words because he finally stops pacing and faces me head-on. "Yes. Before the wedding. I had the honor of walking my daughter down the aisle and giving her away."

At some point, maybe tomorrow or maybe weeks from now, the true weight of this will settle over me, and I'll spend a solid day crying my eyes out. I didn't know until now, right at this very minute, that what I secretly wished in my heart as I walked down the aisle toward the man who would soon be my husband was for my father to be the one walking with me. As it turns out, he was all along.

He draws a deep breath. "I'm sure you have plenty of questions."

"Only about a million. The one that stands out is why was my birth mother so afraid of you? I don't understand."

"Honestly, sometimes I feel like I used to be a different person back then. I was young and hurt, and so fucking lost. I was reckless and didn't care about anything. I'm sorry, Aspen. It's probably not what you want to hear, but I'm glad you didn't meet me then."

"I'm glad I met you now," I say honestly. Even if he wasn't blood-related to me, Lucas has become more to me than just a mentor.

"I'll tell you everything you want to know. We have all the time in the world now that you're safe." Something close to a smile plays over his lips. "For now, you don't want to keep your in-laws waiting too long. Xander's patience is not legendarily generous."

It feels wrong, leaving it here, but he's right. We have plenty of time now. "Thank you for speaking up when you did."

“It was only what was right.” I follow him out of the room and find Quinton waiting for me out in the hall. He practically jumps on me as soon as I emerge.

“You okay?” He searches my face as if looking for any signs of trouble.

“I’m just fine.” I’m alive. I’m safe. I’m married to the man I love. And now I have a father again. I also have in-laws, like Lucas said. Scarlet is my sister. I have a sister. My mind can’t grasp it all.

He pulls me in for a hug, which is the best thing he could’ve done. I need his touch now to calm me. “What do you think? Are you ready to move one last time?”

“You don’t think the idea of a long-distance relationship is sort of hot?”

“Considering we’re only on different levels of the same structure, I don’t know that it qualifies as a long-distance relationship, but...” He grins. “Phone sex is kind of fun. Although, compared to the real thing, it’s hardly my first choice.”

“Yes, I’m very much ready to move one last time.”

“Good,” he says with a wink. “Because I’ve already had your things moved to my room. We’re all set.”

I can’t pretend to be surprised. “Is that how our marriage is going to be? You bossing me around?” I tease.

“You know what you signed up for.” Quinton smiles... a genuine smile. One that reaches his eyes and isn’t overshadowed by dread and grief. I don’t remember the last time I saw him like this, but I hope I’ll see it every day from now on.

QUINTON

*I*t's amazing. The change in everyone over the past week.

I almost don't know what to do with myself. How did I function before I had Aspen's welfare to worry about? Only now that she's safe do I see just how much of my energy and thought went into her. Where she was, what she was doing, whether anyone was bothering her or threatening her. To say nothing of the hours I spent wanting her. Craving her.

Now I have her, always. The past week has been as close as I can imagine paradise. No matter where I am during my day, I know I'll be returning to her. When we leave class together or finish eating, we're going to the same place. She's even started coming to the gym with me rather than me going alone since all we want to do is be together. And the joint post-gym shower is a nice reward for a hard workout, too.

We're leaving class hand in hand for all the world to see. That's another refreshing change, not having to hide our being together. That was just as torturous as any other aspect of our past. Having to hide what I felt. Having her so close, close enough to touch, and always holding myself back for her sake as well as mine. There's no need for that now. I almost have to reacquaint myself with every detail of my daily existence.

Not that I'm complaining. Not that it doesn't make me happier than I have any right to be.

"You can stop doing that," Aspen murmurs as we walk down the hall.

“Stop doing what?” I look down at our hands, thinking she’s referring to that.

“You can stop glaring at everybody like you’re waiting for someone to come up with a smart-ass remark.” She snickers at my widening eyes. “What? You can’t tell me you don’t know you’re doing it?”

“I have no idea what you’re talking about.”

She juts her chin forward, drawing her brows together. “This is you,” she grunts.

“I don’t look like that.”

“Pass a mirror sometime.” Her grip on my hand tightens as she giggles. “You don’t have to keep looking out for me now.”

“Call it a matter of habit.”

“And I love you for that. Eventually, you’ll get more comfortable with the idea of everybody treating me better.” As if on cue, we pass a cluster of students who go out of their way to smile at us.

“Have you got used to it?”

“That’s another story.” When I raise an eyebrow, she shrugs. “I’m trying. I keep waiting for the other shoe to drop, that’s all.”

“Aspen, you’re my wife and Lucas’s daughter. Everybody knows. And if anyone so much as glances at you the wrong way, they’ll have their asses handed to them two times over.” I can’t help but chuckle. “Actually, I’m sure they would be afraid of you, too.” News of what she did to Nash spread like wildfire. I would laugh at the stupidity of anyone believing my Aspen would do the same to them, but it might not be such a bad thing for our schoolmates to have a healthy sense of concern. If it keeps them behaving themselves.

She shoots me a look of surprise when, on reaching the apartment, I grab my coat. “Where are you going?”

“Get your coat. There’s something I want to show you.” I’ve fought with myself over whether to share this with her and when. It isn’t exactly as if

I'm keeping secrets, but something tells me she would like to know.

"What is it?"

"Call it a wedding gift."

"We were married a week ago."

"Is there a statute of limitations on wedding gifts?"

"Fair enough." She's wearing a playful smile as she grabs her coat, eyes gleaming with anticipation. She has no idea what she's in for. I only hope she understands why it took me this long to tell her the truth.

Her eyes are wide as I lead her out to the helicopter pad and give the pilot his instructions. It's hardly the first time he's made this flight, after all. But it's a first for her. "What's my present? A lot of snow? Maybe some wind?"

"Keep it up with that smart mouth, and I'll show you what else you can do with it later." The thought stirs me below the belt, and the wicked gleam in her eye tells me she wouldn't see it as punishment. The half-hour flight passes pleasantly, with Aspen admiring the sparkling snow beneath us.

When we reach the hangar, there's no more playfulness. "Are we flying somewhere else?" she asks, then eyes the old plane warily. I laugh to myself, knowing what her assessment of the rusted piece of junk must be.

"Not today." Bruno and Rick have made themselves scarce, as I asked them to when I texted on the way here. I don't want anyone interrupting this. I don't want anyone sharing this with us either. This is for Aspen and me. Nobody else.

She eyes the empty office where Bruno and Rick must have been interrupted in the middle of a game of cards. A pistol lies in the center of the table. Are they betting their weapons now? Whatever it takes to pass the time, I suppose.

Aspen is growing more wary by the minute. Her body language is tense, and when I reach for her hand, it's cold and clammy.

"You don't have to worry." I try to assure her, but she is clearly not fond of this whole situation.

We stop in front of one of the two iron doors, and I turn to her. “You might be surprised by what you find behind this door,” I explain. “I want you to know you have nothing to be afraid of. No one can hurt you.”

“Quinton, what is this about?” Her question is laced with fear, and it kills me to see her like this.

“Everything is going to make sense in a moment. I only wanted to make sure it didn’t come as too much of a shock. I’ve waited weeks to give this to you.” I jerk my chin in the direction of the second door. “In both of these rooms are guests. At least one of them was involved with your attack.”

She sucks in a sharp breath but says nothing.

“You deserve to face him, but if you don’t think you can handle it, that’s okay. I want you to have a choice in this. If you would rather go back, we can do that right now. Or you can meet them and decide their fate. That’s what this is really all about. You get to decide.”

Her eyes go perfectly round. “Who is it?” she murmurs. “I thought everybody was dead.”

“Not quite yet,” I explain. “There are some things worse than death. Take a person’s freedom away, for instance. Make them live in fear, so they never know what’s coming next. Remove all contact with the outside world so they can’t rely on anyone. No protection. Not even the possibility of help.”

I can’t help but smile. “And every once in a while, have them roughed up a little. Sometimes for no reason at all. Keep them guessing. Whittle away their sense of self-determination. It can be a lot more satisfying than simply putting somebody’s lights out.”

She nods like she understands. I take that as a good sign.

“Are you ready? Remember this is all your choice. We can turn around and leave anytime. I’m right here with you.”

Another nod. “Yes. I’m ready.”

I punch in the code and open the door, setting eyes upon my captive. He is completely naked, his hair is grown out, and his body is beaten, and so thin

his bones are visible. His face has changed the most. Without any teeth, his lips are sunk in, in an odd way. His eyes are almost swollen shut, and his forehead is caked with blood and something that looks like cum.

I've told Rick and Bruno to do the most fucked-up things they can think of and looking at Matteo's face and the large blood-covered dildo on the floor, I think they've delivered more than I could've hoped for.

To no surprise, it seems the fight has left him—he sits in the corner of his bare room, knees drawn up to his chest, arms wrapped around them. I've never seen a man look as whipped. His eyes are blank, staring straight ahead into nothing.

He barely resembles the person he used to be, but Aspen recognizes him. "Oh, my god." She falls back half a step, and I place what I hope is a comforting hand on her waist. Her breathing quickens. "He's still alive?"

"I wanted to save him for you." Right now, she is my only concern. "Are you all right?"

Her head bobs up and down after a moment's hesitation. "Fine." It's the way she says it, the flatness in her voice, the coldness as she scans the room. There's not much to look at. It's pretty empty besides a bloody dildo lying in one corner. I turn to Matteo, who's less than a shadow of his former self. I'm thrilled to see it. He barely stirs. Staring at the wall, he licks his cracked, parched lips.

"Did you get fucked in the ass, Matteo? How was it? Judging by all the blood, not pleasant. We should have taken a video to keep... but really no one wants to see that."

Matteo still doesn't react, almost like he has gone somewhere in his mind, drowning the misery around him out.

"You have visitors, fuckhead." I go to him, take him by his greasy hair, and jerk his head back so I can look him in the eye. "You haven't greeted my wife. I take that as an offense." I release his hair and give his head a shove.

He blinks rapidly before glancing at Aspen, who hasn't moved.

“That’s okay.” Aspen takes her first steps into the room, moving slowly. There’s something about her I can’t put my finger on. I know her so well, I can normally sense her mood and know what she’s thinking. Not today. Today she is unpredictable. Was it the right move, bringing her here?

She comes to a stop at my side, standing over Matteo. “He doesn’t need to speak to me. I would rather he didn’t. He said plenty the last time we were together. I was hoping I would never have to hear his voice again.”

“We can go.”

“No.” Her eyes meet mine for an instant before returning to him. Her fists are clenched. She’s shaking. “No, I needed this. One final link, one more reminder of what we lost and what I survived.”

She kicks Matteo’s leg. “Did you hear me, you piece of shit? You raping, murdering piece of shit? You killed my baby that night. You almost killed me. Have you had plenty of time to think about that in this cell? In the middle of nowhere? Or do you even possess the self-reflection to look back on the things you’ve done?”

He only groans, turning his face toward the wall. His spirits have truly been broken. When I think back on what an arrogant, self-assured person he used to be, it’s almost exhilarating.

“What do you want to do with him?” I ask, turning to my wife. “He can stay here the rest of his life, however long that might be. I have men guarding him and dealing with him whenever he becomes rowdy.”

I throw him a withering look, and he closes his eyes. “Though between you and me, he’s lost a lot of his fight. It takes a while for him to learn his lessons, but he does eventually learn them.”

“I could leave him here and know every day he’s suffering?”

“As far as I’m concerned, you can ask for daily reports. I have no doubt the men would be glad to provide them.”

She appears to be thinking it over. What would be the worst punishment? Death, or living the rest of his life this way? He’s a young man. He could spend decades here.

When she turns and leaves the room, I'm almost sure it's because she can no longer handle the situation. My heart sinks. I shouldn't have subjected her to this.

I'm about to express my sarcastic condolences to Matteo since now it seems he has a long life of relentless torture ahead of him. Before I can, Aspen marches back into the room, and this time she's holding one of the guns left in the office.

She raises her arm, brandishing the pistol. "Look at me," she grits out, teeth clenched. "I said look at me, you cowardly bastard."

"I would do as she says," I murmur, backing away from him, one eye always on Aspen.

Matteo raises his head, meeting her gaze. She's breathing hard, eyes bright. "Did you have fun that night? Was it a good time? Was it worth this?"

"No. It wasn't," Matteo rasps out.

"But you did it. And you've deserved everything they've done to you. You deserve to know your family is all dead because of what you did. You destroyed all of them."

His chin quivers, but he says nothing.

"I should let you live in filth, all alone." A tear rolls down her cheek, but she ignores it in favor of glaring at Matteo. "While I live an incredible life. Happy. Loved. I'm going to live a long life surrounded by family and in love with my husband. While all you'll have to look forward to is forgetting all the things you used to love since remembering them only hurts. I should do that to you."

She draws a deep breath. "Instead, I'm going to be merciful."

Something like a grin begins to spread over those peeling lips, and it almost seems his pasty skin regains some of its color. "Do it," he begs in a soft voice. "Please, finally, do it."

"Stand up," Aspen orders. "Stand up so I can end your life face-to-face." I'm not sure what she is doing, but I'm not about to interfere with her

wishes.

It takes Matteo a moment to gather enough strength to stand. Bruises, cuts, and welts cover most of his body. His legs shake as he pushes himself to his feet. Pointing the gun at him, Aspen waits patiently, not bothered by Matteo's slow movement.

When he finally stands in front of Aspen, a smile spreads across her face. "This is for what you did to me that night." She lowers the gun, pointing it toward his crotch, and fires the first shot. Everything happens so fast that I don't realize what she is doing until the bullet hits Matteo's dick.

He falls to his knees with a blood-curdling scream, his hands covering what's left of his balls. Blood pours from between his fingers, forming a puddle around his legs.

"And this is for my child." Another shot cracks through the air an instant before Matteo's head snaps back, hitting the wall behind him, where blood and brains have splashed.

The room goes eerily silent for a moment as we both watch the life drain from Matteo's body.

I go to her, taking the pistol from her hands and throwing it on the ground before wrapping her in my arms. "He's finished. You took care of him." I couldn't be prouder of how far she's come.

"I don't even feel bad about it."

"You have no reason to. You've taken control of your life." I'm gentle as I ease her away from me, taking her by the chin and tipping her head back to look her in the eye. "You did well."

"Did you say there's someone else here, too?"

"Yes. Wait here." Now, I'm almost giddy with anticipation. Nothing in the world could keep me from going to Delilah's cell and unlocking the door. Rather than attempt to attack me this time, she's sitting at the foot of her cot, trembling. It's clear she heard the shots despite the thick walls.

“Come on. There’s something I want to show you.” I take her by the arm and drag her from the cell before dumping her on the floor at Aspen’s feet.

“Look at him.” When Delilah refuses to lift her head, I take her by the hair and pull her head back, crouching beside her. “I said look. Look at what’s been done to him. This could be you. And it will be.”

“Who is this?” Aspen asks.

“This is Delilah Wallace. Delilah has ties to Matteo and Nash, but she refuses to say exactly how they’re connected. *Were* connected, I should say. When speaking of Matteo, one needs to use past tense from now on.” I’m almost enjoying this too much.

“What do you think, Delilah?” I ask. “Does this convince you I mean business? This isn’t a game. Who was he to you? What did you have to do with his family?”

“He was my brother.” She lifts her eyes, but there doesn’t seem to be much feeling in them. “Satisfied?”

“Your brother is dead now.”

“No kidding. I thought that was paint on the wall behind him.” I snarl and shove her away, standing. “You have more spirit than he did, that’s for sure. So you’re a Valentine?”

“I’m a Wallace. I might have shared blood with Matteo, but I was never allowed his name.”

“And it means nothing to you, seeing him like this?”

“He played with fire. When you play with fire, do you cry when you get burned?”

“Most people would puke their guts out seeing someone like this, not to mention a family member. You know what your reaction tells me? That you are not innocent. You are more of a Valentine than you claim.”

She turns her head away, but I don’t miss the defiance in her eyes nor the angry way her teeth grind together.

I look at Aspen, whose troubled expression tells me she's struggling to make sense of this. "Delilah's number was in Nash's phone. He called her quite a bit after your attack."

Delilah's head snaps up so she can stare at Aspen. "I had nothing to do with that. I'm not an animal." Her head swings around, and she looks at me. "Is that what this is about?"

I crouch down again, which is not precisely a pleasant experience considering it's been a while since my guest has been afforded the luxury of bathing. "You mean to tell me you knew nothing about it? Matteo's own sister?"

"We shared blood, but that's about it."

"Were you close with Nash?"

"Not very. I heard about what they did to you." She looks up at Aspen. "I was disgusted, and I told him so."

"Nash is dead now," I deadpan.

Rather than flinch, she snorts. "So he got burned, too. They took it too far."

I don't know whether to believe her. It seems if she had knowledge of the attack and was close with either of the bastards, she would have a stronger reaction. Yet there hasn't been so much as a catch in her voice to betray a deeper feeling.

"Shall I do the honors?" I brandish the pistol, and now Delilah begins to tremble again.

"I told you. I didn't know anything about it."

"You're a part of the family. And they're dead now. I don't like leaving loose ends."

"A family that wouldn't let me share their name. They kept me a secret because I was a girl. Do you think I give a shit whether they're alive or dead?" She spits on the floor. "I couldn't care less. And I don't deserve to die for what they did."

Aspen meets my gaze. Does she believe her? “I’m tired of death,” she announces. “She wasn’t there that night. That’s good enough for me. And if she was guilty of anything...” She shivers, looking around. “I think she’s paid her price.”

I drop to a crouch so suddenly it makes Delilah gasp. “Do you hear that? My wife is granting you mercy. If it were up to me, your brains would join his on that wall.” I point at the grotesque splatter as a reminder. “But Aspen is compassionate enough to let you live. She’s endured far worse than you have since you got here, and she wants to let you go. Every morning you open your eyes, I want you to remember that, and I want you to be grateful to her. Do you hear me?”

“Yes,” Delilah whispers, then looks up at Aspen. “Thank you.”

I pull out my phone and send a message to Rick. “They’re going to take you home,” I announce. “And if you say a fucking word about this, so help me God, you won’t live to see tomorrow. I’ll be watching you. Got it?”

“Understood.” A single sob bursts out of her as she fights her way to her feet. By the time we leave the cell, Rick and Bruno emerge from wherever they tucked themselves before we arrived. I exchange a nod with Rick before taking Aspen’s arm and leading her toward the waiting helicopter outside.

“I don’t know how you do it,” I admit once we’re in the air with the hangar getting smaller behind us.

“Do what?”

“How you can be merciful.”

“Delilah did nothing to me. Just like I did nothing to the men who chose to attack me. I can still choose to show mercy the way I wish they would have shown me.”

I find her hand and lace my fingers through hers, thanking whatever entity that happens to be watching over us for her presence in my life. I don’t know what I did to deserve her, but I plan to spend every breath from now until my last earning her love.

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EPILOGUE

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ASPEN

Two months later

“*I*’m still nervous.”

Quinton’s hand closes over my knee, and I realize it’s been bouncing up and down ever since we sat down in the limo Xander sent to the private airstrip to greet us on arrival. “You’re going to be fine. Everything will be great.”

“But we’re going to be there for an entire week.”

“Yes. Spring break lasts a week. Only seven days.”

“You’re deliberately misunderstanding me.”

He squeezes my knee before leaning over to kiss the corner of my mouth. “No. I’m not misunderstanding you at all. What I’m trying to do is calm you down. There’s no reason to be worried about how this will go. Everybody loves you.”

That much, I’m beginning to believe. Not that Ella and Scarlet have ever been anything less than kind and sweet but accepting me as a true member of the family is another story. Loving me from afar and maintaining that feeling while hanging out for a week are two different things.

And Xander? I still have to pinch myself whenever we have a warm exchange during one of his video calls with Quinton. It's become easier to feel natural while chatting, but being in person is another story.

"Scarlet's dying to go shopping with you." Quinton offers an easy smile that warms me from the inside out. I love seeing him like this, so easy and relaxed. The thought of me getting along well with his family makes him happy, which of course, makes me happy. It's enough to make me want to try as hard as I can to be the wife he needs. A wife who fits in with the people who mean so much to him.

"I'm going to have to get used to that, too," I admit.

"To what?"

"Being able to go shopping and get whatever I want."

"You've been able to do that for months. Anything you want to order."

"I know, but actually going to the store and being able to touch things and decide if I like them first? I haven't been able to do that in so long." And never with the unlimited budget, Quinton assures me I have at my disposal. I want to pinch myself over that, too. I'd better be careful, or I'm going to end up bruised all over.

"Does it make you happy?"

"Being able to go shopping with your mom and your sister? Sure. I'm looking forward to it."

"That's all that matters. Relax and enjoy yourself. That's all anybody wants you to do." He kisses me again, harder this time. "Be yourself. Everybody already loves you."

I don't even realize my smile falls until Quinton frowns while looking at my lips. "What did I say to make this happen?" He reaches for my face and lets his index finger brush over the corners of my mouth.

"You said everyone loves you..." By everyone, he means everyone from his family. "I still haven't heard from my mom."

"Can I ask you something? You don't have to tell me if you don't want to."

“Of course, I’ll tell you.” I can’t imagine anything I would want to keep from Quinton.

“Why have you not asked Brittney to find your mother?”

I suck in a ragged breath, looking out the window instead of at Quinton’s face. Of course, I have thought about that as well. Brittney could probably track her down in no time if I asked her to.

“Honestly... I don’t think she wants me to find her. I think she didn’t want to be my mother anymore. Maybe she never really did. When I look at your mom, I can see her love for you in her eyes. I can see how much she cares for you and Scarlet. It’s there in everything she does, every gesture, every word. My mom never looked at me that way. She never cared for me like that, and I never even realized it until now.”

“I’m sorry, Aspen.”

I shake my head. “There is nothing to be sorry about. I didn’t know any better growing up. I didn’t feel unloved back then, but now, I just don’t want to search for someone who doesn’t want to be found.”

“Makes sense.” Quinton smiles, showing off his straight white teeth just when the limo stops. “I’m glad you know you are loved now.”

If I needed any proof of that, Scarlet delivers it by launching herself at me the moment Quinton opens my door. “Finally! You’re here!”

“I’m here, too,” Quinton reminds her, wearing a wry smile.

“Sure, sure. You’re old news.” But she gives him a playful nudge. “I guess it’s nice to see you since, without you, we wouldn’t have Aspen.” She puts an arm around my waist and leads me inside. “Let’s find Mom. Are you hungry? We were thinking about going to lunch before heading out to shop.”

She’s like a whirlwind. “Yeah, that would be great. I’m up for whatever you want to do.”

“Here they are. The newlyweds.” Ella hugs Quinton before turning the light of her smile on me. I wouldn’t be so bold as to call her mom unless she

wanted me to, but she's definitely starting to feel like a true mother to me. It's almost like getting a second chance at a family.

"Quinton, you stay close by," she warns him before we leave for the afternoon. "We have dinner reservations this evening, so I'll need you ready."

"I thought we were having dinner at home tonight."

"No, we thought it would be nice to go out since a reservation was available this evening." She kisses his cheek before taking me by the hand. "Come on. We have a lot to do."

All I can do is throw Quinton a helpless look before I'm whisked away again. Good thing I'm not expected to unload my own bags from the car, I guess.



"YOU LOOK LOVELY." Xander takes both of my hands, wearing a warm smile upon meeting me at the top of the stairs. "I'm sorry I wasn't able to greet you properly when you first arrived, but it seems the women of the family had other ideas. No sooner had I received word of your arrival than you were gone."

"It was a wonderful afternoon. Thank you so much for having us stay here over break." The word wonderful doesn't begin to describe it. It was a regular girls' day, complete with manicures, pedicures, and blowouts. The restaurant where we're having dinner must be a fancy spot if we have to get this dressed up for it.

Quinton's standing at the foot of the stairs, where Scarlet ordered him to wait for me. "You'll get to watch her float down the stairs to you," she insisted before throwing him out of her room so we could get ready together. I'm almost as giddy as a girl on her way to the prom as I descend, watching my husband's face along the way.

It was definitely worth the effort to watch his mouth fall open the closer I get. The clingy silver dress Scarlet and Ella insisted I buy hugs me but is

still modest enough for a family dinner. I feel like I'm wearing pure silver. The slightest move, and I shimmer. My lotus necklace is nestled on my chest, and a pair of diamond earrings sparkle on my ears. I feel like a princess.

And there's my prince, gazing up at me. "You're breathtaking. I've never seen anything so beautiful."

"Thank you." I offer a shy smile. "You look really nice, too. So handsome." It doesn't feel like enough, but it's not easy to come up with words to describe what he does to me. The fire he sets off in my heart, along with other places. We can talk about that later.

I adjust his tie before patting his firm chest. "Are we ready to go?"

"I think so. Mom and Scarlet were waiting outside before Dad joined them." Yet when we go out there, they're nowhere to be found. A black car waits for us, but it's empty, the driver standing beside it.

"What's this all about?" Quinton looks down the driveway, and a pair of taillights dwindles to pinpoints in the distance.

"Mr. Rossi asked me to follow with the two of you." The driver opens the door, and a bottle of champagne and two glasses waits inside.

Quinton grins. "I bet Scarlet has something to do with this. She keeps making all those newlywed comments. Like everybody expects us to be pawing at each other all the time and unable to share a car with them." He extends a hand to help me inside. "We might as well take advantage of it."

"No offense, but you're not messing up my hair or makeup until after dinner." I spent too long getting them done, and I feel too beautiful to have them ruined. At least not before everybody sees me with the family.

We enjoy our champagne on the twenty-minute drive from the house to the restaurant. Quinton's parents and sister are walking into the restaurant by the time we enter the parking lot. It looks like an elegant place. I have to remind myself I belong here, with these people, in this world. I'm Aspen Rossi.

So why are my knees a little shaky when I step out of the car? Somehow, deep inside, I still expect the looks. The resentment. A girl doesn't go through what I did without carrying at least a little baggage. Every day I spend being loved by Quinton lessens the burden, but it hasn't completely left me.

"You ready?" He takes my hand, gripping tight. "It's going to be great."

Yes. It will be just great. We walk into the building together, hand in hand, and I'm ready to face anything.

"Surprise!"

The two of us stop dead in our tracks, and I'm left gasping for air at the sight of so many smiling faces directed our way. I've never been here before, but something tells me it isn't generally decorated like this, with lavish floral centerpieces and elaborate table settings. I don't think there's normally a table piled high with wrapped gifts, either.

"What is this?" I manage to gasp before recognizing one person I never expected to see during break. "Lucas?"

He steps forward, reaching out. He hugs me while I struggle to understand what's going on. "What is all this?" I look at Quinton, but he's as confused as me while Scarlet playfully teases him about how shocked he looks.

Lucas pulls back, smiling down at me. When I think of where we started compared to where we are now. "This is your wedding reception. Since we didn't get a chance to throw you one at the time, we thought this would be the next best thing. My family is here, and everyone has looked forward to celebrating you and your new marriage."

His smile widens. "And welcoming you into the family. You're one of us, a Diavolo, just as much as you're now a Rossi. Tonight only makes it official. I hope you're ready to get to know a lot of people because they're all dying to get to know you."

There goes my makeup. "See, it was a good thing I recommended waterproof mascara." Scarlet hands me a tissue, and I can't help but laugh. It's all so funny and so overwhelming and so touching at the same time. My eyes scan the room, taking in the array of people here to celebrate us.

“Aspen, let me formally introduce you to my brother, Nic, and his wife, Celia.” Lucas gestures toward the table, where a man who looks eerily similar to Lucas sits. His dark eyes scan me from head to toe. He’s got his hair slicked back, and his sleeves rolled up, showing off the intricate tattoos on his forearms. Nic’s features are almost cold, but when he smiles, the unsettling feeling in my gut diminishes. Beside him sits his wife, her silky brown hair falling down her back in gentle waves. Her features are striking, her heart-shaped face one you can’t look away from. She smiles, and her eyes brighten with joy.

“It’s so nice to meet you. I’m so excited to have another woman in the family.”

Family... I almost can’t believe it. Every day I wait for the moment when I find out this was all a dream.

“I’m happy to be a part of it and can’t wait to make memories together.”

“Oh, sweetheart, you’ll have lots of time to make memories, and believe me, memories will be made. You’re married to a Rossi, after all.” Another beautiful woman I have yet to meet chimes in, a glass of champagne in her hands.

“Aunt Keira, what’s that supposed to mean?” Quinton teases.

“Yeah, what’s that supposed to mean?” Damon, Xander’s brother, interjects. I’ve heard his name in conversation often and seen him a time or two. His dark eyes are as menacing as Xander’s, but where Xander has an edge about him, Damon seems chill.

“Aspen, this is Keira and Damon. My aunt and uncle. They can be a little odd sometimes,” Quinton adds, smirking.

Damon flips him the bird, and my grin widens.

“Can we get through one dinner without someone flipping someone else off?” Ella scolds Damon from across the table, her motherly voice making me giggle.

“Sorry, but it’s his fault,” Damon exclaims, and Quinton, of course, rolls his eyes.

“Never a dull moment,” the person beside Damon adds, and my gaze moves to him.

Even knowing all these men are older, they don’t seem to appear of the age they should be, each appearing younger than the next.

“That’s Roman and Sophie, Ren’s parents,” Quinton explains. “You met them at the founders’ ball.”

Yes, a night I would rather forget. “It’s nice to officially meet you.”

The apples of Sophie’s cheeks grow flush, and she beams at me from her seat. “We’re so happy to see you again, the elusive girl who won over Quinton’s heart.” She bats her eyes, and Roman lets out a gruff laugh.

The man is built like a brick house, his arms huge. In fact, his entire body is huge, and I imagine I’d find myself trying to hide behind Quinton if he was standing.

But there’s something about him, something that says as dangerous as I know he probably is, he’s also kind.

“It’s very nice to meet all of you, and thank you for doing this for us.” I’m so happy I could cry, *again*.

“There’s one more thing,” Lucas says. “It was always your dream to become a doctor, and I want to make sure you know that’s still possible. I asked Dr. Lauren if she would mentor you and get you set up for medical school if that’s something you still want to do?”

“I...” I stumble over my words. “Of course. I’d love that. It’s always been a dream of mine, and I can’t believe it’s even an option now.”

Lucas smiles, but I can tell something is lingering beneath the surface. “Nothing is out of reach for you, Aspen, and if I’m being honest, I don’t think it ever was.”



AFTER HOURS OF EATING, drinking, and being pulled from one conversation to another, I need a breath of air. There's a terrace beyond the ladies' room, and it happens to be empty when I come out after freshening my makeup. I decide now is my chance and duck out before anyone sees me.

The night air is soft and gentle. I pull in as much as I can, filling my lungs. This is my life, right at this moment. I want to soak in every bit and not forget a single thing.

Especially once a pair of arms snake around me from behind. "Caught you ducking out on our guests."

"I'm not ducking out on anybody. I need a second to breathe."

"Why do you think I'm out here?" He chuckles against my neck and makes goose bumps race over my arms. "It's amazing. I truly had no idea."

"No wonder it was so important to go out today and to be on time tonight."

"I should know better than to take those two at face value." He leans over my shoulder, and I turn my face toward him. "Are you happy?"

"Do you even need to ask? I've never been so happy in all my life. Tonight is perfect." I look back into the restaurant, where soft music has begun to play. "I have not one but two families eager to welcome me into the fold. I have more gifts than I know what to do with—seriously, what are we going to do with all that?"

"I was going to ask you."

"I guess we can store most of it until we're out of school and setting up our own house."

His brows draw together. "I meant to talk to you about that. A home. Dad and I had a discussion earlier today while you were out. He got it into his head that we'd like him to build us a house on their land, so we could be close by. Not attached to their house. We'd have privacy. But we'd all be together."

He searches my face. "What do you think about that?"

I don't have to think about it. "When can we get started?" And it was the right thing to say since Quinton's face practically glows. Like I would turn down such a generous gift, especially when I know it would make him happy to be near the rest of his family. As for the rest of my family, we've already received three offers to pay visits over summer break. We're going to be busy.

It's almost too good to be true, all of it. I didn't dream it would ever happen to me. Being loved. Cherished. Protected and valued.

I close my eyes when Quinton leans in for what promises to be a smoldering kiss.

Until someone makes a big deal of it by coughing loudly. "Um, you two? I hate to break it to you, but it's pretty noticeable when the bride and groom disappear at the same time." Scarlet's barely able to keep herself from laughing as she waits for us in the doorway leading inside.

Quinton rolls his eyes at her. "Let them wait." Then he turns back to me and winks. "We might as well make it worthwhile." I don't have time to laugh before his arms tighten and his lips find mine.

Considering everything Quinton Rossi has given me, a little smudged lipstick seems a small price to pay.



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ABOUT THE AUTHORS

J.L. Beck and **C. Hallman** are a *USA Today* and international bestselling author duo who write contemporary and dark romance.

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USA TODAY AND INTERNATIONAL
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